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KERALA SOUND ELECTRICALS:
AMPLIFIED SOUND AND CULTURAL MEANING IN SOUTH INDIA

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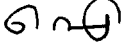
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NOTE ON TRANSLITERATION AND PRONUNCIATION

Malayāḷam contains the sounds of both Tamil and Sanskrit. With the exception of placenames or personal names which have established English orthographies, like Thrissur (*Tr̥ṣṣūr*) or Irinjalakuda (*Iriññāḷakkuṭa*), I have followed the standard system detailed below for transcribing Malayāḷam words. Note that consonants may have different sounds depending on their position; for example, *p* at the beginning of a word, as in *pañcavādyam*, sounds like the English 'punch', but in combination with the nasal *m*, as in *kompū* or *ampū*, is soft like the English 'b', so that these are pronounced 'kombu' and 'ambu' (the *ū* at the end of these words is a very short, stopped 'u'). The retroflex *ṭ* similarly sounds like the English 'd', so that *ceṇṭa* is pronounced as 'chenda' (*c* is a soft or unaspirated 'ch'), *Vaṭakkunnāthan* as 'Vadakku-nah-ton', *taṛavāṭū* as 'taravahd' (the *ū* is almost dropped), or *Nampūtiri* (with its short *a*, long *ū*, and short *i* sounds) as 'num-boo-diri'. The Dravidian sound 'zh' is often transliterated from Tamil as *ḷ*; it actually sounds much like the American English 'r' as in 'arrange', so 'Īzhava', with its long *ī* and short *a* sounds, is pronounced as 'ear-uh-va'. The sibilants *ṣ* and *ś* are both pronounced roughly as 'sh'.

Vowels [svaraṇṇaḷ]:

					
a	ā	i	ī	u	ū
					
e	ē	ai	o	ō	au

Consonants [vyañjanaññaḥ]:

ക	ഖ	ഗ	ഘ	ങ
k	kh	g	gh	ṅ ['ng']

ച	ഛ	ജ	ഝ	ഞ
c ['ch']	ch	j	jh	ṇ

ട	ഠ	ഡ	ഢ	ണ
ṭ	ṭh	ḍ	ḍh	ṇ

ത	ഥ	ദ	ധ	ന
t	th	d	dh	n

പ	ഫ	ബ	ഭ	മ
p	ph	b	bh	m

യ	ര	ല	വ
y	r	l	v

ശ	ഷ	സ	ഹ
ś ['sh']	ṣ ['sh']	s	h

ഝ	ഞ	ട	ഢ
ṭ	ṇ	ṭ	ṇ

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

Amplified sound plays a prominent role in Kerala's public spaces, and by extension, in its changing public culture. Just as the making and hearing of amplified sounds in public spaces relies on the physicality of the loudspeaker, so debate and discussion around such issues as the encounters between mass-mediated performance genres and traditional religious settings center on the indexical or iconic referentiality of the loudspeaker as situated in the realm of public culture. Appadurai and Breckenridge have described the notion of public culture as "an arena . . . in which the emergent cosmopolitan cultural forms of today's India shape each other" (1988:5). As this study illustrates, in Kerala, the loudspeaker is an essential component of cultural performances and in the emergence of new cultural forms, which in turn are implicated in the construction and refinement of group identities and of lived social spaces.

This dissertation examines the ways that emergent sonic practices and performance genres are employed and evaluated

within specific cultural contexts, in order to gain insight into the processes of cultural change -- and equally importantly, cultural continuity -- as they are experienced, or at the level of how people make meaning out of their environments, processes which occur in parallel with macrolevel social changes. In this way, it is appropriate to say that I am interested in amplified sound as a 'total' social fact (Mauss 1990 [1950]); cf. Schade-Poulsen 1999:5), in the sense that I analyze the sound not only as music, but as an outgrowth of technology, as indicative of economic realities, and as declarative of social relations and of cultural values.

The "zone of cultural debate" that is public culture in Kerala (Appadurai and Breckenridge 1988:6) necessarily includes the beliefs and practices of its three religions -- Hinduism, Christianity, and Islam -- just as public spaces are filled with the sounds of their observances.¹ I set out to study amplified sound in public spaces, and inevitably the sounds I encountered most were the loudspeaker-dependent daily observances and assertions of temples, churches, and mosques, and the reverberating amplified performances of religious festivals. This study interrogates the confluence of 'traditional' religious spaces and practices, with electronic audio technologies -- from the common horn speaker, to the state-of-the-art MIDI programmable multitimbral polyphonic digital synthesizer -- and the mass media-infused musical approaches they both present and represent (cf. Langer 1953). In multiple

1. Since the first century C.E., a large community of Jews lived along the coast of Central Kerala. After the formation of the State of Israel in 1948, however, almost all migrated there. At present there are at most a handful of Jews still living in Fort Cochin.

contexts, I show that this confluence is a site of contestation wherein the boundaries or overlaps between public (shared, mixed, 'modern') and ritual (pure, 'traditional') spaces are negotiated.

1. Theoretical context: Sound in society.

The question of how to understand the connections between performed sound and society, or musical structure and social structure, has been of great interest to ethnomusicologists. There have been three basic ways to address the issue, each describing a different directionality for a causal arrow pointing between music, on one side, and society, on the other. To simplify for a moment, the first of these positions is that music reflects society, the second is that music creates society, and the third, that both are true. The three studies that make up this dissertation illustrate in different ways that sonic and social realities are indeed mutually constitutive.

The first position had the arrow pointing from society to music. This view has been ascribed to scholars such as Alan Merriam and John Blacking in the 1960s, who come "from the [social] 'anthropological side' of ethnomusicology" (Turino 1993:7). This point of view, which Born and Hesmondhalgh refer to as a "homology model", holds that music reflects and articulates social relations, structures, and values (2000:31). This perspective has worked most effectively in studies of classless societies, as in Steven Feld's insightful studies of

the iconicities of sound structure and social structure in a Papua New Guinea society (1982, 1984, 1994).

The cultural rather than social anthropological heritage of this idea is reflected in Geertz's essay 'Art as a Cultural System,' where he remarks that "an artist works with signs which have a place in semiotic systems extending far beyond the craft he practices" (quoted in Blacking 1995:227). Geertz here suggests that art, or music, 'makes sense' only with respect to an agreed-upon system of signs that inheres in other domains of the culture, a view which is put succinctly in Merriam's observation that "the sounds of music are shaped by the culture of which they are a part" (1964:27). Milton Singer extends the same perspective to the phenomenon of sociocultural change in India:

Changes in cultural performances, cultural media, and cultural centers give some indications of change in the total cultural structure and so may be used to study general trends and processes of cultural change.
[1959:xiii]

The next position to emerge was that musical and other cultural performances do not reflect social structures, but help to create them; the arrow points from music to society. Thus while extensively documenting the key role of musics in political and protest movements throughout Southeast Asia, Craig Lockard recalls Brecht's observation that "art is not a mirror that reflects society but a hammer that forges it" (quoted in Lockard 1998:28). This perspective has been especially useful to ethnomusicologists concerned with the notion of a sense of social groupness or distinctiveness, for which the term most commonly used is 'identity'. For example, Martin Stokes introduces a volume of essays which "illustrate some of the ways

in which musical performance, as well as the acts of listening, dancing, arguing, discussing, thinking and writing about music, provide the means by which ethnicities and identities are constructed and mobilised" (1994:5). Born and Hesmondhalgh refer to this model in which "music has a formative role in the construction, negotiation, and transformation of sociocultural identities" as "a current orthodoxy" in the field (2000:31). Other influential studies which successfully adopt this kind of model include Waterman (1990) and Turino (1993).

As Born and Hesmondhalgh go on to point out, neither model is satisfactory in and of itself; music can either reflect existing identities or help to form new ones, depending on the situation (2000:31-32). By the same token, Victor Turner agrees with Singer (1972) that cultural performances cast light on cultural values and themes as well as processes of change, but adds that one must also be cognizant of their performative aspect:

[C]ultural performances are not simple reflectors or expressions of culture or even of changing culture but may themselves be active agencies of change, representing the eye by which culture sees itself and the drawing board on which creative actors sketch out what they believe to be more apt or interesting 'designs for living.' [Turner 1986:24]

Of course it is doubtful that either unidirectional position outlined above has ever been followed in practice to the absolute exclusion of the other; researchers have always seen that the interrelations between music and society are many-faceted and complex. Merriam, for example, observed that "[m]usic is interrelated with the rest of culture; it can and does shape, strengthen, and channel social, political, economic, linguistic, religious, and other kinds of behavior" (1964:15).

Blacking also recognized this bidirectionality, if less explicitly. While he agreed with Geertz's position, above, that artistic practices must be placed in social context, he also wants

to invert the process and say that for an ethnomusicologist a crucial analytical procedure is not so much to fit the music into a social system, but *to start with a musical system and its symbols, with styles and sound groups, and then to see how and where society fits into the music*. We should consider artistic cognition, and musical practice in particular, as having primary roles in the imagination of social realities. [1995:234, emphasis added]

The fact that musical practices are intertwined with social structures and cultural values leads to the idea that music can be studied not just as music, but as indexical of such structures and values. Sonic practices act as signs which exist in broader semiotic networks; however, these networks are not something static that is merely 'referred to', but function as a dynamic resource capable of engendering performativity and of effecting change.

Thus in this study I take a dialectic approach, wherein on the one hand, I make the claim that because sound production is implicated in the continual creation of social spaces, I can learn more about the cross-currents of global flow and intracultural flux by listening to and inquiring about amplified sound, than by trying to ask directly about such nebulous concepts.² On the other hand, and at the same time, I

2. Although his ends are different, Marc Schade-Poulsen approaches his study, *Men and popular music in Algeria: The social significance of raï*, with a similar motivation:

As I became more focused on the purpose of the study, it became clear that I was not going to undertake a traditional

acknowledge that sonic practices reflect and thus must often be understood in terms of or with some specifiable relation to cultural models already in existence.

My analysis extends the boundaries of ethnomusicology as a discipline in that its central object of study is not a specific musical or instrumental tradition, or even 'music' narrowly defined. Instead, in it I am concerned with aspects of local sound production which predominate in contemporary Kerala's soundscape and which are most salient in cultural performances; crucially, these involve the integration of electronic audio technologies such as amplification, and the larger social and global contexts in which such technologies are embedded.

Surprisingly given their ubiquity, sound amplification practices have received relatively little attention in the ethnomusicological literature in general, including that concerning South Asia. When amplification has been noted in South Indian ethnomusicological writing, it has been as an unwelcome addition to Karnatak music concerts in Chennai. L'Armand and L'Armand (1983) note that microphones were introduced into Madras concert halls in the 1930s, and quickly became ubiquitous. As Higgins remarks,

The universal adoption of the microphone in concert halls has not been altogether a blessing. The equipment frequently breaks down and even if it works properly, there is bound to be distortion of the natural tone quality of voice and instrument. [1975:24]

ethnomusicological project. Instead, I wanted to approach music as a means of answering nonmusical questions; rather than asking questions in Algeria about issues such as Islam, economics, and politics, I would ask questions about music in order to reach an understanding of those aspects of life. [1999:4]

The predominance of electronic audio technology in cultural performances outside of the concert hall, along with the pervasive influence of mass-mediated musical genres, are underrepresented in the literature. For example, in the entry under 'Kerala' in the Garland Encyclopedia of World Music (Groesbeck and Palackal 1998), the musical genres and aspects of sound production that I devote most attention to throughout this dissertation are scarcely mentioned.

This study acknowledges that amplification and other electronic technologies have become integral to many contemporary musical practices, and seeks to understand their place in Kerala cultural context. An important precursor to this study is R. Anderson Sutton's brief article, 'Interpreting electronic sound technology in the contemporary Javanese soundscape', which begins with the declaration,

The global adoption of electronic sound technology from the West is unquestionably one of the most significant developments in music in the twentieth century. The ubiquitous use of this technology has had profound effects on the ways music is presented, in the proliferation of recorded formats and in amplified live performances. New contexts for the experience of music abound, and the transformations of 'traditional' musical sound that this technology provides have certainly altered compositional processes and the very way people think about and evaluate music. [Sutton 1996: 249]

The point that Sutton goes on to make, however, is that "all is not change" (ibid.), and that preferences for particular styles of amplification in Java, both in terms of production and reception, reflect deeply rooted cultural values in which musical aesthetics and cultural psychological significance are mutually implicated.

Present Kerala society is situated very much in the midstream of the 'global flow' which now characterizes all societies where electronic mass media are pervasive influences (Appadurai 1996). The quick spread of electronic sound technology around the world initially appeared as a spread of Western cultural or aesthetic domination, which would be destructive to local, traditional aesthetics (e.g., Wallis & Malm 1984). Upon a closer examination, however, culture theorists and ethnomusicologists have been finding that although the technology originates in the West, it tends to be appropriated (or resisted, or rejected) by cultural groups according to local or indigenous values (Penley and Ross 1991:xi; Waterman 1990; Sutton 1996), and that cultural groups use such new technologies to redefine and refine their own identities, whether in the service of creating new identities or of maintaining traditional ones in the face of cultural change (e.g., Sharma et al. 1996; Lee 1999). In this dissertation, I show that the role of such technology in Kerala musical practices is best understood not as an instance of Western cultural hegemonization, but rather that global technologies and musical influences interact creatively with local realities and are put to uses which are meaningful within Kerala cultural contexts. As Appadurai and others remind us, globalization is often a localizing, rather than a homogenizing, process (1996:17).

2. The locale: 'The Cultural Capital of Kerala.'

From September, 2000, through June, 2001, I carried out ethnographic research in Thrissur, Kerala, in South India. Thrissur (spelled in Malayāḷam as *ṭṛṣṣūr*; formerly anglicized as 'Trichur') is the mid-sized capital of Thrissur District in Central Kerala, some 30 kilometers inland from the coast [see map, Figure 1.1]. According to the 2001 census by the Government of India, its population is 317,474. Thrissur District includes such important sites as Guruvayur, a famous pilgrimage temple, and Kodungallor (formerly anglicized as Cranganore), an ancient center of trade which was known to the Greeks, Romans, and Arabs.

The state of *Kēraḷam* itself was formed when Indian states were redefined linguistically in 1956, by combining the princely states of Malabar, Cochin, and Travancore, which correspond with North, Central, and Southern Kerala, respectively. The language of Kerala is Malayāḷam, and its speakers are referred to as Malayāḷis.

Thrissur is known, especially in the tourist literature, as the 'Cultural Capital' of Kerala, a fact which I took to be auspicious for a study of music in culture. The primary association for this appellation may be the many festivals for which Thrissur is famous, most importantly the *pūram* festival celebrated at Thrissur's central Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan Temple in April-May. But the slogan also refers to the high level of 'cultural' activity going on elsewhere in Thrissur District. Cheruthuruthy, about 35 km north of Thrissur town, and Irinjalakuda, about 20 km south, are both important centers of

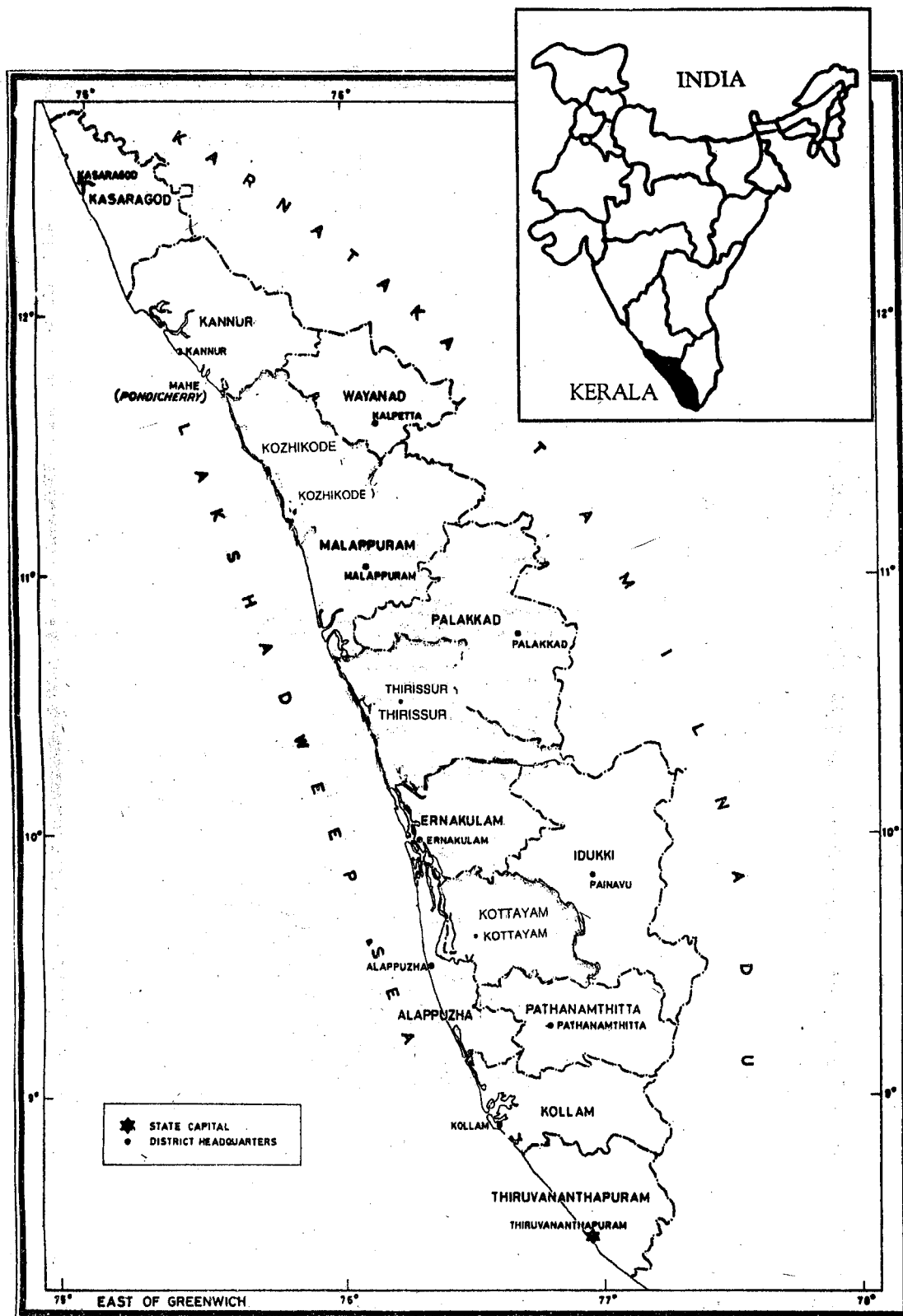


Figure 1.1 Map of Kerala [reproduced from Sreedhara Menon 1996a; India inset from Franke and Chasin 1994].

traditional performance arts. The former is home to the Kēraḷa Kalāmandalam, a state-run institution founded in 1930 for training in traditional performing art forms, and the latter is home to Natana Kairāḷi, a small but vital training center for *kūṭiyāṭṭam* and lesser-known performance arts. These institutions, and some of the artforms they promote, are discussed in Chapter Three.

Consistent with the traditional Hindu model wherein the center of a radiating power is the temple, the town of Thrissur radiates outward from the small hillock upon which sits the temple of Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan, a form of Śivan, at which the eighth-century Vedānta philosopher Ādi Śankarācārya is reputed to have spent his last days. The grounds around the temple are called the Tekkinkāṭṭu Maidān ['teak forest expanse'], but the teak trees are long gone. The Tekkinkāṭṭu Maidān is now a rather bald park area crossed by pathways. A section of it is set apart as a children's park. During the day, the Tekkinkāṭṭu Maidān is a popular place for men to gather and to play cards, or to watch the card games of others. Different parts of the grounds are occasionally used for exhibitions or for large-scale public gatherings such as political rallies or religious gatherings, the presence of which is generally signalled by massively amplified sound (see Chapter Two). The road which encircles this area is called the Round. The surrounding area was historically dominated by Nampūtiri Brāhmins and temple-related institutions such as the Brahmasvam Maṭham, a school for training Brāhman boys in Vedic recitation which is reputed to have been founded in the eighth century by disciples of Śankarācārya (Wood 1985:49); the famous Paramekkāvū goddess

temple; and the offices of several Devaswom Boards, or temple governing bodies.

In a shift which perhaps iconically signifies changing cultural priorities, the Round has in recent decades become Thrissur's major commercial center. The marketplace has moved from its peripheral geographic location to the central one which was previously reserved for Brāhmanic activity. Several multi-story upscale shopping centers have now been built on the Round. The rest of Thrissur is oriented around the four major streets which radiate outwards from the Round in the cardinal directions, and which are filled in with mazes of residential neighborhoods dotted with temples, churches, and mosques.

The area in which my partner Helen and I lived was a residential area about five kilometers from the Round, just off one of the four main arteries. This area only ten years earlier had not yet been 'incorporated' into Thrissur Corporation, and was governed under a separate *pañcāyattū* [Hindi *pañcāyat*], or village council. Now the area is and feels fully absorbed into Thrissur town. In this way it follows a trend which is visible throughout Kerala, that when one travels from town to town one never really leaves settled areas; one town blends into the next, with no open space in between. Part of the reason for this is that Kerala is among the most densely populated countries on earth (Jeffrey 1992:160-161; Kannan 2000:65); however, it doesn't feel overly crowded because its habitat pattern has always been one of high dispersal rather than concentration. This pattern has resulted in contemporary Kerala largely having the feeling of one huge sprawling town.

From the point of view of a dichotomy between urban and rural, this dispersal pattern makes much of Kerala into something between the two; as a whole, the state has a reputation for cosmopolitanness, as if it were one big city with many downtowns. This reputation is furthered by Indian companies who, when test-marketing a new product, are said to introduce it to Chennai, Mumbai, Bangalore, and Kerala. To be sure, there are huge differences between Kerala's big cities of Kozhikode, Ernakulam and Thiruvananthapuram and agriculturally-oriented village areas. Small cities (or large towns) like Thrissur fall very interestingly in the middle. By conducting this study in Thrissur, I was able to engage conceptions about public sounds and their role in the production of social space, in the midst of the dialectic between urban and rural cultural standpoints which help propel cultural change in Kerala.

Kerala's 'cosmopolitanism' is due to the long history of intercultural contact and exchange between Kerala's ports and the wider world, a history which very much continues into the present. Situated on a major trade route linking West to East Asia, for literally thousands of years Kerala experienced peaceful and prosperous contact and interaction with people of other cultures. Franke and Chasin credit this background with forming "the basis for the development of a progressive outlook by many of the state's more recent rulers," in that it "may have helped condition Kerala's people to respond easily to outside influences" (1994:24). This history compounds with more recent forms of intercultural exchange, such as that presented by cable television channels from elsewhere in India and abroad, and the continuing flow of workers from Kerala to other countries, to

form the basis for a cosmopolitanism described by the ethnomusicologist Thomas Turino as follows:³

Cosmopolitanism is a specific *type* of cultural formation and constitution of habitus that is translocal in purview. Because cosmopolitanism involves practices, material technologies, and conceptual frameworks, however, it has to be realized in specific locations and in the lives of actual people. It is thus always localized . . . and will be shaped by and somewhat distinct in each locale. Cosmopolitan cultural formations are therefore always simultaneously local and translocal. [2000:7].

The sonic and musical practices explored in this dissertation are thus rooted in local conceptions and practices, which are however informed by and thus framed with respect to a direct awareness of transnational situatedness.

Awareness of group differences or distinctiveness in Kerala society does not depend, however, on transnational reference points. Indian social relations in general have historically evolved through mutual transactions among kin networks continually differentiating their styles of life, as reflected and enacted in the division of persons into *varṇa* and *jāti* [often (mis)translated as 'caste'] categories (Marriott 2003). The issue of group distinctiveness, or what is commonly called 'social identity', may be more salient than elsewhere in India because of Kerala's religiously more diverse population: approximately 57% Hindu, 19% Christian, and 23% Muslim (according to the 1991 Census of India). Muslims are in higher concentrations in the Northern part of the state, while Christians outnumber Muslims in Central and especially Southern

3. See also Pollock, Bhabha, Breckenridge, and Chakrabarty (2002).

Kerala.⁴ The area surrounding our house represented the diversity of the population in general, and served as the primary locus for the research I report in Chapter Two. Interview material from a predominantly Christian neighborhood, in contrast, forms one base for the research I report in Chapter Four, where the notion of social identity becomes central to my analysis.

3.1 Historical context.

Setting the stage have been thousands of years of intercultural exchange, over one hundred years of social movements, nearly fifty years of Communist reforms and a purely Malayāli musical genre (which came packaged together), twenty years of state television, and almost a decade of cable television. I will outline this history selectively here. For detailed general accounts of Kerala history in English, see Sreedhara Menon (1996b), my principal source for the following summary. Ramachandran Nair (1999) provides a social and cultural history of the period of colonial rule.

Kerala's geographical situation has long exposed it to international crosscurrents. The area's fame as a land of spices brought foreign traders to its shores as early as the third millennium BCE. The Assyrian and Babylonian civilizations

4. According to Fuller (1976:38), in South and Central Kerala, Christians constitute about 31% of the population, with fewer in the North, while Muslims make up about 33% of the population in the North and only about 7% in Central and South Kerala.

of the third and second millennia BCE in Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq) traded goods for cardamom and cinnamon. The ancient Egyptians are also said to have imported Kerala spices to perfume oils they used in embalming and mummification. Biblical references to cinnamon and other spices indicate trade continuing between West Asia and Kerala in the second and first millennia BCE (Sreedhara Menon 1996b:61).

Trade continued with Arabs and Phoenicians, possibly not only by sea but also over land via the Indus Valley. Herodotus (484-413 BCE) noted that trade in cinnamon and cassia was in the hands of Egyptians and Phoenecians. In the following centuries up to the beginning of the Common Era, Greeks, Arabs, and Romans traded with Kerala for cardamom, cinnamon, ginger, turmeric, and pepper, all of which were considered by Greek physicians to have medicinal value. Sreedhara Menon further observes that it is possible that the Greek word for 'ginger', *zingiber*, may be derived from the Malayālam *iñji*.

Following the Roman conquest of Egypt in the first century BCE, the Romans actively entered the spice trade, breaking up the Arab monopoly. Roman gold and silver were traded not only for spices, especially pepper, but also for muslin, silk, and other luxuries. By the early centuries of the Common Era, the Chinese were trading for pepper, and traded for a much longer period than did the Romans. In the fourteenth century, Marco Polo wrote of a still-active trade in pepper, ginger, and cinnamon between Kerala, West Asia, and China.

There is a long history of religious diversity in Kerala. Jainism and Buddhism both flourished in the area for many

centuries. 10,000 Jews escaping persecution came to Kerala in the first century CE, shortly before Christianity is thought to have been introduced by the Apostle Thomas, who is said to have landed in Kodungallor, in present-day Thrissur District, in 52 CE. The Christian population was bolstered by the emigration to Kerala in the fourth century of a group of 400 Syrian Christians from 72 families, led by Thomas of Cana, from the cities of Baghdad, Jerusalem, and Nineveh; more immigrants followed in the ninth century (Visvanathan 1993:14). Islam may have been brought by Arab traders as early as the seventh or eighth century.

Vedic concepts of social order were unknown to the South before being brought by North Indian Brāhmans, who may have first come to Kerala in the third century BCE (Sreedhara Menon 1996b:102). Through them Āryan culture became known, and through the actions of rulers it began to affect much of Kerala from the fifth century CE. In this way of describing society, many birth-defined groups [*jātis*] of many occupations are characterized as belonging to four primordial *varṇa* [Sanskrit *varṇa*] class categories: *brāhmaṇ* ['priest'], *kṣatriya* ['protector'], *vaiśya* ['householder'], and *sūdra* ['servant'] (cf. Marriott 2003). Apart from these four are the *avarṇa* groups, known since the 19th century as 'untouchables'. In Kerala, however, the category of *kṣatriya* is represented by only 0.1% of the population (the former ruling elite, with the name Varma), and there are no *vaiśyas* at all. Brāhmans make up less than 2%; the group known as Nampūtiris are the indigenous Kerala Brāhmans. The next highest-ranking *jāti* group is the Nāyars, who are technically *sūdras*, but functioned as an elite group in

Kerala society. The Nāyars are the largest non-avarṇṇa group in Kerala, at about 15% of the population, according to pre-Independence census data (Fuller 1976:37-38). At a similar status level as the Nāyars are temple servant [ampalavāsi] jātis such as Vāriyars and the drummer/singer Mārārs. There are a number of avarṇṇa groups in Kerala; the largest of these are the Īzhava, constituting about 22% of the population (ibid.). Christians, Muslims, and Jews also categorized themselves in ways that were consistent with varṇṇa and jāti rankings.

3.2 Contemporary social context.

Kerala's present social structure is radically different from that which existed a century ago. In the period ending in the first part of the twentieth century, Kerala was, in Swami Vivekananda's famous phrase, "a madhouse of caste". As I describe in Chapter Two, the concept of distance pollution [tīṇṭal] was so pervasive that not only did 'low caste' persons pollute 'high caste' persons, but members of different low-ranking jāti groups mutually polluted each other. Temples were strictly the province of Nāyars and Brāhmans, and not only temples themselves, but even the roads approaching temples were off-limits to the lower jātis. And finally, almost all land was controlled by what Moore has labelled the 'house-and-land units' of Nāyar taravāṭṭus and Brāhman illams (1983; 1985), leaving the vast majority of persons as landless laborers in a situation that is often described as 'feudal' in nature.

Social movements extending back to the late nineteenth century began to dismantle Kerala's rigid jāti-based structures

of economic dominance, such as the land tenure system. As a result, social and geographical space has been reconfigured. I will here provide only an outline of these reforms; many other writers have written about them in great detail. For an in-depth study of the relations between notions of community and progressive political movements in the first half of the twentieth century, see Menon (1994). Fuller (1976) and Moore (1983) focus on the nature of the joint family system of the Nāyars and its disintegration. Franke and Chasin (1994) and Jeffrey (1992) show that radical reform by the Communist-led state governments elected since 1957 has resulted in social and economic progress which are unique in India, and which, despite sometimes mixed results, may serve as a 'model' for development strategies elsewhere in the world.

The first major attack on the 'caste system' also had the result of redefining the social nature of public space. In the context of the Gandhian nationalist movement against the British in the 1920s and 1930s, Malayālis began the famous *satyagraha* at Vaikkam, a campaign for the right of low caste persons to use the roads around the main temple.⁵ The campaign, in which Gandhi also participated, stretched on for twenty months in 1924-1925. The results were in fact mixed: rather than opening the existing roads to all, new roads around the temple, but at a 'safe' distance, were constructed. Not until 1928 were all roads in Travancore opened to all castes. Nevertheless, the massive popular participation in the *satyagraha* resulted in others elsewhere in the state, such as at the famous Guruvayur

5. Much has been written on the Vaikkam *satyagraha*. See, for example, Jeffrey 1992, Menon 1994, Sreedhara Menon 1997.

temple, eventually leading to the Temple Entry Proclamation of 1936, which opened all temples to all castes, at least legally. Perhaps more importantly, a new era had begun in terms of popular participation in movements for social reform.

The joint family living situations which existed in old Kerala, such as the Nāyar *taravāṭṭu*, are well known in the anthropological literature, thanks to scholars such as Melinda Moore (1990, 1985, 1983), C.J. Fuller (1976), and E. Katharine Gough (e.g., 1961). Some Īzhavas also lived in *taravāṭṭu*s, and Nampūtiri Brāhmans also lived in joint families known as *illams* or *manas*.⁶ In such situations, large numbers of people lived together in a single building, which in the case of the Nāyars was known as the *nāḷukeṭṭu* ['a space with four built-up sides' (Moore 1983:203; see also Moore 1990)]. The properties controlled by these *taravāṭṭu*s began being partitioned, and the joint family system they supported began breaking up, even before the Nayar Act of 1925 under which partition was first permitted, due to a variety of economic pressures (for more details, see Fuller 1976:123-150). In 1976, the Joint Hindu Family System (Abolition) Act was passed, which required the final dissolution of any remaining joint estates, matrilineal or otherwise (cf. Jeffrey 1992:41-49).

Social movements and legislation such as the 1933 Nayar Act led to the breakdown of the large Nāyar, Nampūtiri, and also Īzhava joint family house-and-land units [*taravāṭṭu*, *illam*], and resulted in the nearly universal adoption of nuclear family

6. While *taravāṭṭu*s were matrilineal, Brahman *manas* and *illams* were patrilineal.

living arrangements throughout the state (Fuller 1976; Moore 1983). The economic side of these movements, which required the partition not only of family but also of land and housing property, has led to the pattern one sees today throughout Kerala of parcels of land seemingly infinitely partitioned, such that children build houses for their own nuclear families on their parents' plot of land, and so do their children. As a result, residential areas are populated more and more densely, and -- as land is sold on the open market rather than controlled within families -- more diversely, by small family units.

Even more radical than the opening of public roads and temples to people of all castes, and the dissolution of the joint family and house-and-land unit, has been Kerala's land reforms. As Jeffrey remarks, "agrarian relations since the 1950s have changed. And since the 1920s there has been a revolution in the strict sense of the word: a whole system has been overturned" (1992:162). Land reforms were one of the central aims and accomplishments of the first Communist government in Kerala (Herring 1983:170), which was elected in 1957 and was dissolved by federal decree in 1959. Although land was largely owned by a small number of landlords, the land was cultivated by laborers in a complex system of tenancies and sub-tenancies. The goal of the land reforms was redistribution, such that all land should be owned by the one who works on it.

The provisions of Land Reforms abolished landlordism, but they were not altogether successful in establishing 'land to the tiller' (Herring 1983:165). While tens of thousands of families at least acquired the land on which their houses stood, disparities in land-holding were far from eliminated, as a

number of 'middlemen' acquired land they had leased, but had subcontracted out to be worked. According to the finance minister (later chief minister) of Kerala, C. Achutha Menon, this was not oversight but conscious compromise:

If the slogan, 'Land to the Tiller,' is to have any meaning, it is the person who actually cultivates the land either with his own labour or the labour of the members of his family who ought to get the benefit of land legislation. We have extended this a little and also included a person who personally supervises cultivation, although not doing actual manual labor, because we thought it was necessary in the interests of production to encourage such people also. [quoted in Herring 1983:165]

E.M.S. Namboodiripad, Kerala's Chief Minister from 1957-1959, explains the reasoning somewhat more clearly by arguing at the time that the main tactical goal of the reforms was to attack what he called 'feudalism' (ibid.).

Most significantly for the present study, land reforms left temples without resources, and thereby fundamentally changed the structure of patronage of the traditional arts and the nature of temple festivals. Temples, which were a center of high-caste culture, had been supported by the vast landholdings of the Nāyar or Nampūtiri families that owned them. The 'feudal' economic structure was what had allowed for the development of Kerala's elaborate and complex traditional musical and theatrical arts, such as *tāyampaka* or *kathakalī*. After the redistribution of land resources, temples had to turn to a broader community for basic financial support, with repercussions for festival and festival-based artforms that I discuss in Chapter Three.

3.3 KPAC: A new musical genre for a new society.

These and other reforms were achieved through the leadership of the Communist Party,⁷ and in what is an excellent example of the way music can be used as an effective political tool (cf. Lockard 1998), the original success of the Communist Party in the first place is widely credited to the popularity of a new genre of songs through which they raised social and political awareness. Significantly, the new form of music that escorted the new government into power provided the basis of the popular music that dominates contemporary Kerala mass media:

With the beginning of the struggle for independence and social justice, a new form of music with a different musical set up dawned, and many musical styles had to retreat to accommodate this new form of exquisite music which combined the classical, semi-classical, folk and the traditional theatrical styles under one melodious pattern called *lalita sangeetam*. This new form of music conveying touching emotions through moving tones and tunes, has manifested itself in the field of cinema, drama, All India Radio, Television etc. [Omcherry 1999:165-166]

Contemporary popular cinema music thus has its roots in the theater movement of the 1940s and 1950s which is represented most strongly in the musical plays of the Kerala People's Arts Club. The example of Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA), a national-level collective which was engaged in presenting dramas that raised social issues, "had given impetus to a radical collectivity which shaped innumerable amateur theatre groups in Kerala, mostly under the guidance of the Communist party" (V.M. Ramachandran 1999:68). Under this

7. As has been widely noted, the first democratically-elected government of the newly-formed state of Kerala in 1957 was led by the Communist Party, and Communist Party-led coalitions continued to lead the State Government well into the 1990s.

influence, the Communist Party in Kerala founded its own theater organization, the Kerala People's Arts Club, or KPAC.

As Omcherry suggests, above, to trace the early productions of the KPAC is to trace the construction of a new genre of purely Malayāḷam song. In 1954, KPAC staged its first play, *ente makanānū sari* ['My Son is Right']. As the title implies, it depicts a generational split, where the younger generation embodies new ideologies that are in conflict with the established social order, represented in this play by a progressive student leader and his conservative father. It was KPAC's second play that secured its reputation: *ninkaḷenne kammunistākki* ['You Made Me a Communist'], written by a communist activist named Tōppil Bhāsi while he was in hiding from the police. The actor KPAC Premachandran estimated in a conversation that this play has been performed well over 10,000 times, and it continues to be performed today.⁸

Music was used in drama before this time, but KPAC's approach to music was very different from the norm. Before *ninkaḷenne kammunistākki*, music had in general not been taken as an important part of the drama by either producers or audiences (Śilākumāri 1992:73). Songs of other troupes were loosely based on classical music [*śāstriyasāṅgītam*], but expectations were low; Śilākumāri, in her dissertation on Tōppil Bhāsi, comments that as long as someone kept their hand on a harmonium and made some tune, people were happy (ibid.).

8. At the 70th anniversary celebrations at Kēraḷa Kalāmandalam in December, 2000, which was co-sponsored by the CPI(M)-affiliated Manaviyam Cultural Mission, I saw a production of it on the grounds of the Kalāmandalam.

The early productions of the KPAC, in contrast, treated music as an important element. The play *nin̄kaḷenne kammunistākki* marks a transition between old and new. When was first performed, it had fifteen songs with lyrics by the poet O.N.V. Kurup, but these had simply been set to Hindi film tunes. Before long, G. Devarajan came along and composed new music for those songs. Consistent with the KPAC's populist goals, Devarajan and others felt that they could not reach the public in the way they wanted to with songs in a classical style. Devarajan and other early KPAC composers broke entirely new ground by incorporating folk song styles [*nāṭanpāṭṭu*] into their compositions, in essence developing a form which was felt to be purely Malayāḷam.

Their approach was successful and hugely influential. The songs took on a life of their own outside of the theatrical context, and set a standard for popular music in Kerala thereafter. Devarajan was one of several composers from the KPAC who went on to dominate cinema music and to profoundly influence the next generation of composers. Malayāḷis thus trace the development of contemporary popular cinema song styles to the innovations of these composers. I discuss the interactions between the genre of cinema songs and other domains of culture in Chapters Three and Four.

3.4 Television channels.

Although this project is not about television itself, the presence of television has affected everything within it. One of the increasingly significant ways in which Kerala society is

enmeshed in a transnational space is through the very recent and quick spread of cable television channels. The National Government's Doordarshan only began broadcasting Malayālam television programming in 1982, and since 1991, when satellite and cable channels began to become available, the effect on music and public culture in general has been immense. It would not be too great an exaggeration to say that the sudden prevalence of cable television is a key aspect of the present social order in Kerala.

For present purposes, however, I will say only that the life of music and other performing arts today must be understood with relation to television. One reason for this is that in India generally, television programming is highly determined by cinema (Agrawal 1998). Since the early days of sound films, popular music throughout India has been synonymous with film songs. Indeed, the tremendous popularity of cinema itself may be due more to the songs than any other factor: according to a survey conducted by the Centre for Social Research in Chennai, during the 1980s approximately 77% of movie-goers in South India attended only to experience the songs (Venkatraman 1995:107).

Cinema songs are made of both sound and image, song and 'picturisation', and therefore television delivers a more complete film song than a mere audio recording ever could. Television has accordingly assumed its natural place as a primary vehicle for music. Whereas only a few years ago, the main vehicle for widespread dissemination of film songs was the cassette, today the vast majority of the people I spoke to

listened to music through the television far more than they did via cassettes or radio.⁹

Along with ever-greater exposure to recordings of popular songs, now more than ever, Hindu and Christian devotional music is composed and heard in relation to film music styles. Television music programs and music channels allow listener-viewers unprecedented access to film songs in Hindi, Tamil, and Malayālam, as well as MTV-brand pop music from the West and from elsewhere in Asia. While sheer exposure to foreign pop music may be raising its popularity in places like Thrissur, Indian film music remains without question the most popular. Stylistic and language differences exist between regional film musics, but what they increasingly have in common are high-technology production, electronic instrumentation, and strong rhythms. Such characteristics are increasingly heard in commercially recorded devotional music, both Hindu and Christian, as well as in ensembles performing liturgical and devotional music in some Christian churches and prayer centers. These issues are important to the discussion in Chapters Three and especially Four.

9. Until 2000, the Indian Government's All India Radio constituted the only radio programming in India. Private companies began broadcasting in some locales in 2001, but to my knowledge, none have yet started in Thrissur.

4. Amplified sound and cultural meaning.

The following chapters represent three separable but interrelated spheres of investigation, in which I show that semiotically enmeshed technologies of amplified sound are used both to suit preexisting contexts and to mold new ones. The study of sound always brings us to the idea of space: we find that amplified sound is employed to transform not just physical space, but the social spaces surrounding temples and churches. In Chapter Two, I show that the practice of broadcasting devotional music in these communities both stems from long-standing cultural models and participates ambiguously in redefining social spaces in contemporary context. Chapter Three discusses new mass-mediated performance genres that are increasingly popular at Hindu temple festivals, and shows that such performances both reflect and enact a changing relationship between temples and public culture at large. Chapter Four illustrates the ways in which contemporary liturgical music in Kerala's Syro-Malabar Catholic Church is put to the difficult task of creating and sustaining a coherent and distinctive group identity. In these different domains, these investigations examine the mechanics of the interactions between social spaces of different natures, sociocultural change and the influence of mass media, sound technologies as used in cultural performances, and identity construction in contemporary Kerala.

CHAPTER TWO

LOUDSPEAKER BROADCASTS AND THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF SPACE

Introduction.

When Helen and I first looked at the house we ended up living in while we were in Thrissur, the owners, who occupied the upstairs flat when they periodically returned from their employment in Dubai (United Arab Emirates), made a point of reassuring us that the music from the nearby temple was much quieter now than it used to be. They were referring to the practice in nearly all temples and churches in Kerala of broadcasting studio recorded, commercially released devotional songs over loudspeakers for forty-five minutes to an hour at the beginning of each day, starting before dawn, announcing the morning *pūja* or church services going on. Churches hold their rituals only in the morning, but temples broadcast songs in the late afternoon as well, at the time of *dīpārādhana* ['worship with lamps'], the last ritual of the day. Our landlords needn't have feared that the broadcasts would frighten us off, however, since they were precisely what I had come to study.

Loudspeakers these days have pride of place at Hindu temples. They are sometimes simply attached to existing structures, but very often a pole or simple tower has been constructed solely for the purpose of mounting speakers, and nearly always the speaker is spatially higher than any other part of the temple. This spatial deployment serves an acoustic purpose, to be sure, but it is also tempting to read this placement as iconically signifying the status of amplified sound with respect to temple practices. Indeed, many devotees consider their service to be essential to the temple, and are unwilling to imagine a temple 'without songs'. While for some critics, the long history of Hindu devotional practices without the aid of loudspeakers indicates that loudspeakers are unnecessary, the fact remains that they are now an expected norm, fully integrated into the life of nearly every temple. The problem that this chapter addresses, then, is twofold. First, how has this electronic audio technology become an essential part of temple practices? And second, how do these broadcasts function in the socio-spatial context of contemporary Thrissur's diverse and densely populated neighborhoods?

In addressing these questions, I find the notion of 'cultural models' to be a useful one (e.g., Shore 1996; D'Andrade and Strauss 1992; Holland and Quinn 1987). This is the idea that culture is best understood "as an extensive and heterogeneous collection of 'models,' models that exist both as public artifacts 'in the world' and as cognitive constructs 'in the mind' of members of a community" (Shore 1996:44). Culture does not consist simply of a set of understandings or of knowledge about the world, nor is it made up only of learned patterns of behavior. A definition offered by Richard Shweder

encompasses both of these aspects of being human: culture is "a reality lit up by a morally enforceable conceptual scheme composed of values (desirable goals) and causal beliefs (including ideas about means-ends connections) that is exemplified or instantiated in practice" (1996:20). Culture is both internal and external, and irrevocably and inseparably so. The idea of cultural models is that one can gain understanding of the internal workings of culture, or culture 'in the mind', by paying close attention to the way it is 'instantiated in practice'. Thus as Shore describes,

As external and public forms, cultural models point to a great variety of human institutions that are the projections of conventional understandings of reality set in time and space, for all to experience as artifacts of a community's life. [1996:44]

These models can be either general or specific in their application. Shore uses the term 'foundational schema' to refer to a very general cultural model which serves as an organizing principle for a variety of specific practices (Shore's 'instituted models') or mental constructs ('mental models') (1996:45).

Broadcasts, which we may call an instituted model, have become a normal part of daily life in Kerala because they are an extension of cultural models already operative. The practice is related to a foundational schema wherein *greatness* is signified by *loudness*. Rooted in a universal synaesthetic perception, this schema has been highly elaborated in the context of Indian religious practices. For example, In her study of the social constitution of a Tamil village, Diane Mines devotes considerable attention to the conceptual correlation between "density" and *perumai* ('bigness', 'greatness') (1995:242-300).

By "density" she refers to what J. Bernard Bate (2000:145) calls "saturation of the visual and aural fields"; its semiotic relation to *perumai* is one of iconicity. In the context of a temple festival, she vividly describes the plethora of ritual objects and the prominence of loud music coming from the *pēriya mēḷam*¹ and from loudspeakers, and argues that worshippers understand such density or material excess as indicative (or more precisely, perhaps, as iconically indexical) of value, or relative greatness (*perumai*). That this relation can be considered part of a foundational schema is supported by examples she provides from other cultural domains of the polysemic interrelations between density, display, and bigness, and the ways their qualities project along several social dimensions.

In all of these cases, promoting density, by ensuring that the *koṭai* [temple festival] is well-organized and as grand as possible, is part of the process of creating *perumai* for oneself and one's community. Spatial extension signalled in part by the music blasted from temples across the night air is no small matter, but another way of locating the village, community, and person at the center of an extending source of power (the power of the loudspeaker announces that of the god). [Mines 1995:299]

The traditional association of loudness with importance and prosperity leads not only to temple broadcasts, but also to notable uses of heavy amplification in other domains, such as classical music performances and presentations of traditional Kerala dance-dramas such as *kathakalī*.

1. This is the pan-South Indian Hindu temple ensemble which consists usually of *nāgasvaram* (double-reed instrument, similar to oboe, but larger and louder) and *takil* (double-headed drum, struck with stick and finger caps; called *tāvil* in Tamil). It is outdoor music, and these instruments maximize high volume. Variations of the ensemble can be found from state to state; in Karnataka, for example, the ensemble commonly includes the alto saxophone.

As Mines suggests above, amplified sound is implicated in South Asian concerns about space, and how space is to be shared. A close examination of the practice of broadcasts thus is valuable not only for what we can learn about music and musical practices in Kerala, but also for what those practices can tell us about local categories and understandings of shared space; in this sense the project is an ethnosociological one, in Marriott's sense 1989). Urban spaces become experientially characterized, and social alliances and tensions alike are highlighted, when shared spaces are filled with amplified sound whose source is specific, but whose reception is quite general. Broadcasting sound through loudspeakers in an urban environment causes space to be subjectively demarcated. Such broadcasts are therefore implicated in what Western social theorists have called the social production or construction of space (Low 1996; Gottdeiner 1994; Lefebvre 1991). According to Setha Low, although the two terms really define the parameters of a single concept, the social *production* of space is subtly distinguished from the social *construction* of space in that the first has a materialist emphasis, and is more concerned with the political and economic formation of urban space. In contrast, the social *construction* of space blends this materialism with an approach to culture which evokes its intentional and performative aspects. It refers to the

phenomenological and symbolic experience of space as mediated by social processes such as exchange, conflict, and control. Thus the social construction of space is the actual transformation of space – through people's social exchanges, memories, images, and daily use of the material setting – into scenes and actions that convey symbolic meaning. [Low 1996:861-862]

Because broadcasts highlight both traditional and more recent local notions of how space is to be shared -- and the conflicts between these -- they also have implications for local notions of personal boundedness, of privacy, and so on. Such notions are changing as new models emerge as more appropriate for a world where, as a result of reforms instituted by the communist government, nuclear family living arrangements have taken the place of joint families, and neighborhoods are vastly more densely and diversely populated than in the past.

Thus the goal of this chapter is to provide a cultural account of the prominent place of amplification in shared spaces, an account that takes traditional cultural models concerning loudness and space as points of departure. The account goes on to consider broadcasts with respect to newer models or strategies for constituting social spaces which have emerged, for example as a result of the extensive social and economic reforms in the past half century, as well as of the changing uses and availability of audio technology. This account furthermore explores the conflicts that necessarily arise between these models, and their uneasy coexistence.

Section 1. Broadcasts.

1.1 'We prefer to use loudspeakers.'

Throughout India, one way in which people transform shared space is through extensive use of loudspeakers, which are very much a part of daily life in many areas. The situation is well-

represented by Diwan and Diwan, authors of a book published in New Delhi on environmental law:

Since we in India are fond of loud sounds, the most used source of man-made noise is loudspeakers on all occasions, and on any and every occasion, we prefer to use loudspeakers. Whether it is advertisement of new film or of dramatic performance or circus, we are fond of using loudspeakers. In worships, too we use them. *Jagratas*, *Akhandpaths*, Musical nights, religious sermons, marriage processions, political and non-political meetings, no programme will be held unless we use loudspeakers.
[1998:224]

In Kerala's neighbor states of Karnataka and Tamilnadu, political rallies and festivals are marked by broadcasting speeches and music through horn speakers strung up and down streets and alleyways, for blocks, completely taking over an entire area (cf. Bate 2000:132-182; Mines 1995). In those states, weddings too are celebrated with boisterous processions involving brass bands and amplified keyboard, amplifiers powered by a generator in tow. Such use of loudspeakers is not only celebratory but also a part of routine daily practices. I remember walking early one morning in 1996 around the small town of Kumbakkonam, Tamilnadu, having to cover my ears because of the unbearably loud songs being played from horn speakers apparently placed permanently on the street by a nearby temple. I watched incredulously as none of the many others on the street around me made any outward appearance of even noticing it.

In Kerala, such extravagant uses of loudspeakers are not found in urban areas, although the situation may be different in villages.² A Muslim man who had spent time working in Bangalore,

2. Although I spent very little time in village areas, my impression from brief visits and from conversations with others is that

Karnataka, felt that the difference in loudspeaker use between Kerala and Karnataka was due to the higher level of education in Kerala than in other states. His opinion was that loudspeakers were definitely overused in Karnataka, and that Malayālis "are changing as they get more educated.... Because culture [samskāram] is changing." A public indicator of this change is that a 1992 Kerala High Court decision completely banned all use of horn-type loudspeakers under any circumstances.³

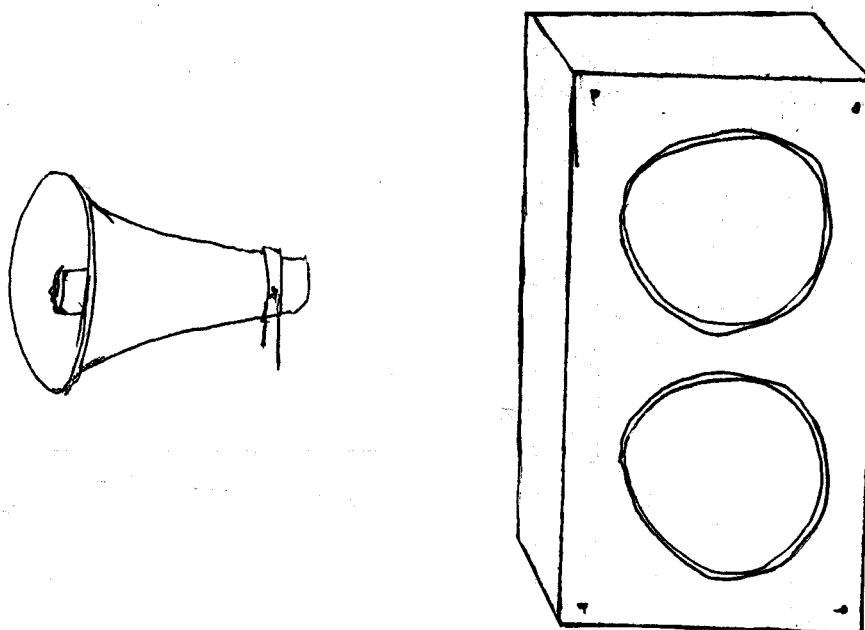


Figure 2.1 A horn speaker and a box speaker.

Despite that ruling, loudspeakers -- very much including horn-type speakers -- and amplified sound remain a salient part

amplifiers may be turned up louder and used with more abandon in villages than in cities.

3. Jacob v. Superintendent of Police, 1992, KLT (Kerala Law Times) 238.

of civilization's soundscape in Kerala. The ban against horn-speakers has had almost no effect on relatively permanent installations such as those at temples, churches, and mosques, nearly all of which continue to use horn-type speakers exclusively. Its effect has apparently been mainly to prevent the above-mentioned scenes of rampant loudspeaker usage which are common in Tamilnadu and Karnataka, and to force 'sound electricals' companies to rely on the more expensive and less efficient (yet higher fidelity) box-shaped speakers when they supply sound systems for public events.⁴ Sound electricals companies are bitterly opposed to the ban, and argue that because horn speakers are so efficient, they are useful if properly controlled. The state-wide association of sound workers organized a protest against the ban at the Secretariat in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala's capital, in December of 2000, but to my knowledge, the ban remains in place.

Loudspeakers are used to convey information to the public. To this end, sound electricals companies provide 'mobile sound systems': jeeps piled high with loudspeakers announce the latest cinema offerings, store openings, and the like, throughout the town. Especially during the season of the Ōṇam festival, a very popular secular statewide harvest celebration that places emphasis on gift-giving,⁵ these 'announcement cars'

4. Many horn speakers can be powered by a single low-wattage amplifier, but box speakers, in contrast, require more power and thus do not lend themselves to the same kind of spatial coverage.

5. Ōṇam is celebrated in *cinkam* month (August-September), the month of harvest. It is based on the legend that at this time Mahābali, "the legendary king who ruled over Kerala in an age of plenty and was pushed down to the infernal regions by Vishnu in the form of Vamana," returns to visit his people (Sreedhara Menon 1996a:65). In

go about advertising clothes, ornaments, jewellery, and other items. During the monsoon season, I heard vehicles out advertising umbrellas.

Not only private companies, but also the city of Thrissur itself relies on loudspeaker-laden vehicles to go about spreading urgent public service messages. For example, while I was there, as a part of a national campaign to eradicate polio, advertisements appeared on television, in the newspapers, and also on banners displayed around Thrissur's central hub, known as 'the Round', and in railway stations. Thrissur Corporation supplemented the campaign with an announcement jeep, piled with box-type speakers, informing the public that the next day, children of a certain age were to go to designated places to receive polio drops at no charge.

Probably most frequently announced over mobile loudspeakers, though, are the sounds of politics. During election periods (elections for different levels of government are held at various times of year), these jeeps piled with loudspeakers are almost constantly to be seen going around the Round and other major streets, advertising their parties and their candidates.

The loudspeakers convey not only political speeches and endorsements, but also music: each party plays songs which are associated with its political history and outlook. The Left Democratic Front (LDF), a leftist coalition which includes both

recognition of the value of having a (relatively) secular holiday which could unite Malayālis as citizens of Kerala, regardless of religion or caste, the state government took up the celebration of Ōṇam as a national festival in 1961 (ibid.).

the Communist Party of India (CPI) and the larger Communist Party of India-Marxist (CPI-M), may broadcast excerpts of poems from the great revolutionary poets O.N.V. Kurup or Vayalar Rama Varma, both of whom play central roles in the development of Kerala society since midcentury. They may also play songs of the Communist Party-affiliated Kerala People's Arts Club (KPAC, about which more will be said in Chapters Three and Four), which emphasize the ethos of the proletariat (e.g. "We are the laborers, we have nothing to lose; from the drops of blood of one laborer, thousands of laborers come"). The Congress Party-led United Democratic Front (UDF), which won a statewide election when I was there, plays old nationalist and patriotic songs, embodying their nationalist spirit. Their car-top broadcasts on the streets of Thrissur may also include excerpts from the speeches of national Congress Party leaders Indira Gandhi or Jawaharlal Nehru expressing sentiments such as "I am ready to spare my life for the nation." Mobile broadcasts by the Bharatiya Janata Parishad (BJP), the right-wing Hindu nationalist and 'fundamentalist' party which is currently in control of the national government -- but which has won less than 10% of the vote in recent Kerala state-level elections -- incorporates recordings of *mantras* or verses from the Bhagavad Gītā, for example Kṛṣṇa asserting that "when *dharma* has decayed, I will come again to correct it", spreading the message that they are working to build a Hindu nation.

Given the development of communist principles in Kerala, workers are well-organized, and demands are often reinforced by calling general strikes [*harttāls*]. Employing loudspeaker-laden jeeps was a frequent strategy for announcing such strikes for the next day, including those being called by government

offices. These communications appeared to be effective: the day after hearing such a call, the streets would be empty.

1.2 The spread of electronic sound technology.

The ability to broadcast sound obviously depends upon having the appropriate audio technology at one's disposal. Sound electricals companies are the source of large public address systems, but today nearly every household owns its own means of playing music through speakers, whether those of a cassette player, radio, or most prominently in recent years, television. Well within living memory in Thrissur, however, it was very rare for a household to have its own radio or cassette player, and those who were lucky enough to have their own set usually didn't mind sharing by playing their sets loudly enough for neighbors to hear. The sound of radios, and more recently televisions, was the sound of prosperity and high status, representing cultural capital in Bourdieu's (1977) terms, according to the values of an increasingly technologizing society. Today, although the sheer novelty of readily available sound technology has worn off to a certain extent, some of my neighbors say they continue to enjoy hearing the sound of music drifting in from their neighbors' houses, as I discuss later in this chapter. The point I wish to emphasize here is simply that from the earliest days of their use in Kerala, radios and cassette machines were played loudly, in order to function both as a service to neighbors and as a display of one's own status.

Before privately owned sets became common, the sounds of radio were provided from centralized locations by local or

regional governments. Public broadcasts via loudspeaker were first introduced in continuity with a cultural model of public service. This model is derived from the history in Kerala of a strong, widespread social emphasis on the virtues of education, increasing public awareness, and grassroots social movements. Following this model, 'village libraries' or *vāyanaśālas* began to be established even preceding the election of the Communist government in 1957, in what was known as the *granthaśālapraṣṭhānam*, or library movement (cf. Kannan 2000:60-61). These libraries were supplied with radio sets by both the state government and local *pañcāyattū*s in order to supplement the news which was available in print. My neighbor, D. Sasindran,⁶ a 50-year-old professor of English at a nearby college, had a job when he was a student in 1968-69 as a "librarian-cum-radio operator" in a nearby village area which is now, due to population growth, fully incorporated as a neighborhood within Thrissur. In his words:

DS: So, my duty was this: At 5:30 [in the afternoon] I have to open the library, village library, and take the big horn speaker, place it on the window, then pull the wires and connect them to the radio; the radio set didn't have a [built-in] speaker. It was distributed by the Kerala Government; the Government distributed this to libraries. And we have to tune the Thrissur station. We will tune the Thrissur station, and sit idle, and then the people will come for changing news; the news and everything will be given to the public. I can show you the library; it still functions like that -- no, now there is TV. It is a TV set.

EK: And how loudly would you play the radio?

6. All names used in this dissertation, with the exception of names of those deemed public figures, are pseudonyms.

DS: Very loud I think [laughs]. I would put on the volume to the maximum I think. Far and near people would be listening. People would be reading newspapers, but when there was news [being broadcast] they would fold the newspapers and listen to the news. Not the box-type [speaker], horn-type!

In addition to village libraries, radios were also installed in other public areas. For example, near our house there was a small overgrown public park next to a main road, on one side of which a small concrete building stood unused; from small windows on all four sides, four cone speakers pointed out silently. Neighbors told me that fifteen years ago, when the area was still a separate village and had not yet been incorporated into Thrissur town, radio was played from these speakers too, as a public service of the *pañcāyattū*.⁷

1.3 Devotional song broadcasts.

Amplified advertisements come and go, and the sounds of politics fill the air during election times, but the main sources of amplified sound to be heard on a daily basis in Thrissur are Hindu temples, Christian churches, and Muslim mosques. Many areas of Thrissur are dotted with small temples,

7. When televisions were new to Kerala some twenty-five years ago, they too were centralized. Sasindran told me that in the 1970s, he remembers going to the Round at the center of town, where a television set had been installed in the Children's Park area of the Tekkinkāṭu Maidān, "just like an exhibition."

In contrast to the radios in village libraries, the televisions were intended to limit citizen's knowledge of politics and the outside world rather than to expand it: the installing of televisions in every town center was a part of Indira Gandhi's Emergency Period, June of 1975 to April of 1977, when the government imposed a media blackout. The televisions broadcast the only channel available, the Government's Doordarshan, which according to Sasindran, was used for propagandistic purposes.

such that it is uncommon to be very far from one, and nearly all have loudspeakers mounted. Churches tend to have speakers mounted near the church bell in a cement bell-tower, and mosques of course have loudspeakers mounted in a minaret. In all of these cases, the vast majority of speakers are of the horn type, despite the fact that they have been legally banned for years. And in all cases, loudspeakers are mounted in such a way that they are quite obviously directed more toward listeners outside than inside the premises.

Beginning in the early morning, generally around 5:00 a.m. (give or take a half-hour), at each temple someone comes in, switches on an amplifier and a cassette player, and presses 'play'. Devotional songs are played for between a half-hour and an hour, between the time of opening the temple and the time to begin the first *pūja* of the day, at which time the cassette is switched off, often abruptly in the middle of a song. At temples which are not in an economic position to support musicians -- in other words, the vast majority of temples -- *pūja* is accompanied by another cassette of music appropriate for ritual, either (as in our nearby temple) *pēriya mēḷam* or an indigenous Kerala temple form based on drumming such as *tāyampaka*, *pañcavādyam*, or *ceṇṭa mēḷam*.⁸ When the *pūja* is finished, the cassette is again switched off as abruptly as it was started, and the air hangs empty, the sound of birds chirping suddenly exposed. In the meantime the sun has risen, and the day has begun.

8. These forms will be introduced in Chapter Three.

Churches appear to have followed temples in taking up the same practice, and play Christian devotional songs for a half to one hour each morning, often while simultaneously tolling the church bell. At temples, the pattern of the broadcast is the same in the evening as in the morning: devotional songs for some time, and then at the time of *dīpārādhana*, the *pēriya mēlam* cassette is put on. Again, the cassettes are started and stopped not between songs, but rather according only to the timings of the *pūja*. Mosques in Thrissur, as in other Muslim areas of the world, broadcast the call to prayer, or *vānkū viḷi*, at five times during the day. In contrast to the emanations from temples and churches, which can go on for an hour or more, the calls to prayer are very brief, lasting only two or three minutes. The exact timings vary according to the time of year; at the mosque I could hear from our house in Thrissur, the first call of the day was as early as 4:30 a.m., and the last one in the evening as late as 9:00 p.m. Rather than using prerecorded cassettes, Thrissur *imāms* use a microphone and perform each call live.

The question remains of how this practice of broadcasting cassettes at temple originated. As I have outlined in Chapter One, the result of Land Reforms was that Hindu temples went from controlling enormous wealth to being utterly without resources. According to some accounts, temples were allowed to fall by the wayside because, as outdated, now impoverished institutions, they did not signify the direction that the state was felt to be moving. The many social and economic reforms taking place at that time led to the expectation of rapid development in the state, and among young people like my neighbor Sasindran, there was widespread idealism and hope for the future. And yet

temples were not in step with the rapid social change which was happening. According to my neighbors, some 30-35 years ago many temples in the area closed their doors, and did not light their lamps; in some temples the idols were broken.

Despite these rapid changes, idealism soon faded somewhat as it became evident that the development was not as drastic as it had been hoped. For those believers who were striving to bring themselves and their communities to a higher economic plane, seeing temples sitting decrepit in their midst may have caused some cognitive dissonance. I say this because there is a cultural model prevalent in South India whereby the power [*śakti*] of divinity radiates outwards (cf. Mines 1995:299, quoted above), and by extension, the energy of a temple radiates outwards into the surrounding community, with potentially either positive or negative effects (Karel 1997; Janaki 1988:xviii). As one of my neighbors put it, before long people "felt a spiritual void" and began turning back to the temples. Those who had begun to achieve some economic success, often by working abroad in the Persian Gulf countries, wanted to return something to the temples, and to reinvigorate them.

For a Hindu temple, a primary signifier of life and activity is sound, and the energy of the divine is most readily instantiated in the form of sound (Karel 1997; Beck 1993; Alper 1989). Therefore, in order to allow the temple to declare itself alive and to radiate its positive energy in the form of sound, devotees returning from employment in the Gulf brought back with them turntables (and later cassette decks) and amplifiers to donate. According to most estimates, by the mid-1980s, almost all temples had sound systems. These allowed

temples to display renewed vitality by broadcasting devotional music out into the community, a mode which became well-established as a display not only of the generosity of its patrons, but also of the prosperity and high status of the temple. Given the historically close cultural affinity between Hindus and Christians, before long this practice was adopted by churches also.

1.4 Broadcasting *bhaktigānam*.

As I have mentioned, except during the actual *pūja*, the songs played by the temple fall into the category of devotional songs, or *bhaktigānam*. These songs are produced in a studio for commercial release on cassette. Musically, devotional songs generally owe more to the development of light music [*lālitasāṅgītam*] and Malayāḷam film songs than they do to older Hindu devotional genres such as *bhajana*, or the indigenous Kerala temple genre of *sōpānasāṅgītam*.⁹ This overlap with film song aesthetics is illustrated by the fact that the same handful of very popular Malayāḷam singers is ubiquitous on cassettes of both film songs and devotional songs, principally including K.J. Yesudas and P. Jayachandran.¹⁰

9. *Sōpānasāṅgītam* is ritual music performed by the Mārār temple musician caste at the stone steps [*sōpānam*] leading up to the central shrine. It is based on *rāgams*, most of which are identical to Karnāṭak *rāgams* and others specific to Kerala, and encompasses the vocal genres of *tyāṇi* [from the Sanskrit *dhyāna*, 'meditation'], *aṣṭapadi* ['eight lines'], and *kīrttanam* [devotional songs, similar in form to the genre of Hindu group singing known as *kīrtan*] (Groesbeck 1995:183-188). See also Omcherry (1999).

10. The fact that Yesudas is Christian does not detract from his popularity among Hindus at all; in fact, Yesudas proclaims his devotion

The paradigmatic *bhaktigānam* -- the standard against which devotional songs are generally measured -- is 'semi-classical', which means that it is based upon a Karnātak *rāgam*, albeit sometimes loosely; it may also contain some Western-style harmonizations. Overall, it is simple and traditional in its instrumentation, featuring only harmonium and *tabala* [*tablā*] with instrumental interludes generally on flute or sometimes *vīṇa*; its vocal melody is flowing and simple, yet with appropriate *gamakas* or ornamentations, and its sentiment is direct and affecting. These are the songs at which Yesudas and Jayachandran excel, and for which they are most famous. Track 1 on the CD is a song sung by Yesudas which was broadcast often from our temple, and which was a favorite for some of my neighbors.¹¹

But there are many variations or types of devotional songs which have evolved over the years, which are heard as having taken on characteristics either of regional musics, commercial cinema music, Western music, or any combination of the above, depending on whom one asks. For example, the central deity of our neighborhood temple is Murukan, and so devotional songs to Murukan were often played. Although Murukan has been incorporated into the Brāhmanical pantheon as Subramaniam, he is generally perceived as a Dravidian (*Śūdra*) rather than an Āryan

to Hindu deities, and Hindus say they hear his devotion in his interpretations. Even at the famous pilgrimage site at Sabari Mala, at the end of every day 'Harivarāsanam' is played as a lullaby for the deity, and I was told that only the recording by Yesudas is played, and that nothing else is acceptable.

11. The song is 'Vaṭakkunātha', and expresses devotion toward the form of Śivan enshrined at Thrissur's Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan Temple. The music director is T.S. Radhakrishnan, the lyricist P.C. Aravindan; the song was released on a cassette entitled *Gangātīrttam*.

(Brāhmanical) deity, which means that he is sometimes referred to as 'Tamil'. Devotional songs to Murukan are in fact more commonly found in Tamil language and with Tamil musical influences. Track 2 is a Tamil song that was played regularly at our temple.¹² Tamil practices such as *kāvaṭi* dancing, a form of penance or vow fulfillment generally associated with trance states and accompanied by fast and loud drumming, are associated with his worship, and thus Tamil devotional songs to Murukan such as this one refer musically to *kāvaṭi* dancing by featuring heavy beats and fast rhythms. Heavy beats and excited singing are also common characteristics of songs of the deity Ayyappan, who is also thought of as a Dravidian or low-caste deity (Groesbeck 1995:93).¹³ During the two month *mandalam* period when men undertake the pilgrimage to Ayyappan's temple at Sabari Mala, the temple played almost nothing but Ayyappan songs.

Where things get complicated is that heavy beats or fast rhythms can also signify the influence of new cinema song styles, for example the electronic innovations of the contemporary Tamil film composer A.R. Rahman. Furthermore, such influences are also felt by some listeners to index the

12. I was unable to find someone who could identify this song, other than to say that it is a Tamil song. The cassette it was on was an unlabeled dub, which had been donated to the temple by a devotee.

13. I would speculate that one reason songs for Ayyappan are characterized by heavy beats, shouting, and so on, is that they express the hypermasculinity which is fundamental to the Ayyappan cult, and which is expressed also through the vow of celibacy which is undertaken in preparation for the pilgrimage, and through the fact that women capable of childbearing are excluded from the pilgrimage. As Sarah Caldwell notes,

The cult of Ayyappan is surely motivated in part by a desire to overcome the perceived sexual power of women, a power which seems to threaten male solidarity and well-being. [1999:137]

influence of Western popular music. Both of these influences -- cinema and the West -- are generally considered undesirable in devotional songs that are played from the temple, although they may be appreciated in songs which are played at home.

Not long after the *mandalam* pilgrimage period drew to a close, at the end of February, there was a change in personnel at the temple, which interestingly resulted in a change in the types of devotional songs that were broadcast in the morning. The son of the *kazhakakkāran* [priest's assistant], a young man who had been helping his father by opening and closing the temple, managing the cassettes, cleaning, and doing other jobs around the temple, was abruptly fired after allegedly drinking alcohol in the temple after hours. One of the committee members then volunteered his services in what was supposed to be a brief interim period, but which stretched on for months. This man brought a new sensibility to the temple broadcasts. Before he took over, we heard the same kinds of songs both in the morning and the afternoon, which were often fast and heavily rhythmic such as the ones heard above. Now, following the change, the music in the morning differed from that in the afternoon. In the early morning, we now heard soft, meditative songs, such as M.S. Subbulakshmi's famous recording of the *Śrī Venkatēśa Suprabhātam*, an excerpt of which is on Track 3 of the CD. The more energetic songs continued to be played in the afternoon.

As we will see in Chapter Four, Christian devotional songs, which are broadcast from churches in the morning, are historically more closely connected with *lālitasāṅgītam* and cinema music. Although Christian history in Kerala is long and deep, Christians did not develop an independent musical culture

until the 1960s, when a Christian music began being developed in parallel with the development of Malayālam cinema music. In early morning church broadcasts, one can hear a continuum from gentle *lālitasaṅgītam* to songs that have more in common with contemporary cinema music. In general, Christian devotional music does not reference Hindu devotional genres such as *bhajana*, although there are exceptions. For example, one Christian family's favorite devotional cassette to hear in the morning was one by Thrissur Kalāsadan, an orchestra that is associated with the Catholic Church, which features a version of the *Suprabhātam* with Christian lyrics.

Broadcasts from mosques other than the call to prayer are rare. Except for one mosque in Thrissur which occasionally broadcast chanted group prayers on Friday evenings which were audible for a radius of at least two kilometers, the only time at which broadcasts were heard from all mosques was on the annual holiday of Bakrid, also called Id-ul-Azha. Beginning at 5:00 a.m., I heard the sound of cone-speaker-inflected voices coming from over the coconut trees, which I described in a journal entry as "minimally melodic, maximally repetitive, very pleasant." The prayer is called *takbīr*, and the day's events were described in an article in the next day's newspaper as following:

Men, women and children alike, dressed in new clothes, were seen moving to the mosques and Id-Gahs since early morning, as hymns of 'Thakbeer' coming from loudspeakers filled the air. After the Id Juma, people were seen warmly embracing one another, consolidating the concept of brotherhood, and exchanging Id greetings. ['Bakrid celebrated with religious fervor', *The Hindu*, 7 March 2001]

1.5 Distortion and perception.

It is important to note that the loudspeakers themselves are not transparent in these broadcasts. In other words, the sound that pervades the area around a temple or a church is not the clear sound that the recording and mixing engineers heard through their studio monitors, but rather a sound that has been duplicated onto analog cassette tape, subjected to the wear of repeated play and possible mold growth in the tropical climate,¹⁴ and transmitted through an amplifier of uncertain vintage to horn speakers kept in the open air year-round. All of these factors affect the sound quality, and can introduce distortion. The quality of sound from the speakers at our temple was often quite distorted, and based upon my observations, such a situation was not uncommon.¹⁵ As noted above, reflex-type horn speakers are designed for efficiency in spreading a message over great distances at the expense of fuller fidelity. They are optimized for the relatively narrow frequency range necessary to understand human voices, whose principal range is 300-3,000 Hertz (Rossing 1990:622), and not for music, which can occupy a much wider frequency spectrum.

To my surprise, most of my neighbors seemed almost not to notice the distortion. When I played back recordings like Track 2 (above), which I had recorded from temple broadcasts, my

14. At one temple, when I was being shown the cassette player and the cassettes, some of the cassette boxes were found to be filled with ants who were busy eating the oil or ghee which had gotten onto the tapes after being handled by the priest's assistant.

15. Track 4 on the accompanying CD gives an example of the worst of this distortion. This quality of sound persisted for about a month. At other times, sound quality could vary widely.

neighbors either didn't hear or (consciously or unconsciously) disregarded what I heard as rather extreme distortion. They seemed to be able to 'listen through' the distortion, and to appreciate the song, as long as they already knew and liked the song. In this way my findings matched those of Greene (1995), who found that when Tamil villagers listened to distorting cassette playback, that they

generally tried to hear through these difficulties to a musical performance that is represented, even if imperfectly, on the cassette. It is the *represented* performance in which villagers expressed an interest, not so much sound qualities introduced by the playback technology. [1995:174]

In the case of my neighbors in Thrissur, it was only in the cases where the song was less than known to them, or especially if the lyrics were rendered unintelligible, that the distortion interfered with their appreciation.

1.6 Community teashop as makeshift temple.

Cassettes played at a teashop served a similar purpose to that of temple or church broadcasts. My early morning walks through an economically poor, low-caste 'colony' adjacent to my neighborhood were accompanied by amplified sound coming from a number of homes. The loudest and most consistently playing emanated from a tiny teashop, which has for forty years served as a social gathering place for men in the neighborhood. The teashop is built onto the front of the proprietor's house, and is just large enough for a place for him to stand and prepare tea on one side, and a small booth for a few men to sit on the

other.¹⁶ The dark walls are covered with aging images of deities, some with tiny red lightbulbs wired in front of them; through the doorway, in the house, I see more old and faded posters behind small glowing bulbs. One customer, a man who used to work as a wage-laborer but is now unemployed because of an unspecified injury, commented that even a small temple may not have so many lights. Also hanging at the top of the wall, against the low ceiling, is one of two small speakers; the other is mounted on the other side of the tea preparation area, oriented so that it plays out into the neighborhood.

The broadcast schedule of the teashop is closely aligned with a common temple schedule, and indeed, the teashop seems almost to play the part of a temple in the lives of its neighbors and regular customers. The proprietor, Siddhārtthan, arises each morning at 3:00 a.m. when he hears the popgun explosion [*veṭikkeṭṭu*] from Vaṭakkunāthan Temple at the center of Thrissur, several kilometers away. This popgun, the first sound of the day, is apparently a signal to the priest to awaken and to come to the temple to begin the day at 4:00 a.m. The teashop owner, too, begins his day at 4:00 a.m. by putting a cassette on through the loudspeakers; he and customers of his that I spoke to emphasized that it was always the same cassette, M.S. Subbulakshmi's *Śrī Venkatēśa Suprabhātam*.¹⁷ The cassette

16. Women may come and buy something from outside, but don't enter.

17. At the time I first asked about this, however, he put on the cassette for me, and it wasn't the *Suprabhātam* that I heard; after a moment of confusion I realized that it was the B-side of the published cassette, which includes Karnātak *kritis* by Swati Tirunal and Muthuswami Dikshitar. The temple in my neighborhood, nearby but beyond earshot, also alternated between the *Suprabhātam* and its B-side.

that would be put on next varied according to the day of the week (see Figure 2.2). The pattern is a well-known, normative one that is used also by some temples to choose cassettes.

<i>Monday</i> Śivan	<i>Tuesday</i> Dēvi ¹⁸	<i>Wednesday</i> Ayyappan	
<i>Thursday</i> Subramaniam ¹⁹	<i>Friday</i> Dēvi	<i>Saturday</i> Ayyappan	<i>Sunday</i> Christian

Figure 2.2 The teashop's morning devotional cassette schedule.

When this schedule was being described to me, the men sitting at the table said first that on Friday, Muslim devotional songs are played. Siddhārtthan, however, said that he doesn't have any Muslim cassettes, and that he plays Dēvi songs.²⁰ Whether the

18. For Dēvi (the goddess), Siddhārtthan plays a cassette of *bharani* songs sung by Kalābhavan Mani. This is an odd choice for a devotional cassette, because the *bharani* festival is one which is infamous for the obscene songs which are sung at that time (Caldwell 1999:95,165-167), and Kalābhavan Mani is a comedian known for raunchy humor; the cassette is a kind of parody. On the cover of this cassette, as on posters advertising it which were plastered around the Round, Kalābhavan Mani is depicted holding a sickle -- an emblem of the goddess -- and with blood dripping down his bald head. The song Siddhārtthan plays for me is in contemporary cinema style; in fact the melody and rhythm are very similar to that of a currently popular song from the hit movie, *Tenkāśipattanam*.

On the issue of why Tuesdays and Fridays are sacred to the goddess, see Caldwell (1999:134).

19. Siddhārtthan used the Sanskrit name Subramaniam rather than the more Dravidian or Tamil name Murukan.

At one Bhagavati temple, cassettes of songs for Kṛṣṇa, rather than Subramaniam, were played on Thursday.

20. I came upon a similar case of prescription replacing description when two people in my neighborhood told me that the local temple follows the pattern given in Figure 2.2 for playing devotional cassettes, when in fact it did not.

men were simply mistaken or were trying to mislead me (which I doubt), their error speaks to the socially widespread endorsement of Kerala's religious pluralism. Furthermore, regarding playing Christian songs on Sunday mornings, Siddhārtthan said that there are four or five Christian families in the colony, and when I asked if they enjoy hearing the Christian songs on Sunday, a Hindu customer said that everyone, not just the Christians, likes hearing them. Thus playing Christian songs, or the imagined playing of Muslim songs, is done not as a favor to a specific target audience, but as a way of proclaiming and even celebrating a theology and a sociology of openness.

Siddhārtthan plays cassettes only from 4:00 until 6:00 in the morning. Then he plays the Thrissur AM radio station²¹ through the speakers, from 6:00 until 8:30, again for a couple of hours at noon, and finally again in the late afternoon until closing at 7:00 p.m., for mixed programming of general interest including news in Malayāḷam, Hindi, Sanskrit, and English, and of course film songs. In the pre-dawn morning, customers come and sit without speaking while they have their tea, listening to the devotional songs. In the *mandalam* period of preparations for the pilgrimage to Sabari Mala, the stall is full by 4:00 a.m. of men dressed in their prescribed black dhotis who have already had their prescribed morning bath. Although only a small group of men come and sit in the small shop, its loudspeakers stake out a large social space in the colony.

21. The Thrissur station comes under the jurisdiction of All India Radio, a government enterprise based in New Delhi, which is generally referred to as *ākāśa vāṇī*, or 'the sound of the *ākāśa* [aether]'.

Section 2. Preparing the way for broadcasts: Cultural models of loudness and space.

Broadcasts from temples and churches play a complex role in contemporary Thrissur society, not least because they occupy a historical moment in Thrissur which is characterized more by flux than by constancy, by virtue of radical changes stemming from both within and outside the culture. In such a situation, values and priorities emergent in a society which has undergone significant economic and social reform, and which has been and is increasingly in close contact with a global economy and global media, may come into conflict with values that were suited to a more traditional, agrarian society.

Before analyzing these emergent conflicts by addressing the question of the meanings broadcasts have for inhabitants of Thrissur, in this section I am concerned with the broader cultural context in which broadcasting originated. I demonstrate that cultural models were in place which set the stage for the particular kind of use that amplification technology has been put in Kerala. I first take up local notions of space and notions of the 'shareability' of spaces, and explore cultural models of the mutual implicatedness of sound and space. I then examine the ways in which 'loudness' may be seen as a cultural model, the ways in which loudness itself is valued, particularly in domains of religious observations.

2.1 Space and *ākāśa*.

Music is commonly thought of as something which exists and unfolds experientially in time, but the substance of music, sound, is equally or perhaps even more accurately conceived of as existing in space. Space is often thought of as negative, as the gap between things which really exist: the space between two words, or the space between two houses. It can also be considered as positive, as a sort of stuff in which we move and do what we do, as a presence which gives definition to the things within it. Classical notions of space in Sanskrit and Tamil texts allow for both of these aspects, describing space as *ākāśa*, or aether, the fifth and most subtle of the five elements [*bhuta*]. It has been described as 'the Void' by a priest at the temple in Chidambaram, Tamilnadu, where Siva is worshiped in the form of the *ākāśa* *lingam* (Deekshithar 1997). It is also thought of as an all-pervasive presence between things which is understood to be the medium of sound. In Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika philosophy, "The proof of *ākāśa*'s existence is exclusively from the facts about sounds." (Potter 1977:90; see also Saraswati 1999).²² One function of sound, then, is to take a negative space, or an absence of connection between people, and to create in its place a positive space, a continuum which realizes a connection between people which is thus both physically and subjectively real.

In what follows I take up this notion of the intrinsic connection between sound and space. I begin with an account of

22. The notion of *ākāśa* as the medium of sound is especially important in the Tamil Śaiva classic, Tirumular's *Tirumantiram* (Natarajan 1991; Natarajan 1994:253; see also Karel 1997).

social space in historical perspective. I then examine two different conceptions of space, each of which is definable by the kinds of sounds which either constitute or fill it. The first concept, or model, is that of space as something vast which is overcome by means of loud sound. The loud sounds that can fill or transcend this space include explosives or 'popguns' and large drum orchestras, such as *pañcavādyam*. Due in large part to the contribution of one of the instruments of the *pañcavādyam*, the *kompū* or horn, that ensemble straddles both the first and the second concepts of space. The second concept of space is what I call a sonic immersion model. This model considers space less as a physical or objective area as in *ākāśa*, but rather as a kind of shared consciousness. It is something intimate which is created and entered into intersubjectively, by means of sharing in religious sound, such as the sounds of *mantra* or *bhajana*. Implicated in both of these concepts of space is a cultural model of loudness, whereby loudness signifies greatness, power, connections between people, and celebration. Before bringing sound and loudness into the discussion, however, I begin by sketching the nature of social space in Kerala from a historical perspective.

2.2 Social space in historical perspective.

Although today Kerala is one of the most densely populated regions on the planet [Kannan 2000:44], old Kerala²³ was notable for its spaciousness. Even as late as the 1970s, Fuller writes,

The settlement pattern in almost all of Kerala is dispersed; the houses are scattered across the countryside more or less haphazardly, rather than arranged in streets and clustered together in nucleated villages, as is the case in most of the rest of India. [1976:25]

Not only were houses not concentrated together, but houses of people of different *jātis* also seem to have been rather haphazardly interspersed. The area in which we lived at the edge of Thrissur can be taken as representative of settlement patterns, in an area that a generation ago consisted mostly of paddy fields that was a separate *pañcāyattū* outside of the city of Thrissur. The area now consists of streets lined with houses, but almost all have been built within the past twenty-five years. There are only a few older houses, and these houses belonged in the past to people of different *jātis* and religions: next to the temple is a Brāhman *mana*;²⁴ the area which our house had been built upon was formerly a Nāyar *taṛavāṭṭū*; an old Muslim

23. By 'old Kerala', I echo the usage of Jeffrey (1992:19-33) and refer to Kerala up to the first half of the 20th century, by which time the stage was set for the communist government to be elected and radical social changes to be implemented. Thulaseedharan (1977) similarly uses the term "traditional Kerala" to refer to the first decade of the 20th century:

It was the time when the rays of a new dawn had begun to fall on Kerala society. Many of the traditional aspects which had gone unchallenged for centuries came to be seriously questioned, although it took time for changes to set in. [1977:xi]

24. The *mana* and *taṛavāṭṭū* are the joint family 'house and land units' (Moore 1983), which have now been legally dissolved. Their properties have now been partitioned, often several times over.

house lies a furlong or two west;²⁵ an Īzhava *taravāṭṭu* lies to the north; and an old Christian house is to the northeast. In contrast to the area's present appearance of small houses crowding together on small plots of land, the area was in the not-so-distant past perhaps characterized more by the spaces between the houses than the houses themselves.

Even though the houses were not close together, people of all kinds were to some degree navigating the same spaces in the surrounding area. The space was not shared easily, however, as the practice of 'distance pollution' makes clear. Concomitant with the unusual settlement pattern, in Kerala there also existed an unusually severe implementation of caste distinctions. Unlike the rest of India, where the touch of someone of a 'low' *jāti* pollutes someone of a 'high' *jāti*, in Kerala such pollution could be contracted merely through spatial proximity; touch was not requisite. This phenomenon is known as distance pollution [*tīṇṭal*]. Thulaseedharan (1977) and Fuller (1976:35) cite exact measurements at which one kind of person pollutes another. As Fuller notes, such measurements in feet were not absolute -- indeed, one wonders from where these various sources derived them -- but can only be understood relative to the lived spaces in which people interacted (or avoided interacting), such as the gate of a compound, a courtyard, or the first step of a verandah (1976:43-44). Thus a Nāyar landlord would stand on the verandah and shout instructions to 'untouchable' workers who remained outside the compound wall (Fuller 1976:44). I quote Thulaseedharan not

25. A furlong is one-eighth of a mile. This unit of measurement is in common use in Malayālam.

because the specific caste or sub-caste names and relationships are important for this study, but rather simply to provide a sense of the complexity of the 'system' as it existed a century ago:

The approach of the eleven polluting castes from Izhavan to Paravan within thirty six feet polluted the Brahmins. The Izhavas were said to pollute a Nayar from twelve paces. The Kanakkans had to keep at a distance of forty eight feet from high caste Hindus. They polluted Izhavas by touch. They also polluted the Kammalans and the Valans, but at a short distance. They were not allowed to approach the temples controlled by the upper castes. The Kutans also had to keep at a distance of forty eight feet from the Brahmins, Kshatriyas, high caste Nayars and the Antaralas. They were polluted by Pulayas, Nayatis and Ullatans. They had to stand at some distance from them. In the southern parts of the erstwhile Cochin State, the Pulayas had to keep at a distance of ninety feet from Brahmins and sixty four feet from Nayars.... The Parayas were asked to keep at 128 feet distance from Brahmins.... [A] Vetan polluted the road while he was on it, but a Pulayan polluted the road by which he had gone. [Thulaseedharan 1977:74-75]

Social space is not static, but moves or changes shape and meaning according to the ways in which human beings move about in it or through it. In order to avoid being polluted while walking along shared roads, Nāyars and other upper *jātis* of a century ago would announce their approach by shouting out '*pō!*' ['go', nonpolite imperative] in order to warn those of lower *jātis* to get out of the way. Usha Chettur's report on conditions in the same period is of interest in that it highlights the role that audible announcements played in the system:

A Nayar must keep a minimum distance of 16 feet from a Nambutiri, an Ezhava 16 feet from a Nayar, and Pulaya 48 feet from him. Besides one can get polluted by breathing the same air as a lower caste -- a windy day could wreak pure havoc. A Nayar could also get polluted by just seeing someone who was lower than a Nayar. In the interior of Malabar, where even today palanquins are used to carry people from one *tarawad* to another, the palanquin-bearers

used to chant "Ha-Ha-Ha-Ha" every weary step on the way. This was a warning to lower beings that a Nayar was approaching. The Izhavas, Parias, and others answered with "Hom, Hom, Hom" to let them know that they were there and keeping their prescribed distances. [1970, cited in Thulaseedharan 1977:75-76]

Furthermore, the arrangement was upheld by the threat and application of deadly force: if a Pulaya failed to heed the announced warning or was met accidentally on the road by a Nāyar, the Nāyar had the right to kill him on the spot, an occurrence which has been reported by visitors to Kerala for hundreds of years (Fuller 1976:12-13).

Distance pollution is no longer practiced in such an extreme form.²⁶ Even if the idea of it were not now considered distasteful, it has been rendered impossible in practice, in that mode of dress no longer reflects *jāti*,²⁷ modes of contemporary mass transportation require tight crowding, and so on (as Groesbeck (1995:122 also points out). But knowledge of the history of distance pollution in Kerala may help us to understand some contemporary practices involving loud sounds. For example, as will be discussed further below, space continues to be socially defined by transient, dynamic human presences in the practice of processions which are a crucial part of temple

26. One remnant of distance pollution was still apparent in Thrissur, in that some who go house to house begging will observe such distances. Instead of opening the gate of the compound, coming to the door, and ringing the bell, as door-to-door salespersons would do, beggars who came to our house would call out from outside of the gate, and wait out there. Some would even move behind the gate posts when we came out; we were told that it was so that we could avoid having to see them.

27. A European missionary wrote in 1884 that "Anyone after living a little while in the country can at first glance tell to what caste a stranger belongs by the way he or she wears the hair or their garments" (quoted in Jeffrey 1992:20).

festivals and Catholic feasts. The model of announcing the arrival of a 'superior' being, or signifying military or political power, carries over into festival processions. In Brāhmanical Hindu processions in Tamilnadu, a chariot bearing the deity is accompanied by the so-called *maṅgalavādyam* ['auspicious instruments'] or *pēriya mēḷam*, the ensemble of *nāgasvaram* and *takil*, but far out in front of them, an ensemble of *paṛayan* ['pariah'] drummers will announce the procession, preparing the way for their passage. Relatedly, but perhaps with different caste connotations, Christian processions in Kerala are sometimes still preceded by the beating of a very large kettledrum called the *nakāra*, which due to its size must be pulled on a wooden cart, at the very beginning of the procession. This drum was formerly "played at the gates of royal palaces . . . at dawn and sunset as a sign of royalty" (Rajagopalan 1974:49).²⁸

2.3 Explosives, shared space, and the love of noise.

One can very frequently hear the sounds of firecrackers and larger explosives in Thrissur. Explosives are a key part not only of Christian and Hindu festival celebrations and Christian processions, but also of daily devotional practice in many temples, where they serve as an offering to the deity. Outside the front gate of Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan Temple at the center of Thrissur, for example, a red banner and a red metal sign with

28. Variations of this drum are common elsewhere in South Asia (e.g., Tingey 1992), as well as across Asia and into Europe (Philip Bohlman, personal communication). In Kerala, its sole remaining use is in these Catholic processions.

Śivan's mantra *Ōṃ nama śivāya* at the top both alert visitors in Malayālam, Tamil, and English²⁹ that the "MAIN OFFERING TO SREE VADAKKUNATHAN" [*śrī vaṭakkunāthanù pradhāna vazhipāṭù*] is "POPGUN FIRING" [*veṭivazhipāṭù*]. The *katinaveṭi* are set off there every morning at 3:00 a.m. as well as following each *pūja*.

Explosives are also blown off at times of elections, weddings, and any number of other occasions. Near the beginning of our stay in Thrissur, I asked an acquaintance about the firecrackers I was hearing:

EK: It seems like almost every day I hear firecrackers coming from somewhere, morning and evening. Some festival somewhere?

PM: Yeah. Small elections. Not only for festivals, for election, for marriage; everything they will --

EK: Why, do you think?

PM: Just to make the other people know that something is happening here. [When you hear] that some crackers is going on, naturally your interest will come out to know what is going on. So you will go and ask.

EK: That's true, it works!³⁰

Explosives are clearly about traversing space, about announcing an event to as great an audience as possible. When I was asking about the purposes of celebratory or religious explosives, one origin story I heard more than once clearly

29. The sign is in these languages for the benefit of visitors from Tamilnadu and from North India, not for foreign tourists; the temple is open for entry only to Hindus.

30. At least it 'worked' for me, in that I generally did try to find out what was going on. However, I have many examples on tape of conversations I was having which were interrupted by massive explosions coming from somewhere nearby which I found very jarring -- and my interlocutor didn't even blink, but just continued speaking, as if absolutely nothing had happened.

indicated a very specific relationship to social space, and historical anxieties surrounding the idea of many different categories of people sharing close quarters. This account began by reiterating the fact that in earlier days people didn't live as they do today, crowded in cities, that instead they lived at great distances from each other, spread out throughout the land. Thus the only time people got together in large groups was for temple festivals. People who weren't used to close contact with others might not have strong immune systems, and so disease could spread easily. According to this account, igniting gunpowder releases sulphur, which has the capacity to clear or 'purify' the atmosphere, to destroy germs, and thus to prevent against the spread of infectious diseases. Therefore, the reason that fireworks were blown off at large gatherings was not the resulting sound, but rather the explosion's effect as essentially a public health measure. In a slight variation of this story, *veṭikkeṭṭū* are blown off on a daily basis at temples like Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan for the same reason.

What is interesting about this account is that the language of 'pollution' which may have been used in the past has been replaced by a medicalized language of 'infection'. Whether the biomedical language is Hindu or Western, however, it is clear that what is at issue is minimizing the consequences of transactions between people, in Marriott's (1990, 1976) sense, when they are gathered together closely and contact is unavoidable. This account falls short, however, because it lacks any reference to the actual sound of the explosions, which is certainly more than incidental.

Although the words *kaṭinaveṭi* and *veṭikkeṭṭu* are generally translated as 'popguns' or 'firecrackers', I have been referring to them here as 'explosives' in order to indicate the magnitude of sonic power which is sought after and achieved by their use, but which is not conveyed by the word 'crackers'. The force of explosions that one hears, especially within large temple festivals, is intense. The frame of reference for such explosives is the famous Thrissur *pūram* festival, where a so-called 'fireworks display' which is one of the main attractions. This display places no emphasis on visual dazzle; the bright flashes are incidental, and what is valued are high decibel levels. Residents of Thrissur practically boast about the fact that many storefronts around the Round will have their windows shattered by the magnitude of the explosions; all of the proprietors tape their windows to try to prevent it. The evening before the main 'fireworks display', which occurs at 3:00 a.m., a 'sample display' is held so that families (i.e., women and children) can attend. The sample display has all the magnitude of the actual display, and indeed, although I did not attend, I could physically feel the shockwaves from our house approximately five kilometers away. The thunderous sound of this display from five kilometers distance can be heard on Track 5 of the CD.

Thrissur *pūram* is an extreme example, but with that festival as a point of comparison, no explosives are too loud for other celebrations. The Malayāḷam new year's holiday, Viṣu, celebrated on 14 April in 2001, began promptly at 4:00 a.m. with firecrackers being blown off in all directions, continuing more or less constantly for several hours. Near and far, one's hearing was full of explosions, some regular, describing the

speed at which someone could light one, then another, then another, and some going off in clusters, describing the interwindings of fuses in a package. As a part of Christian processions, too, where the procession accompanied by a brass band stops at each sponsoring home on its route, fireworks and explosives are used very liberally at each stop. In the following journal entry, I describe my experience of one of these nighttime processions in a village area on the outskirts of Thrissur, as I was walking away from it:

As I walked farther, the screaming clarinets and trumpets and pounding drums stayed with me; they covered quite a distance out there away from traffic noises. With the clarinets and trumpets spreading throughout the sound environment, much larger explosions began. It was a constant roar, punctuated with steady, louder, pops, and it sent a plume of smoke gradually into the air, higher and higher. It rose and spread, larger and larger as the fireworks continued, reflecting and refracting the flashes from the ground. After the noises stopped, the cloud continued spreading over the area, and I was reminded of the idea that sulphur in the air is supposed to halt bacteria, to purify the air.

G.S. Paul, a well-known music critic who writes on Karnātak and traditional Kerala music for *The Hindu* newspaper, thought of Malayālis as "noise-loving", attributing this essential quality to the characteristics of the natural environment. In the following conversation, I have been asking about the widespread use of popguns as offerings, and firecrackers at festivals. In response, G.S. Paul suggests that festivals 'reproduce' the noise and loudness which he associates with thunder and other natural phenomena not only in the ubiquitous explosives, but also in the performing arts:

GSP: That's why people assemble, to see and listen to this noise. Everywhere in Thrissur, *pūram*, *Vaṭakkāñceri*, even at churches. People are noise-loving, no doubt.

The geographical features also. Look at the rains that we have. The thunder and lightning.

EK: Is there a lot of loud thunder?³¹

GSP: Oh [yes], June July August, heavy heavy rains and the sound it produces. And also the seashore, the waves. All these things must have affected. And the forest, the wind, everything -- such factors are there naturally. They are reproducing the whole thing in the temple festival, that's what I have felt.... The geographical features have influenced the performing arts, the artistic outlook of Kerala.

2.4 *Pañcavādyam*: 'maximum sound'.

It has been widely observed that Kerala's indigenous arts are based fundamentally on drumming and rhythmic compositions. G.S. Paul's sentiment, expressed above, sheds light on a key aspect of the music of Kerala from an experiential point of view. Beginning with the topic of explosives, he articulates a sympathy between these and the loudness of natural phenomena such as thunder; the recording of the *pūram* 'sample fireworks display' in the distance on Track 5 is certainly illustrative of this connection. He then sees such qualities as a basis for Kerala's indigenous temple festival arts, i.e., noise in its more organized form as *mēḷams*, or drumming ensembles.³²

Such felt connections indicate that the significance and impact of Kerala musics cannot be explained with reference only

31. At the time of this interview, I had not yet experienced the monsoon in Kerala.

32. I use the word 'organized' with reference to John Blacking's famous definition of music as "sound that is organized into socially acceptable patterns" (1995:33).

to analyses of their complex rhythmic structures, or in other words, to the way the music unfolds in time. Instead, a cultural account of indigenous Kerala drumming ensembles must include an understanding of the way they exist in space. Specifically, by virtue of the central role played by sheer loudness, the sound of these ensembles is capable of bridging or transcending open spaces. By virtue of what the ethnomusicologist Charles Keil (1994b [1987]) has called 'participatory discrepancies', their music can furthermore create a subjective space of sonic immersion. In this section I seek to provide the beginning of such an account with specific reference to the role of the *kompū* ['horn'] in Kerala drumming ensembles.

G.S. Paul's above quote expresses an aspect of 'Malayāḷiness' which I heard talked about elsewhere as well. While *kathakālī* and *kūṭiyāṭṭam* may be the artforms that represent Kerala on the world stage, within Kerala the *pañcavādyam* orchestra seems to be a more potent sign of a Kerala cultural distinctiveness.³³ The *pañcavādyam* has its origins as a

33. A *mēḷam* such as *pañcavādyam* can include up to 150 musicians or more, who assemble on the grounds surrounding a temple. *Pañcavādyam* is Sanskrit for 'five instruments', and the ensemble accordingly features five kinds of instruments, but many of each. Three of the instruments are classified as *avanadha* or membranophonic: *maddalam*, *iṭaykka*, and *timila*. The *ilattālam* or cymbals are *ghanam* or idiophonic, and finally the lone wind instrument, or *suṣiram*, is the *kompū*. Finally, the beginning of each performance is marked by a blow on the conch, or *sankham*, which is usually performed by one of the *iṭaykka* players. Prescriptive numbers of each instruments are given as follows:

There are major and minor groups. The minor group has eleven *thimilas*, five *maddalams*, eleven *elathalams*, eleven *kombus*, two *edakkas* and one *sankham*, while the major set has fifteen *thimilas*, eight *maddalams*, fifteen *elathalams*, fifteen *kombus*, two or more *edakkas* and one or more *sankhams*. [Omcherry 1999:173]

crucial part of any major temple festival, but has come so much to signify a defining feature of Kerala culture in an inclusive, state-level sense, that *pañcavādyam* musicians now get a large percentage of their work playing for state festivities such as Republic Day and Independence Day parades, for political rallies, and for dedication ceremonies or advertising campaigns for newly opening jewellery shops, TV shops, financing companies, and so on. That the genre now transcends its Hindu origins is shown by the fact that it has also become a key part of many Christian church festivals and even large Christian weddings.

The distinguished musicologist L.S. Rajagopalan, as well as musicians that I knew, often made sense of Kerala's traditionally drum-based music by similarly positing something like a musical 'national character' among Malayāḷis, such that listeners are concerned more with rhythmic energy and noise than they are with melody or intonation. To support this claim they point to notable absences in Kerala's musical culture. First, Karnātak music, the 'classical' music of South India, is in fact considered to be foreign to Kerala. Its centers are in Tamilnadu, Andhra Pradesh, and Karnataka; its history in Kerala dates back only 250 years to the rule of Swati Tirunal in Thiruvananthapuram. The second absence is the impoverished development of string or wind instruments in Kerala compared to within the Karnātak or Hindustani traditions elsewhere in India. Instead, I was told, Kerala's musical genius has expressed

These numbers are not absolute in practice, although the general proportions tend to remain similar. Furthermore, smaller groups are common for smaller-scale events.

itself in the extended and complex rhythmic patterns and interplays upon which the temple music traditions such as *tāyampaka* and *pañcavādyam* are based. In fact, the legend of Karnātak music's introduction to Kerala depends upon this rhythmic achievement. Two and a half centuries ago, Swati Tirunal -- who while perhaps an ineffectual ruler was a very prolific composer and skilled musician -- wanted to bring the renowned composer and saint, Tyāgarāja, from Tanjavur to his palace in Thiruvananthapuram, in order to learn from the master. In order to entice him to come, he sent the legendary drummer, Ṣaṭkāla Govinda Mārār, from the Kerala Mārār *jāti* which specializes in drumming, as a messenger. But the devotee and saint Tyāgarāja was not interested in going to any palace, and refused. That evening Ṣaṭkāla Govinda Mārār performed for Tyāgarāja, and he sang one *aṣṭapadi* in six tempos [*ṣaṭkāla*], which astounded and won over Tyāgarāja. Even now, one storyteller said, three is the maximum, but this Mārār was able to reach six tempos because he belonged to the drumming profession and community.

And yet this cultural rhythmic genius is not separable from the production of sheer loudness, and commentators such as G.S. Paul quickly stray from the realm of what is strictly 'musical' in their discussions about it. Emphasizing the point that Malayāḷis are inherently rhythmically inclined, G.S. Paul furthermore noted:

The greatest *mṛdaṅgam* artist that India has ever seen was a Keralite, Palakkad Mani Iyer. Only recently I mentioned [in an article in *The Hindu*] his contributions. Because, perhaps the main contribution of Kerala is this: because of the geography, season, climate, torrential rains -- sound! noise! So, all the percussion ensembles, *mēḷams*, produce maximum sound. A hundred chendas, sometimes 120

chendas are there! Look at the noise that is coming out! But that is a different art. So here, the Kerala people are more rhythm oriented, and they know how to produce an art with noise. I will always say noise. Because, forget about 100 chendas, with five chendas you cannot tune them to the same *śruti* [pitch].

In his consideration of the issue of why drumming is so central in the music of Kerala, Groesbeck (1995:147-164) traces Kerala music and instruments back to the Tamil Śaṅkam literature of the first few centuries CE, before Malayāḷam became a separate language, and finds close parallels. In Śaṅkam literature, we find that *tūmpu* ['horn'] has a status equal to that of *kompū* ['horn'] in contemporary Kerala genres, i.e., it is used as a rhythmic instrument, and that *kuzhal* [a simple double-reed instrument] is also significant in both. Furthermore, in both the Śaṅkam literature and in contemporary Malayāḷam, he notes that there is no general word for 'drum', and that instead, drums and horns fall into the same category. Groesbeck surmises, and I agree, that the fact that these instruments fall into the same category indicates that

the most important criterion for the instruments ... must have been their loudness, and most, but not all, of the loudest instruments were drums. ... [T]he combination of drums with *kuZals* and *kompūs* (in *mēLam*), as in Sangam literature, suggests the importance of noise for its own sake. [1995:161, 275-76]

2.5 *Kompū* as icon of amplification.

If we take up the suggestion of G.S. Paul, L.S. Rajagopalan, and others, that there is a culturally-rooted disposition for noise as noise, or a fondness for loudness, then we needn't look further than the *kompū* as an important musical instrument which embodies sheer amplification. The *kompū*

(literally 'horn' in Malayālam and Tamil, as in the horn of an animal; see Figure 2.3) plays a unique and crucial role in this rhythm section.

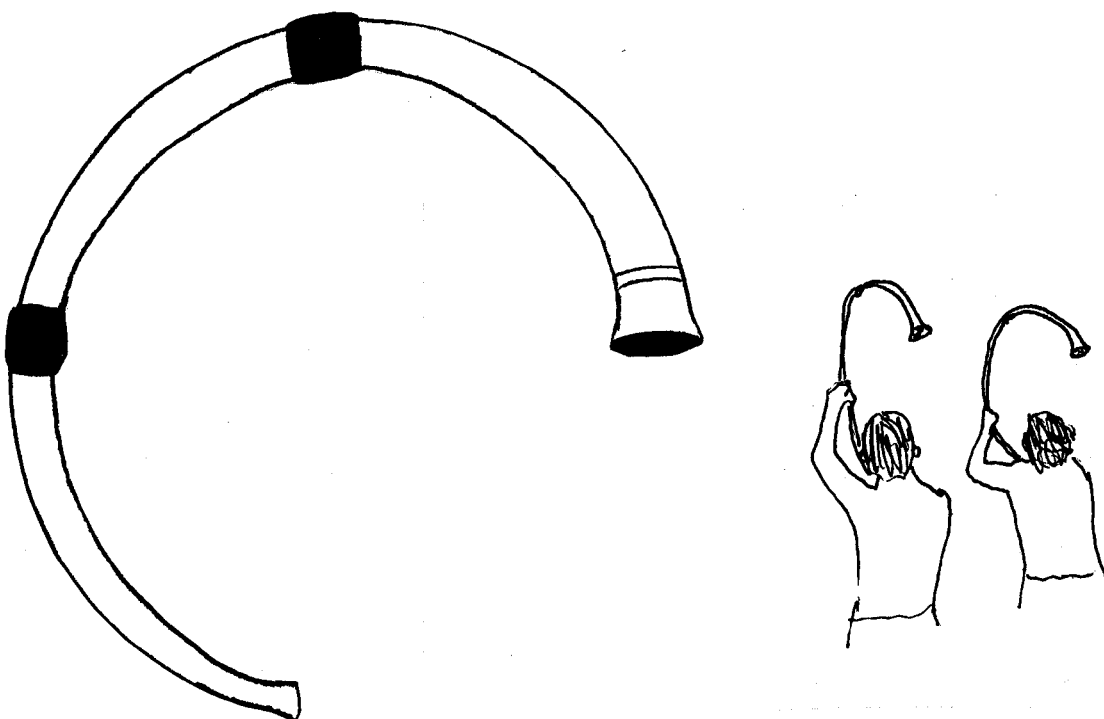


Figure 2.3 A *kompū*.

The *kompū* is roughly in the shape of the letter C, with a total length of about 160 centimeters and a diameter of about 72 centimeters, and is held up over the head, supported by the left arm extended nearly straight upwards and the right hand gripping it near the mouthpiece. It is made of bell-metal, is conical, and is built of three pieces which are fitted together and sealed with wax. At present there is only one *kompū* maker in

all of Kerala, P.V. Rāman of Pērāmaṅgalam in Thrissur District.³⁴ There are two sizes for different purposes, the smaller *tīmiri* and the larger *bari*, the latter of which is in more common usage today, and which is used almost exclusively in *pañcavādyam*.³⁵ The horn is played much like a trumpet or bugle, by blowing while buzzing the lips into the mouthpiece. The pitches most easily accessible are the harmonics at the bottom of the overtone series, in particular the second and third harmonics, which correspond to *pa* and *sa*, or in the terms of Western music theory, dominant and tonic. *Kompū* players use these two pitches exclusively as they play along with the *pañcavādyam* orchestra. *Pa* is generally used as a springboard to *sa*, and *sa* is repeated in different rhythmic patterns depending upon the stage of the *mēḷam*.

Thus, as L.S. Rajagopalan points out below, although the *kompū* is a *suṣiravādyam* or wind instrument, it serves a rhythmic function. Note that Rajagopalan suggests at the same time that the appropriation of a wind instrument for rhythmic purposes owes itself to something essential about 'the Keralite':

unlike other wind instruments this is not used for melody but only as a Laya ['rhythm'] or Tala ['meter'] instrument.... The Keralite has a special aptitude for Laya and he has raised this instrument from its primitive

34. I visited him in order to have a *kompū* made myself. As a trumpet player, I had an affinity for the instrument.

35. L.S. Rajagopalan notes the following:

Formerly only the Thimiri instruments were being used in temples. The Bari instrument is comparatively of recent origin. It came into prominence with the development and refinement of Pancha Vadya by Venkichan Swamy. Of late Bari instrument is mainly used, the Thimiri is found more with Harijans who use it for their folk festivals. [1973:173]

levels to that of a classical instrument for Laya.
[Rajagopalan 1973:170,174]

While the instrument's pitch content may be irrelevant in theory, it is by no means irrelevant to its total effect. Instead, I am arguing that the differences in pitch between multiple *kompùs* played in unison create 'participatory discrepancies', in Keil's (1994b) sense. According to Keil,

The power of music lies in its participatory discrepancies, and these are basically of two kinds: processual and textural. Music, to be personally involving and socially valuable, must be 'out of time' and 'out of tune'.
[1994b:96].

By 'processual', he refers to aspects of rhythm such as 'beat', 'vital drive', or 'swing', and by 'textural' he refers to the timbre or tonal qualities of a sound. Regarding the former, he argues that it is the inaccuracies in rhythm which propel music rhythmically; for example, in straight-ahead jazz music, he suggests that the fact that the walking bass and the snare drum are slightly off from each other accounts for the perception that the music 'swings' (Keil 1994a [1967], 1995). For my present argument regarding *kompùs*, the latter textural or timbral aspect is more of interest. Keil bases his theory on observations of paired rather than solo trumpets in polka bands, pairs of reeds in accordions, and paired trumpets and shawms in Tibetan Buddhist ritual music. In the case of the Tibetan example, he says the following in a conversation with Steven Feld:

I began to wonder what was at stake with this music. These monks have been practicing up there for eight hundred years, every day, and this is what they have come up with. It is very timbral and textural, with an emphasis on harmonics and overtones. And I realized that their pairing of the conch shells, pairing of the shin-bone trumpets, pairing of the shawms, pairing of the bass trumpets, that all those pairings of instruments share one goal: to

maximize overtones, harmonics, and 'beats,' the throbbing of pitches rubbing against each other. I think that is one goal of music, to maximize timbres, textures, overtones, and harmonics. [Keil and Feld 1994:168-169]

As can be heard on the recording on Track 6, the intensity of the sound created by multiple *kompùs* playing in unison is due in large part to a very similar phenomenon. First, it must be noted that the instrument is almost never heard playing solo, but always in a group of at least two, and usually more.³⁶ Second, because each instrument is made by hand, there are natural variations in pitch from instrument to instrument. Individual playing style renders the pitch of any instrument naturally variable also, depending on such factors as lip tension and air pressure. The result of this variability is that no two *kompù* players are ever playing precisely the same *śruti*, or pitch. The discrepancies in pitch which tend to exist between *kompùs* can be described in terms of Western music theory as ranging from between a quarter-tone and a minor third; in general, hearing *kompùs* approximately one to two half-steps apart is quite common.

36. The only time a *kompù* might be heard by itself is if only one *kompù* player is available for the performance of *kompùpattù*, which accompanies certain temple rituals. Prescriptively, however, this form calls for several *kompù* players to play together, and is generally played by two, with accompaniment by cymbals [*ilattāḷam*] (Groesbeck 1995:177).

Another occasion where the *kompù* is featured is during the Maccāṭu Māmāṅkam festival procession near Vaṭakkāñceri, Thrissur District, each year. It is described in a press release from that festival's committee as follows:

Another distinct feature with the parayeduppu [procession] is the absence of the traditional drum which is an inseparable part of the parayeduppu processions of other temples. Here, in Thiruvaniikkavu, it is the horn-like wind instrument 'Kombu' in accompaniment with Kuzhal that are mandatorily played. The shrill clarion of Kombu played in its classical rhythm, unmistakably announcing the approach of the parayeduppu procession, will reverberate in one's mind for days together.

Aside from the issue of *śruti*, which as I have said is not explicitly theorized within the system, the role of the *kompū* is to increase energy and volume, where 'volume' includes the senses of three-dimensional space and of amplitude. Indeed, the *kompū* essentially acts as an amplifier. At the point at which the *kompūs* join in, at the climactic final section of each stage in the composition, or *kalāśam*, they amplify the part of the *timila* drum, mirroring it rhythmically, but raising and spreading the overall sound of the group. When the *pañcavādyam* is playing along with an elephant procession, the moment is synaesthetically amplified by the visual flourishes which L.S. Rajagopalan describes as follows:

Before the start of the Kalasam all the *Kombus* will get ready by blowing the lower note. The people on top of the elephants holding the Alavattom (peacock-feather fan) and Venchamaram (Yak tail Swish) will take their cue and stand up holding their fan and swish ready. When the Kalasam is played the swish is waved. This is one of the most picturesque sights of the elephant procession in Kerala. [1973:175]

At large festivals, *pañcavādyams* are always surrounded by crowds of men (never women) who pack in tightly and enthusiastically wave their arms along with the rhythms. At the moment at which the *kompūs* begin playing, cheers inevitably arise from the crowd; the blasting horns, frequencies beating against each other microtonally, raise the total sound to the next energy level, in terms of both affect and decibels.

The *pañcavādyam* thus embodies two kinds of space-making. On one hand it traverses great distances, and announces an occurrence, as explosions do. The extra loudness provided by the *kompūs* at specific moments in the composition increase the ensemble's ability to project itself across the open spaces of

empty paddy fields which were its traditional performance situations. By filling this space, the sound announces the festivities to all who inhabit it, thereby establishing a connection between the temple whose festival is being celebrated and each hearer, and thus adding to the grandeur and reputation of the temple. On the other hand, and at the same time, the 'dissonance' or diffuse pitch area of the *kompù* contributes crucially to heightened emotional effect for the men gathered close by, by creating a kind of immersive psychic space. The sound of five, or seven, or nine, or more *kompùs* playing in unison but 'out of tune' is filled with participatory discrepancies whose effect on those gathered closely around is one of sonic immersion. This cultural model of sonic immersion is taken up further in the following discussion of *bhajana*.

2.6 *Bhajan*s and the construction of psychological space.

Sound is commonly used to transform a space where people are already gathered into a specific kind of shared subjective space. Anthropologists and ethnomusicologists have long noted the ubiquity of some kind of organized sound in rituals around the world, although they haven't always agreed on how to interpret or understand it (e.g., Needham 1967; Blacking 1968; Rouget 1985). Delineating a religious space with sound is a well-elaborated cultural model within Indian religious practices, especially Hinduism, but carrying over into Christian practices as well (see Chapter Four).

In certain Hindu philosophies, such as Śaiva Siddhānta, the primordial godhead is described as being in the form of sound,

or *nāda brahman* (Beck 1993; Dhavamony 1971; Soni 1989). The manifest world is the outward vibration of this primordial *nāda*, and by extension, there is an inherent connection between a name (conceived as a particular sound) and that which is named. As a result, a name of god is understood as itself a manifestation of divinity; chanting the name(s) of god(s) in the form of *mantra* is thus to fuse oneself directly with the divine (Alper 1989; Coward and Goa 1991). Understood in psychological rather than spiritual terms, chanting *mantra* is a technique of using sound to focus one's concentration on the idea of the divine.

This theory of *mantra* also underlies the practice of *bhajana* singing. *Bhajan*s are repetitious songs which consist of little more than the names of deities, sung by a group of devotees with the express intent to transform their subjective experience into one which allows for the interpenetration of devotional or divine essences into themselves. In this way, a specific kind of psychological or spiritual space is created.

Bhajana is a functional music. The function of *bhajana* is to create a particularly exclusive space, a space which is characterized by including only the desired object of concentration, and excluding everything from outside, a space which is postulated and valorized by the religion and performed by members of the religious community. The focus of *bhajana* singing is on those doing the singing, rather than on an audience. It is a form of meditation, not far removed from that of chanting mantras, but one that relies even more on the ability of sound to carry the full weight of one's concentration, by virtue of the model of sonic immersion.

In Thrissur, *bhajana* singing continues to hold an important place in temple practices, though one which has changed significantly in recent years. A generation ago, it was relatively common for individuals to gather at a neighborhood temple either in the morning or evening in order to sing *bhajan*s together. A group of men I spoke with at a Nāyar-owned Subramaniam temple in Thrissur spoke of the old days where people of the surrounding area would meet at the temple to sing *bhajan*s together for an hour after *dīpārādhana*, the closing *pūja* of the day. Given today's economic realities, however, the practice has disappeared, something these men saw as an unambiguous sign of cultural decline:

When you're working in companies, you won't be able to return home by 5:30 or so [for singing *bhajan*s], and the new generation is not taking an active interest. They are supposed to be doing this [*cheyyantatāna*], but they are not. We are working and unable to come back in time. Our great culture is eroding day by day.

Today, the only *bhajan*s to be heard at mainstream temples on a regular basis are played back on cassette tape. At festival time, some committees may hire professional troupes to perform a stage program, either on the same stage which has been set up for the *gānamēḷa* (cinema song) program, or on a smaller stage nearer to the temple.³⁷ Here, the model is one of entertainment rather than of participation.

However, participant-centered *bhajana* singing remains a central practice of a few specific cults. The most popular of these is the cult of Ayyappan, for which a large percentage of Hindu men undertake the 41-day period of fasting, celibacy, and

37. The significance of spatial configurations/significations of temple festival performances is discussed in Chapter Three.

other self-regulatory behaviors before making a pilgrimage to the temple of Ayyappan at Sabari Mala (see Daniel 1984 for a detailed analysis of this pilgrimage). During the *mandalam* period when the pilgrimage happens,³⁸ Ayyappan *bhajan*as can be heard blaring over temple loudspeakers, and groups of pilgrims can often be heard singing *bhajan*as themselves, sometimes at temples but more often at specially-erected *paṇṭals* both during the period of preparation as well as en route. The aid of microphones and amplification is generally held to be crucial.

Sonic immersion through the singing of *bhajan*as is also a central practice of two other cults of great popularity in Kerala, both of which are led by charismatic leaders: that of Mātā Amṛtānandamāyī, and the Art of Living movement of Sri Sri Ravishankar. Sri Sri Ravishankar is a guru-type figure, while Mātā Amṛtānandamāyī, a woman from a poor Kerala village who is also known as the 'hugging mother' or simply as Amma ['mother'], is actually worshiped as an incarnation of the goddess.³⁹ At the Mātā Amṛtānandamāyī Maṭham in Thrissur, one of many throughout Kerala and other parts of India, devotees gather each Sunday morning at 8:00 to engage in group meditation and prayer. The major part of the gathering consists of singing *bhajan*as or chanting mantras together, while playing on rhythm instruments. To add to the effect, microphones are used and the mantras are highly amplified, and delay and reverb effects are used to add grandeur. The Art of Living movement emphasizes silent

38. The *mandalam* period begins on the first day of *vṛścikam* month, in mid-November.

39. For a recent hagiography of Mātā Amṛtānandamāyī, see Cornell (2001). For Sri Sri Ravishankar, see URL <http://www.artofliving.org>.

meditation, but *bhajan*as are also a regular part of their practice. At the regular meetings held in a hall above a supermarket in Thrissur, microphones and loudspeakers help those gathered to be fully enveloped in the *bhajan*as they are singing.

Both groups held large-scale gatherings attracting thousands to the Tekkinkāṭu Maidān, the large area surrounding Śrī Vāṭakkunāthan Temple, while I was in Thrissur. The main attraction of Amma's gatherings is that she hugs and blesses each of her devotees, which can take all night. But the most palpable outward sign of her presence was the massively amplified, trance-inducing *bhajan*as that went on and on for hours and hours, as Amma hugged her devotees one by one. Sri Sri Ravishankar's event was a very interesting mixture of silent meditations, pithy pronouncements about the universality of humanity, and hugely amplified *bhajan*as. In fact, I was at our house about five kilometers away when the meeting started, and heard it from there. I left the house to see where the music was coming from, and to my astonishment, I followed the sound on my bicycle all the way to the Round at the center of town. The sound operators told me afterwards that they were using 20,000 watts of amplification. In the case of both gatherings, the sonic immersion model was plainly in operation.

2.7 Processions.

Another paradigmatic conjunction of loudness and shared space is the procession. India has a highly developed cultural model of processions; they are an integral part of religious functions of all kinds as well as life-stage celebrations such

as weddings, and in Tamilnadu they have also become a feature of temple festival-like political extravaganzas (Bate 2000:132-182). In Kerala, Catholic Christian 'feasts', too, are celebrated with processions.

One function of a temple festival procession is to transform the space which it traverses from the mundane space of daily business and comings and goings, to a sacred space. The mechanics of how this works is analogous in inverse fashion to the archaic practices concerning distance pollution described above. Recall that according to some reports from the past, 'untouchables' could not only pollute a high-caste person through proximity, but actually polluted the road itself while they traversed it (Thulaseedharan 1977:75); the space itself was transformed by virtue of the perceived nature of the beings occupying it.

An important means by which processions transform the space they traverse is loud sound. Processions are never silent affairs, but are rather always as loud as possible, announcing their approach and their passage far and wide.⁴⁰ We have already seen that *pañcavādyam* is used to such an effect in certain Hindu processions. Christian processions are by no means outdone by their Hindu counterparts when it comes to maximizing sonic presence. For example, the occasion of St. Sebastian's Feast, often referred to as *ampū perunṇāl*, is celebrated at every church. For this festival, the arrow [*ampū*] of St. Sebastian is carried out in procession to all Christian homes -- and many

40. This aspect of processions also brings to mind the days of distance pollution, specifically the high-caste practices of audibly announcing their approach, as discussed above.

Hindu homes -- in the vicinity of the church, with the accompaniment of a brass band or 'bandset', or less commonly, *śinkāri mēḷam*.⁴¹ Bandsets, which are discussed more fully in Chapter Three, consist of trumpets, clarinets, euphonium, and drums, and perform arrangements of the popular cinema songs of the day at top volume. At each home, the bandset plays a song or two, and firecrackers and small explosives are discharged as the procession moves on to the next. Each neighborhood forms a committee which is responsible for sponsoring its own procession, and thus there are many processions going on simultaneously, all of which meet up at the church sometime after midnight. On Track 7, for example, after the processions have all joined together, several bandsets can be heard simultaneously, to Ivesian effect.

Section 3. Hearing broadcasts.

The lengthy excursion of the previous section has, I hope, provided a sense of the cultural and musical context in which technology of the twentieth century has enabled temples and churches, among others, to broadcast sound through outwardly directed loudspeakers, into shared lived environments. We now return to the issue of these broadcasts, and address the questions of what the amplified broadcasts signify and how they

41. *Śinkāri mēḷam* is a recent innovation for an ensemble of *ceṇṭas* and *ilattāḷam* which involves cyclically increasing and decreasing tempos, and choreographed movements by the drummers. It is not performed by *Mārārs*, the traditional Hindu drumming *jāti*, and *Mārārs* I knew spoke disparagingly of this genre.

function in the perception of those who live in their surrounding community.

3.1 The semiotics of broadcasts.

Amplified sound coming from temples every morning and every afternoon signifies above all that a temple is alive and well, although the world which the broadcasts now confront is a more complicated one in many ways than the world in they began. The broadcasts from temples must be seen in the context of social, political and economic changes that have been taking place in Kerala for a half-century. The most significant economic changes faced by temples were those brought on by Land Reforms, after the final implementations of which in 1970, temples were left with nothing more than the plot of land occupied by the temple itself.⁴²

Following these radical economic shifts, when temples began to be revived, it was under circumstances that reflected democratic rather than 'feudal' values. This is to say that the affairs of each temple are managed by committees made up of representatives from the immediate area of the temple, rather than autocratically by the Nampūtiri (Brāhman) or Nāyar family which may have run the temple previously.⁴³ Thus the temple was

42. The ramifications of land reforms for the structure of patronage of traditionally temple-based artforms are addressed in Chapter Three.

43. Temples in Thrissur are managed bureaucratically by the Cochin Devaswom Board; in the south the governing body is the Travancore Devaswom Board.

now explicitly oriented towards and depended for its survival upon the community, rather than a single family. Furthermore, the community which a temple served was explicitly diverse, in terms of *jāti*: state law specifies that committees of temples which come under the Devaswom Board must contain a modest number of representatives from different caste communities, specifically including Īzhavas.⁴⁴

At the broadest level of generality, then, and on a level at which nearly everyone would agree, the broadcasts signify renewed life and prosperity. They announce not only that 'rituals are happening at this temple', but that the temple has supporters who are prosperous enough to have provided a sound system. As noted earlier, temple sound systems are linked in many people's minds to the flow of Malayāḷi laborers to the Gulf; when I would inquire about temples' sound systems, people would often casually suppose that someone had brought it from the Gulf and donated it to the temple. Of course, amplifiers and cassette players are and have been made in India as well, but what is notable is what appears to be a widespread assumption that the technology is explicitly foreign, and furthermore, derived from wealth accumulated outside the state. Indeed, its foreignness may have added to its perceived value at the time it was introduced to the temples.

44. However, a minority of temples which remain in private hands need not follow such guidelines, and may have committees that are made up very exclusively of Nāyars, as was the case with Śāṅkaramkuḷaṅgara Temple, whose festival is discussed in Chapter Three. In addition, temples run by the Īzhava-based SNDP (Śrī Nārāyaṇa Dharma Pariṣad) will likewise have committees consisting only of Īzhavas.

It is important to note that the prosperity signified by cassette broadcasts is definitely a *limited* prosperity. Playing cassettes is recognized to be a cheap second to actually having musicians to play instruments at the time of *pūja*, which only the biggest temples can afford. Cassette machines, amplifiers and loudspeakers allow any temple to play music, and temple-goers feel that it's better to have some music than no music at all. Peter Manuel (1993) shows that cassettes have had democratizing effects on regional musics in India. In an analogous way, the ability to play music from cassettes also has a levelling effect on temples, in that with the aid of a cassette player, amplifier, and loudspeakers, even a small neighborhood temple can now (re)create the sounds and vitality of a full-featured *pūja*.

The music from temples does not only signify prosperity, but according to temple committees, it helps to ensure continued prosperity. In one interview with committee members at a privately-owned Nāyar temple, after establishing that the broadcasts function in their minds as a sort of 'public service' to the surrounding community, I asked if they also benefit the temple. One member replied,

Of course! They donate to us! For our festival, the December and October and January festival, and when festival comes, people donate. We get nearly three lakhs [three hundred thousand rupees] of donation. With donation only we celebrate our festival.

Although this committee member and others rejected any likeness to advertising, in some ways it appears that a comparison may be made.

3.2 Morning music as part of an intentional world.

This ability to control the aural environment without the economic burden of supporting musicians becomes a valuable one, and electronic sound reproduction technology thus offers a new solution to an old desire. Those in control of the temple can 'engineer' the acoustic environment of the community using such technology, simply by switching on a cassette player and amplifier (Greene 1999). And for at least some of those living nearby, the sounds from the temple become a meaningful part of a culturally-constituted reality which may be described as an 'intentional' world, or in other words, a world which is

real, factual, and forceful, but only so long as there exists a community of persons whose beliefs, desires, emotions, purposes, and other mental representations are directed at, and thereby influenced by, it. [Shweder 1991:74]

The sounds contribute to an intentional world because, as I describe in this section, for those who live in it, the sounds are intimately connected with those things which are true, good, and beautiful about the world (Shweder 1991). The temple is successful in creating a shared social space among those who share the values of the temple culture.

The morning music is appreciated not just as a reminder that the temple is alive, but also because the sound causes the area to be pervaded with a devotional [*bhakti*] feeling, which has positive physiological and even environmental effects. Many of my neighbors, both Nāyars and Īzhavas, talked about how much they loved living so near to a temple, and the broadcasts were a central part of that awareness. I heard many expressions of feelings that hearing the music provides in the morning, such as

that it "gives energy", it makes a "peaceful atmosphere", and "it feels like good *bhakti*". One participant in Sri Sri Ravishankar's Art of Living movement went so far as to say that, "If you hear a very beautiful song in the morning, it is very good for your health." One temple committee member took this notion a step further, citing a 'Hindu belief' according to which the sounds of prayer or *bhajana* will "entertain or be appreciated by all the creatures in the nature", making the point that the sounds are not only intended for human benefit but for that of the whole environment.

There is something about hearing the songs in the early morning, rather than at another time, which gives them their power. Early morning seems to constitute what we might call a particular intentional zone. In the early morning, there is quiet. A day in Thrissur closes gradually, and it takes a while for the dust and smog of the day's business to clear away. But all night, the roads are nearly empty of traffic, shops are closed, and streets and neighborhoods are silent. So it is in the early morning that people can awaken and find the day fresh, rested, and new. The sweltering heat of the day has not yet come; the blindingly hot sun has not yet begun to rise. One can go outside in comfort. The roads are not yet full of pounding trucks and buses, their horns screaming, their catalytic converterless engines pouring choking smog into the air. The air has had all night to cleanse itself from these disturbances, and most people rise well before dawn in order to bathe, to worship, to take advantage of the opportunity that morning, unlike any other time of day, affords. Only some younger, college-age men and women admitted -- and then usually with an embarrassed laugh -- that they sleep until 7:00 a.m. This is

commonly seen as sleeping late, as going against an expected norm, as choosing not to participate in one aspect of a cultural reality.

Beginning the day well before dawn is an established part of Indian tradition. Hindu temples often open at four or five o'clock. In some of the most prominent temples, such as Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan Temple in the very center of Thrissur, the practice persists of firing off explosive 'popguns' [veṭivazhipāṭu] at 3:00 a.m., which hour is seen not as late at night, but as early in the morning. Such explosions are audible for a great distance in the cool, empty morning air -- up to ten kilometers, perhaps farther. It is traditionally normative for temple caste Hindus to begin the day with a bath and a trip to the temple. Pre-dawn activities thus echo the quiet and emptiness of the air by focusing on purifying the person.

The morning is the first time of day, in the sense that firstness is imbued with great import in Hindu traditions. For example, a Brāhman friend of mine would never write on a page without first writing, at the top of the page, a small insignia of Gaṇapati, the elephant-headed son of Śivan and Pārvvati, presider over beginnings. Beginnings of any endeavor are a time of vulnerability and risk, and one must be careful to allow in only auspicious influences. When we awaken in the morning, we come out of sleep and are open to influences from the environment around us. I was told that, if possible, the first thing we see, the first thing that enters us through our open eyes should be auspicious; ideally the first thing we see is an

image of the divine.⁴⁵ For this purpose, many cautious Hindus will keep an image of a deity near their sleeping area.

These parallel cultural models of firstness and of vulnerability to influences are also implicated in sonic practices. One's ears are open even before one's eyes are, lacking as we do earlids, as McLuhan pointed out (McLuhan and Fiore 1967:111). Equivalent to seeing the image of a god upon awakening is hearing the god's name. Thus for many of my neighbors, hearing devotional songs first thing in the morning allowed them to start the day with a mental peacefulness, energy, and devotion. For this reason, in previous (pre-amplification) generations, Brāhmans and other 'temple caste' Hindus found it auspicious to chant the mantra known as the *Śrī Venkatēśa Suprabhātam* in the morning. After the celebrated female vocalist M.S. Subbulakshmi recorded a beautiful version of this on cassette in 1964, it was marketed and began being played widely through temple loudspeakers.⁴⁶ It became popular in high-caste households as well. According to the owner of Kerala Sound Electricals, the largest sound system rental company in Thrissur, this particular cassette and its widespread popularity in morning temple broadcasts contributed greatly to the growth of the devotional cassette industry as a whole.

Hearing songs from a nearby temple or church has also integrated itself into local ways of marking time, cuing domestic ritual observances such as lighting the lamp as well as

45. On the importance of sight and seeing the divine in Hinduism, see Eck (1981).

46. It is still very widely played. As mentioned earlier, this cassette was played both at our local temple and the teashop in the nearby colony.

mundane passing of time. As described by a woman in her thirties who runs a small shop near our local temple,

When it is played in the temple we know that it is time to light the lamp, that it is evening, that we have to complete all the works quickly, and so on. We need not look at the watch. Early morning at 5:00 the songs will be played in the temple and church. No one has to wake me up.

It seemed a relatively common practice in both Īzhava and Nāyar homes to bolster the music from the temple with a cassette in one's own house. In the evening, for example, the cassette would be put on following domestic rites such as the lighting of the lamp. In this way a temporal as well as a spatial continuity is experientially forged between temple broadcasts and domestic observances.

Temple broadcasts have become so incorporated into daily routine that their (very rare) absence was felt by a few of my neighbors as an unpleasant lack. Śārada, an elderly woman living in a tiny house on the other side of the temple emphasized how much she and her family like hearing music from the temple (and from her neighbors' houses) by declaring that in fact, if they *don't* hear the music from the temple, then they won't feel quite right, that "there won't be a satisfaction":

We will stay thinking, 'Oh! why is the music not heard today?' if we don't hear any songs. We wake up at 5:00 listening to it. We wake up hearing the songs of the Lord. There won't be satisfaction on the day when it is not heard. We will wake up then, saying we haven't heard any *nāmam* ['names'] of the Lord, we haven't heard any songs of the Lord. Our Lord Murukan is protecting us. So we feel disappointed when we don't hear the songs of Lord Murukan.

Universalism of religion is very much part of public discourse in Thrissur, and the propensity to accept religious sentiments of any denomination carries over to the experience of devotional songs. Given the communal harmony existing in

Kerala, people of different religions seem to appreciate devotional sentiment, regardless of what religion it is centered on. Of course, this mainly applies to members of the minority religions, Christianity and Islam, since it is they who are more likely to be in an area of Hindu broadcasts. As a 36 year old Christian man said, "Whether we are Christians or Hindus we see the songs of God as same."⁴⁷

3.3 Issues and conflicts in the reception of broadcasts.

In the ways just discussed and more, many people I spoke to talked about their appreciation of the temple's broadcasts. And yet I often suspected or was given to understand that a significant percentage of my neighbors were less than fond of the sounds' incursion into surrounding homes. I now shift my analysis to some of the problems or conflicts involved with the broadcasts. The broadcasts do not simply outline a single intentional world of shared understandings of what is true, good, and beautiful, but also highlight tensions which are emergent in contemporary Kerala society. It is in the nature of urbanization and 'modernization' that new cultural models come into play, some of which may conflict with preexistent models.

47. The Hindu woman Śārada, quoted above, also communicates a version of religious universalism, but a somewhat misguided one where "everyone believes in Lord Muruka":

Here we don't have religion or caste. People from every religion will go out only after praying before Lord Muruka. There is nothing like Christian, Muslim, or *vēṭṭuvan* ['hunter', a hill tribe]. Everyone is devoted to Lord Muruka. Everyone believes in Lord Muruka.

When enough variables are introduced, even high wattage cannot create a unified social space.

In most of the conversations I had with people about the devotional music played at the temple, two aspects were continually emphasized: first, that it's music, and second, that it's devotional. In other words, how could anyone possibly object to it? Anyone who would object may be accused of either not liking music, or worse, of being opposed to the free practice of religion. But more to the point, the very notion of a modern Indian society very self-consciously includes a notion of pluralistic cooperation, which seems especially salient in Kerala. Malayālis are proud of their record of a relatively low level of intercaste or intercommunal conflict, and seem to take pains to maintain at least the appearance of harmony in conversations with an inquisitive foreigner, in most cases quite convincingly.

What's true in conversation is also true on paper. In a written, Malayālam-language survey of 82 people selected more or less at random -- or those to whom I and my assistants could easily distribute them -- only six respondents couldn't hear broadcasts at all from their homes. 57 people could hear at least a church or temple (the survey did not distinguish between them), and had positive feelings about hearing it. Only eight people could hear but were indifferent or did not comment, and only six registered any kind of negative feeling about them. While I'm certain that many people do in fact find the morning broadcasts from temples and churches inspiring, conversations I had also suggested to me that the survey results indicated the kinds of answers people are likely to give to a foreign

researcher they don't know, that is, the socially acceptable response.

There were a number of ways in which people I spoke with objected to the broadcasts, almost all of them voiced with careful attention not to be taken to be objecting either to music or to the free expression of religion. The objections voiced were of two general kinds. First, some objected not to the practice of broadcasting, but only to the specific kinds of songs being played at this particular temple. Their criticisms were not simply aesthetic, but drew attention to still-existent group allegiances and affinities, including those based on caste.

I then take up the much more commonly voiced objections which either pointed out that the nature of social space has changed and may conflict with that presumed by the practice of broadcasts, or appealed to values or models which are emergent in the process of what might be called 'modernization', with which the broadcasts may conflict. These include the idea that the broadcasts may interfere with students' ability to pursue their studies in peace, and also recent anti-'noise pollution' movements which take up a language of health and safety to campaign against the overuse of loudspeakers in general.

3.3.1 Political implications.

We have seen that members of different *jātis* and religions now live in close proximity to each other in many urban neighborhoods, and further, that for many of my neighbors, both

Hindu and non-Hindu, one function of the broadcasts is to enact a sense of community or unity in the area surrounding the temple; certainly such a purpose would appear to be intended or presupposed in the practice of broadcasting from a temple or church. And yet, although the society at large is making efforts to minimize caste differences, for some in my neighborhood, the temple's sonic transformation of space into social space had an effect opposite of what was intended: it drew attention to caste consciousness rather than smoothed it over. Conversations with families on the western side of the temple, which is characterized by a higher concentration of upper-caste Nāyar households,⁴⁸ revealed that the sounds of songs from the temple were intertwined in their hearing with recent temple politics, in which caste is a major issue.

Apparently, some months before we arrived, membership in the temple committee had turned over. The former committee was made up mostly of Nāyars, but with the required quota of Īzhavas. Following allegations of misuse and misappropriation of temple funds, a new committee made up almost completely of Īzhavas took over control of the temple. One Nāyar neighbor, for example, in perceiving that there was some 'disturbance' in the sound, or in other words that it was distorted (which was a perception that I shared), and that the songs were not being played on a strict schedule (which was not a perception that I shared), blamed these occurrences on the fact that "our own

48. Although there are more Nāyar-level families on the western side (or 'our side' as they called it, as opposed to 'that side'), there was still diversity: some families were Christian, like our next-door neighbors, and some, including the family we rented our house from, were of the Īzhava caste.

persons" were no longer on the committee. "Now everything is in disorder," she said.

Broadcasts have purportedly been used in some areas as a political weapon. I say 'purportedly' because I was never able to document a case of this happening, but what is just as significant is the existence of the *belief* on the part of my informants that it was. In one village area, for example, a temple with support from the RSS was blaring its music at very high volume into a majority Muslim area. In another village, a mosque and a temple played music at each other for days, at the beginning of Ramadan. In Thrissur, there was a story that a church was blaring music to try to oust a Hindu RSS man who lived next door, so that the church could acquire his property. In this last case, the church had yielded to pressure from the community group I discuss below to cease its broadcasts the previous year; I was unable to substantiate the claim that the church's music was intended to persuade its neighbor to vacate.

3.3.2 Schizophonia and 'involvement'.

One neighbor articulated a rare critique of the very enterprise of playing cassettes. His critique revolves around the phenomenon which R. Murray Schafer (1977:88) has termed 'schizophonia', or the separation of sounds from the contexts of their creation via recording and subsequent playback in a new context. My neighbor S. Madhavan is a well-educated man in his early 40s, fluent in English, and was a good friend of the president of the temple committee. His wife teaches in the English department at a local college, and he has two children.

According to Madhavan, playing a cassette during the time of *pūja* in the temple actually prevents the temple from achieving its purposes. At our temple, his analysis goes, because they use the same *nāgasvaram* cassette for the evening *pūja*, they play the same *rāgam* every day. An actual *nāgasvaram* player, in contrast, will change the *rāgam*, depending on a huge variety of factors, such as the day of the week, the weather, whether the moon is out, and so on. "Their *involvement* is there," he said.

Because when the original *nāgasvaram* is played by this artist [as opposed to replaying a cassette recording], without his knowledge the atmosphere is controlling him, that special atmosphere of that day or evening is controlling him. Whatever is the *rāga* he plays, that involvement is there. That's very important.

We feel these changes, the changes of the seasons, and changes in ourselves, in this music when a musician is there. But on tape, there is no variation. At the time of *dīpārādhana*, the cassette goes its way, and the *pūjārī* and the devotees each go their own way. There is no harmony between them.

Music performed by musicians, in contrast, would create harmony between all participants. Crucially, only if there is this harmony can one expect to receive the wonders one prays for, he said. "Everyone comes to the temple with their problems and seeks relief, but this temple fails to create harmony, and so people don't get relief."

3.3.3 Changing forms of social space.

The broadcasts presume a shared social space or intentional world, and one of the many aspects of this presumed social space is the uniformity of sleep schedule characteristic of an agrarian society, and the early morning 'intentional zone'

described above. However, several of my neighbors pointed out that the assumption that everyone will awaken before dawn is simply no longer accurate in the city that Thrissur has become. A small grocery owner from a Brāhman family, who sells snacks from a cart on the Round while his wife minds the shop, pointed out that it is in the nature of a city that people have different kinds of jobs, with different kinds of schedules, and that they have a hard time sleeping in the early morning if the music is too loud.

Temple broadcasts today are competing for their audience with spreading home use of media and media technology.⁴⁹ When temples began broadcasting, there was a certain exclusivity about the practice, in that as I discuss above, such audio technology was rare and thus highly valued. Now, the technology has become common, not just in the sense of being widespread or prevalent, but also, increasingly, in the sense of being without specialness. Muralīdharan, a 40 year old Hindu man, summarizes this situation at his home on the edge of Thrissur:

Ten years back, it was a very rural area, so this amplifier and tape recorder were very rare. So all the people around this temple or church, whatever it may be, were feeling good, because to hear these songs. Now it's all changed. Every family has got amplifiers, TVs, radios, everything.

The spread of media and media technology that Muralīdharan describes also entail new forms of social space, which may not be compatible with the old. The traditional and most straightforward model for a social space is one which is coincident with a physical, objective space, or in other words,

49. But not as directly as their festivals are competing with mass entertainment, as I describe in Chapter Three.

where the participants are in contiguous physical proximity, as in the example of *bhajana* singing. This is the model in which temple broadcasts operate. But with today's electronic media technology, social spaces are formed which transcend physical proximity. In the case of cinema, for example, until recently viewers of a film shared together in the experience by virtue of inhabiting the same physical space, namely that of the theater. Today in Thrissur, however, audiences watch films on the television 'mini-screen', at the same time but in different physical spaces: at noon on a Saturday one can walk down a residential street and hear the soundtrack of the same film emanating from many different houses, as it is broadcast on the government's Doordarshan channel. The physical space of each house is coterminous with its own social space, and a larger, temporally coterminous social space is formed through the broadcast of these weekend movies that is not equivalent with any particular physical space.⁵⁰

In an analogous way, households today can put on their own cassettes in the morning, in their separate spaces, if they so desire, independently of what sounds may be outside. Given that nuclear family arrangements have generally replaced joint family arrangements, the households of contemporary Kerala are more separate than at any point in the past. The manner in which space is shared has been radically affected by social reforms which have changed the nature of family structures and living

50. Soon Lee (1999) describes an analogous use of radio broadcasting to form a 'virtual' community of Muslims in Singapore. Rather than broadcasting calls to prayer from minarets, they are instead broadcast over the radio, forming an entirely voluntary and spatially dissipated community of people whose shared space is not a physical one.

arrangements. Today, people of all *jātis* live in small nuclear family arrangements, and land is divided up into small plots which are each big enough for one small house; remaining land continues to be partitioned with each new generation.

Subdividing properties and the increase in nuclear families may also have contributed to an increased emphasis on individuation and separation, on focusing inwards, into the house, rather than outwards, on larger structures of social interdependence which have traditionally characterized Indian society (Marriott 1976). This inward focus is mirrored in the fact that many families -- not only the middle class, but increasingly families which may own little else -- have the technology at their disposal that they can watch movies in their own houses, and they can put on their own devotional cassettes; they can create their own sonic environment independent from that existing outside. All of this causes some to question the relevance of the temple or church broadcasts.

The strategy most consistently used by residents of Thrissur allowed them to object to the broadcasts without criticizing either religious practices or music: by appealing to a universally shared, emergent value of Kerala's secular democratic state, that of education. Kerala society has considered education to be a high priority for over a century, and today education is more highly valued than ever.⁵¹ Today, competition is stiff for degrees that will lead to highly

51. For a history of Kerala's progress in education, see V.K. Ramachandran 2000 and 1997; Nair 1983.

desirable white-collar jobs, outside the state if possible.⁵²

Because of this, children often receive group tuition outside of school from an early age, and must spend long hours studying for batteries of exams that last for days if not weeks. The results of these exams determine the fields into which each student will be allowed to continue.

The most frequent comment that my assistant Ambika and I heard whenever anyone felt bold enough to imply that the temple broadcasts are not always completely welcome was that it can interfere with the project of education by causing troubles for young people who are studying for their exams early in the morning. While it may be socially or even cognitively problematic to suggest that songs that are of a devotional nature can also be annoying, it is unambiguously unproblematic in contemporary Kerala to support students' abilities to further their education to the highest extent possible.

However, after hearing this scores of times, Ambika and I both began to feel that it was often something people said as a socially acceptable way of voicing objections to the practice of broadcasting which may 'actually' have been grounded in a number of other issues, such as those explored here. Part of the reason we became skeptical was that the concern that the broadcasts are disturbing to children studying for their exams came from many people who didn't have young children.

52. Citing poor prospects for employment in Government or private sectors in Kerala, the Deputy Inspector General of Police, Dr. Alexander Jacob, advised those attending a career guidance seminar in Thrissur that "Keralites should discard all fancies about sticking on to the State and finding placements, and instead vigorously continue the pursuit of jobs outside the State" ("Look for jobs outside state", *The Hindu*, 30 May 2001).

Furthermore, most students that we spoke to said that they didn't study in the early morning anyway, although clearly such was the practice of the older generation.

3.4 'Sound pollution' and health.

As ambient sound levels get higher in urban areas in general -- with temple and church broadcasts as only one example -- the issue has been reframed not only in Thrissur, but throughout India, with respect to notions of health, both mental and physical, and environmental pollution. Thus various efforts have been made from the standpoint of enacting laws and enforcement to approach what is increasingly placed in the category of a public health problem.⁵³ However, the progress has been slow. As the authors of a text on environmental protection published in Allahabad comment,

[T]he movement against noise pollution seems to be not [as strong] in India as in other countries, the reason, according to environmental experts, being that most of the people in India do not consider noise as pollution but as part of routine life. [Chaturvedi and Chaturvedi 1996:54]

In Thrissur, I found that although the language of 'sound pollution' has entered into common parlance, the concept does not seem to influence behavior: for most occasions involving loudspeakers, amplifiers remain set at maximum levels.

Around five or six years ago, some residents of Thrissur started a grass-roots movement to counter what they saw as

53. This stands in ironic contrast to the idea discussed earlier in the chapter that igniting explosives in fact protects public health.

serious noise pollution in their own areas. The men who make up this group are generally well-educated, upper or upper-middle class, retired individuals who, according to one of the group's founders, want to give something back to society. They formed a group called Citizens for Better Living, or CIBEL (pronounced like 'Sybil'), to address what they perceived to be problems in the society, including traffic safety, and most extensively, noise pollution. One of the founders told the story of the groups origins as follows:

G: Looking around, we found this noise pollution is going all over the country. People are not aware that it is very damaging, creates tension, raises blood pressure and all that. As a matter of habit they do it. So we thought we could create awareness about the dangers of noise pollution, the sources of noise pollution, and the dangers.

. . . And these loudspeakers, you know, basically they are for addressing an audience, or used during the police during emergencies like fire riots etc, for quick communication with the public, to be fitted to mobile vans. Otherwise they are no use. But nobody knows, see, temples start blaring, mosques they blare five times a day, and the churches they also started, because competing with one another. See, you must compete in doing good, not in doing something bad.

EK: Temples think they are doing something good.

G: Yeah, that's what they think! [laughs]. And they think this is connected with some religious affair, so nobody dare protest. Something connected with god, how can you protest? You can't. With the religion is a very sensitive issue here. So how can you protest? So we met together, some 25 of us, and we started this CIBEL.

Working together with the Rotary Club of Thrissur, they began by creating leaflets in both Malayālam and English to educate people about the issues of sound pollution. They distributed

about 20,000 of these leaflets as an insert in people's morning newspapers throughout Thrissur and its suburbs.

The first of these leaflets bears the headline, 'REDUCE THAT NOISE - LOUD SOUND IS SLOW POISON', or in the Malayālam version, '*śabdaśalyam ozhivākkuka potujanārōgyam samrakṣikkuka!*' This leaflet targets the use of both loudspeakers and air-horns.⁵⁴ The text of the leaflet uses language of public health, individual rights, and 'civilized life', in order to make its arguments. The following excerpt illustrates its approach:

OUR CONSTITUTION guarantees the right of free speech and worship. But there is no such right to use loudspeakers during prayers, or as calls to prayer, to play songs or hymns and disturb neighbours, who have their own rights to PEACE AND QUIET. Besides, why keep these emanations LOUD AND HARSH by fitting bullhorn type speakers at the top, when they can be made SOFT AND PLEASANT by fitting box speakers inside? Many places of worship have already effected this REFORM and avoided harassment of neighbours.

The second leaflet uses even more provocative language. I first became aware of it when it was shown to me by the proprietor of a sound electricals shop. At the top of the page, there is a drawing of a horn-type loudspeaker with a devil-like head with horns and pointy teeth coming out of it, and lines indicating sound coming from its mouth. The heading reads: '*ñān maikkāsuran! sūkṣiccōḷū!*' or, 'BEWARE! I AM DEMON MIKE!'⁵⁵ The text is in the first person, from the demonic loudspeaker's point of view. I reproduce it here in its entirety, because it provides an excellent account of the group's perception of the

54. Nearly all trucks and busses throughout India are outfitted with air-horns, which are blasted almost constantly and at earsplitting (and technically illegal) levels of above 110 dB.

55. The word 'mike' is commonly used to refer to loudspeakers, rather than to microphones, in Malayālam (and Tamil) usage.

**BEWARE !
I AM DEMON MIKE !**



I'm Demon Mike popularly known as MIKASURA or MIKE DEMON. I was born about 60 years back. Since then, see how I have grown and grown. There are hundreds and thousands of me, asuras (demons), all over the place and more are coming. **No family planning for me !**

Originally I was created to address large gatherings or for instant communication with the public by law enforcement agencies, in times of fire, floods, riots, etc., when I am fitted to mobile vans. But this limitation went long back.

I have diversified my activities. Now I am blaring from street corners, atop moving vehicles and lottery bicycles, **loud m-u-sic (make-you-sick)** inside buses, vans and railway platforms and from places of worship.

People think they are using me but actually I am using them. I affect all people whether they are aware of this or not. I interfere with their work and rest. I cause irritation and tension, high blood pressure, tension head ache and nervous trouble. I disturb the working of schools, hospitals, offices and housewives in their kitchen. People lose peace of mind and get depression and even lose their sanity. **I am a significant contributing factor in the incidence of mental illness and suicides.** Along with my brother air-horn and other high tone and musical horns, who give ear-piercing shrieks, I have inflicted enormous damage on humanity and continue to do so. It is not for nothing I am called MIKASURA, the MIKE DEMON.

People think when they go to churches, mosques and temples, they are going to worship God. **But many of them actually worship me, they are MIKE worshippers, because I am installed outside much higher than the deity or the podium !** I am fully active from the early morning hours, disturbing the people of the locality by prayers, calls to prayers, songs and hymns.

The Indian Constitution guarantees only the right of free speech, expression and worship. There is no right to install me and use me and disturb others, who have their own right to peace and quiet! But see how I have been defying the Constitution itself ! It's not for nothing I'm known as MIKASURA, the MIKE DEMON.

Though man has conquered scourges like smallpox and plague, he is yet to conquer me. However, the position is different in advanced countries like the U.K. or U.S., where a person is simply not permitted to disturb others by using me. There they have realised my powers for damage and put me behind bars. My brother can not even whimper there. **I dread the day when such a situation may arise here also, when the people will come to enjoy peace and quiet, and of course, BETTER HEALTH.**

But till then, O MIKE WORSHIPPERS, UNITE AND BE DAMNED !

*MIKASURA creates nervous trouble, leading to depression, mental illness and suicide. It is not LDF or UDF ruling us. It is the very demon MIKASURA. It is not the elite who are affected by MIKASURA as they can protect themselves. It is mainly the poor and the common people who are badly affected. Should we let MIKASURA roam our streets, our sweet homes, hospitals and offices and disturb peace and quiet ?
DECIDE FOR YOUR SELF !*

- Dr. P. K. SUKUMARAN, Psychiatrist, Thrissur - 4

Figure 2.4 Demon Mike: Flyer distributed by Citizens for Better Living (CIBEL), Thrissur.

uses of loudspeakers and their strategies for combating them (see Figure 2.4). The flyer strongly frames the issue as a mental health concern, which position is emphasized by including a quote from a psychiatrist at the bottom, who declares that "MIKASURA [demon mike] creates nervous trouble, leading to depression, mental illness and suicide."

In addition to distributing these leaflets, CIBEL held seminars to discuss the problem with local civic and community leaders. According to one of the organizers, those invited included:

headmasters of schools, and chambers of commerce, and some of the important people, principals of colleges and all that, and presidents of the other clubs, Rotary Club, Lions Club and all that.... Bishop, Hindu, all that we invited. They generally don't come. Also the police and the collector, those people. Police don't come, because they fear they will get brickbats in the meeting. [laughs]

They also invited proprietors of the major sound electricals companies in Thrissur, such as Kerala Sound Electricals. The purpose of the meetings, according to this organizer, was simply to inform people about and to discuss the dangers of high sound levels. It is difficult to measure any effect their organization may have had, but through these leaflets, seminars, and regular letters to the editor of local papers, they continue to try to educate and to reduce noise levels in urban areas.

Although some legislation against noise pollution has been passed in recent years, significant challenges have been faced not only in enforcing laws but even in passing them in the first place. Chaturvedi and Chaturvedi point out that passing laws against sound pollution has been difficult from a legal point of view because in India, in contrast to in the UK, "the use of

loudspeaker assumes the status of a fundamental right by virtue of Article 19(1) and Article 25 of the Constitution" (1996:51).⁵⁶ Because of this wording of the Constitution, they argue that "probably nothing short of a constitutional amendment redefining the right of speech and propagation could come to the rescue from noise pollution" (ibid.:53).

Given my discussion of sound as a spatial phenomenon in this chapter, which made use of the old Hindu notion that *ākāśa* is the medium of sound, it is very interesting to note that the first national legislation which addressed noise pollution was the Environment (Protection) Act of 1986, which was passed in the wake of the Union Carbide disaster in Bhopal, was able to include noise under the category of an 'air pollutant', where an 'air pollutant' is defined as "any solid, liquid, or gaseous substance (including noise) present in the atmosphere" (Rosencranz, Diwan, and Noble 1991:68). In any case, the passing of this Act paved the way for the 1989 amendment of the Environment (Protection) Rules, which established prescriptive "ambient air quality standards in respect of noise" (ibid.:70) in terms of permissible decibel levels.

In recent years, however, cases have come before high courts which address the conflict between the need to protect people from noise pollution and the right to religious freedom. In a case before the Calcutta High Court, for example, the court

56. Article 19(1) "provides that all citizens have the right: (a) to freedom of speech and expression; (b) to assemble peaceably and without arms; (c) to form associations or unions; (d) to move freely throughout the territory of India." Article 25 protects "the freedom of conscience and free profession, practice and propagation of religion". [Chaturvedi & Chaturvedi 1996:51-52, 53]

decided that the imposition of restrictions on the use of microphones and loudspeakers for the Muslim call to prayer was not in violation of Article 25 of the constitution. The court decision noted the following:

Azan [call to prayer] is certainly an essential and integral part of Islam but use of microphone and loudspeakers are not an essential and an integral part. Microphone is a gift of technological ages, its adverse effect is well felt all over the world. It is not only a source of pollution but it is also a source which causes several health hazards. Traditionally and according to the religious order, Azan has to be given by the Imam or the person in charge of the Mosques through their own voice, this is sanctioned under the religious order. [A.I.R. 1999 Calcutta 15]

On the law enforcement level, noise pollution is controlled under the Kerala Police Act of 1956, under which the Local Inspector has the authority to grant permission to use loudspeakers. Parties who wish to rent sound equipment for mobile announcements are required to get permission from the Police and present to the sound electricals company the license form which is reproduced in Figure 2.5. However, such requirements appear not to be effective, because the situation that Diwan and Diwan note in Mumbai is also apparently the case in Thrissur:

[U]nder the Bombay Police Act no loudspeakers can be used without police permission. But irony is that permission to use loudspeakers is given as a matter of course. [Diwan and Diwan 1998:232]

Furthermore, permits contain highly ambiguous guidelines such as specifying that the use of amplified sound "should not be [a] nuisance", with no specification of what constitutes a nuisance (see condition no. 3 of the license). The District Police Order on use of loudspeakers also specifies that "the sound amplifier should not be used when the vehicle is in motion" (condition no.

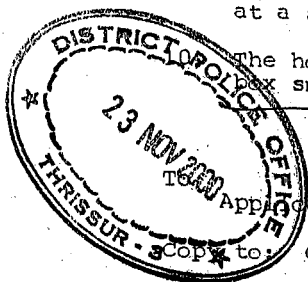
No. G2(b) RT.4/2000/R.

District Police Office,
Thrissur, Dt. 23-11-2000Recd:- Petition dated 23-11-2000 from General Secretary,
Catholic Syrian Male
Staff Federation,
BR.O R D E R

Where the licensee named below applied for a licence for use of sound amplifier. The said person is allowed to install and use the sound amplifier fitted with KRR-1981 to conduct publicity of All India Catholic Syrian Male Staff Federation, on 24-11-2000 at the Thrissur District only.

1. The sound amplifier or apparatus shall not face or be used within 500 yards of hospital, place of worship, educational institution or public office.
2. The use of the sound amplifier should not be nuisance or obstruction to the inhabitants or persons dwelling or occupying the immediate vicinity.
3. Any sound amplifier or loud speaker installed in any place should be kept in such volume that the sound does not become a nuisance beyond the limits to the property of the party using the loud speaker.
4. The licensee shall stop the use of the sound amplifier or shall remove the sound amplifier when directed by any Police Officer on duty not below the rank of SI of Police on the ground that the use of the apparatus is a nuisance or obstruction or account of the time, place and manner in which the sound amplifier is being used subsequent to grant of licence.
5. Any Police Officer on duty not below the rank of the SI may seize any sound amplifier or other instruments used in contravention of any of the conditions of the licence.
6. The sound amplifier should not be used when the vehicle is in motion.
7. The sound amplifier should not be used between hours of 10 PM and 6 AM in any Municipal area and in any busy through fares and in a building of place near such through fares and throughout day and night near hostels attached to educational Institutions.
8. The sound amplifier should not be used at or near the venue of any public meeting or in the vicinity of any Jatha organised by any party other than the party to which the licence belongs.
9. The sound amplifier should not be used more than 2 hours at a stretch.

The horn type sound amplifier should not be used. Only small type mike set should be used.



To: Applicant

300P to: CI, SI.

Sm. General Secretary
Catholic Syrian Male Staff Federation
BR.

For Supdt. of Police,
Thrissur.

aks 15 11

Figure 2.5 Permission from the District Police Office to use sound amplifier, collected from Kerala Sound Electricals, Thrissur.

6), which of course is completely ignored as a matter of course. Rules like this appear designed to allow police officials to stop the use of the loudspeakers for any reason, or also to permit their use, and according to representatives of Sound Electricals shops I spoke to, enforcement of noise pollution rules is generally subject to the political affiliations of those involved.

Summary.

Broadcasts of devotional songs through temple and church loudspeakers are an example of the social construction, or one might even say the performance, of space. Loudness is implicated in the construction of social and intersubjective space in Kerala by virtue of longstanding cultural models. Sound is used in Kerala practices as a means of transcending the vast geographical spaces which were traditionally a part of the cultural landscape, as exemplified by large drumming ensembles such as *pañcavādyam* or *ceṇṭa mēḷam*, and by the centrality of fireworks or explosives in many religious observances. Sound also draws people into shared subjective spaces, as exemplified by the role of *kompū* in *pañcavādyam*, and especially by *bhajana*. Electronically amplified sound is used in ways which extend these cultural models in the contemporary context. With the aid of this technology, temples generate loud sound not only during festival times but each and every day. The sounds from their loudspeakers imply a unified social space which establishes a continuum between the peacefulness of the early morning and the

sentiments of religious devotion signified by broadcast devotional songs.

Temple broadcasts may have played a very important role in the rejuvenation of temples after their period of decline following the implementation of Land Reforms, and the broadcasts continue to be a meaningful aspect of the intentional worlds of many who reside within the social space they delineate. At the same time, however, broadcasts draw attention to the tensions involved in temples' strategies for maintaining relevance in contemporary society. Ongoing social changes -- including those resulting from changed residential arrangements, changing notions of community, adaptations of music playback technology, and others I have discussed -- have resulted in a multiplicity of overlapping social spaces. The emergent incongruities between these spaces and that upon which the broadcasts are implicitly predicated are indicative of broader processes of change in Kerala's public culture. As areas like Thrissur urbanize, shared spaces come to be inhabited -- and conceptualized -- in increasingly diverse ways.

CHAPTER THREE

MASS MEDIA-DERIVED PERFORMANCE ARTS AND THE CONTEMPORARY HINDU TEMPLE FESTIVAL

Introduction.

On the final evening of our neighborhood temple's annual festival, before going to hear the scheduled *gānamēḷa* performance, Helen and I were visiting with our neighbors Ramya and Venugopal, a retired Nāyar couple who had both grown up in Thrissur, but had only very recently returned after having lived and worked in Zambia for nearly thirty years. They had made only infrequent visits home during that time, and they talked about how much things had changed in Thrissur since they had been gone. When we left their house and they walked us to the gate, we could hear highly amplified music coming from the temple. I commented that the festival's *gānamēḷa* performance had already begun, and Ramya and I had the following interchange:

R: That's not the temple, that's a film song I recognize.

E: Right, they play all film songs.

- R: Well, then that's not coming from the temple.
- E: No, it *is* coming from the temple, it's *gānamēḷa*.
- R: They must have changed the words; it must be a film song melody with devotional words.
- E: No, it is just film songs.
- R: No, It couldn't be. The temple only plays devotional music.
- E: No really, it is. It is *gānamēḷa*. This is what they are doing now.
- R: That certainly is very strange!

She insisted a few more times that they wouldn't be playing film songs at the temple. It took further convincing, and especially continued listening to the song, before she believed what she was hearing. She then said, with a laugh, "Next they will be having dance." I had to tell her, "They had cinematic dance last night!"

Kalāparipāṭi, generally translated as 'cultural programs', have long been an integral part of Hindu temple festivals in Kerala. Festivals have traditionally served as vehicles for performance genres which are understood as *kṣētrakalā* or 'temple arts', such as *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, *cākyār kūttū*, *ōṭṭan tuḷḷal*, and most famously, *kathakalī* (Zarrilli 2000, 1985; Jones 1983; Jones and Jones 1970). These artforms achieved their advanced level of complexity and sophistication through patronage by the wealthy landowning *jātis* of old Kerala, who sponsored their performances during temple festivals.

In today's Kerala, temple and church festivals are very popular events, and there are far more of them happening than

there were a century ago. In fact, temple and church festivals are the main venues for people to experience live music or other performances. However, Kerala's quintessential 'temple performing arts' are not thriving, but rather are seen as in need of protection and preservation. In 2001, in a move which bolsters institutions in Kerala which have been struggling to promote and present these arts, such as Natana Kairali in Irinjalakuda, UNESCO declared the older Sanskrit musical drama form *kūṭiyāṭṭam* to be a 'Masterpiece of the Oral and Intangible Heritage of Humanity', one of nineteen artforms or 'cultural spaces' from around the world to be named in this new category of cultural heritage in need of preservation.

Instead, the artforms which draw crowds of hundreds to small temples are ones that didn't exist a half-century ago, and as Ramya's reaction vividly illustrates, were distinctly separate from temples until the 1980s. They are artforms that derive from the mass media that only recent technology has allowed: *gānamēḷa*,¹ the performance of popular cinema songs by a largely electronic 'orchestra';² 'mimicry', a topical comedy routine; and cinematic dance. Scholars of traditional Kerala festival performances and artforms have brushed over or ignored the increasingly prominent role that *gānamēḷa* and other 'modern' performance genres play in festivals (Zarrilli 2000; Caldwell

1. The term *gānamēḷa* literally means 'gathering or festival of songs', and is not actually genre-specific; thus *bhakti gānamēḷa* refers to the performance of *bhakti gānaññal*, or devotional songs. When used by itself, however, *gānamēḷa* refers to the performance of cinema songs.

2. Following standard usage, I refer to this ensemble interchangeably as a *gānamēḷa* orchestra, an orchestra troupe, a *gānamēḷa* troupe, or simply as an orchestra.

1999; Groesbeck and Palackal 1999; Groesbeck 1995), and even temple committee members generally don't like to linger on the topic of the role *gānamēḷa* plays in their festival.

In this chapter I analyze the cultural context in which *gānamēḷa* emerged, and examine issues of performance and signification especially with relation to its most common performance context, the temple festival. Within this discussion, I redress the gap in scholarly attention to this performance genre by providing an account of its role in the musical and cultural life of Thrissur, with some reference to the other genre of cinema song performance, that of brass bands.

I show that the cultural programs of the contemporary temple festival serve as a site at which culture is being both reflected and actively created. *Gānamēḷa*, mimicry, and cinematic dance are contiguous with the mass media forms of cinema and television. By hosting these modern events, and by making use of modern technologies in other aspects of the festival, the temple aligns itself indexically with and declares its relevance in a contemporary society in which the forms of mass media serve as a constant reference point. However, the new performance context is not without conflicts. Part of the process of incorporating new artforms into festival programs involves negotiating just what the appropriate distance is between the new 'modern entertainments' and the ritual space of the temple, and whether that distance is spatial, temporal, social, or some combination of these.

Section 1. Temples and festivals in context.

1.1 A social history of the festival.

Approximately half of the year is festival season in Kerala. It is determined by the cycle of agricultural production, and coincides with the dry season, the long hot months when the empty fields become hard and parched. Harvest time is marked by the Ōṇam festival in *cinṇam* month (August-September); work in the fields is completely finished by *tulām* (October-November). As discussed in Chapter Two, the fields, which are vast, open, empty spaces, come to life again with the sound of temple festivals. Festival season gets underway in November, and its end is traditionally marked by the most famous festival in Central Kerala, Thrissur *pūram*, named for the *nakṣatram* ['lunar asterism'] on which it falls in *mēṭam* month, or late April to early May.³ Around the end of May the monsoon rains begin, and agriculturalists return to their work in the fields.⁴ In a contemporary city such as Thrissur, of course, the majority of people's livelihood does not come from agricultural

3. Malayāḷi calendars employ solar, lunar, and sidereal measurements; festivals are generally named according to the date of a particular 'lunar asterism' in a solar month (cf. Caldwell 1999:152-153; Groesbeck 1995:249-250). Fuller explains *nakṣatrams* as follows:

The path of the moon's orbit around the earth (one sidereal lunar month) is divided into twenty-seven equal segments, identified by constellations, whose names are given to the *nakshatras*, a term variously translated as 'star,' 'lunar asterism,' or 'lunar house.' As a unit of time, a *nakshatra* is the period (lasting approximately twenty-four hours) during which the moon remains in one segment. [1992:265]

4. The rains can sometimes overlap with the end of the festival season; in 2002 some of the *pūram* observances (including, somewhat ironically, the *kuṭamāṭṭam*, or ritual exchanging of umbrellas from atop elephants) had to be cancelled due to heavy downpour.

labour; nonetheless, from June through August Kerala receives very heavy rains which affect daily schedules, and thus the festival calendar continues to make sense in post-agricultural Kerala.

During this long festival season, nearly every temple -- from the famous pilgrimage centers such as Guruvayur to small local temples like the one in my neighborhood -- sponsors its own festival. As G. Venu, a tireless promoter of Kerala indigenous performance arts, has written, "We doubt if there is any other part of India, or of the whole world, that spends so much of its resources on festivals" (Venu 1990:1). Festivals can span from three to ten days, where each day features not only special ritual observances but also 'cultural programs'. This fact in itself -- that nearly every temple, large or small, sponsors a festival complete with cultural programs -- is itself significant, for this is a recent historical development. Before Land Reforms and especially before the Temple Entry Proclamation (1936), the temples were the exclusive preserve of the high castes, and annual celebrations of the founding of a small temple were often limited to special ritual observances. They probably did not always include performing arts programs, and certainly did not entail opening the temple to the lower caste families living nearby.

The Proclamation changed the social but not the economic situation of temples; in the system of tenancy often described as 'feudal', they were supported by the labor of landless farmers regardless of whether or not the latter were allowed to enter. The Land Reforms changed the situation further. In

effect, because the temples were no longer independently wealthy, they came to need the public for their very economic survival, perhaps even more than the public needed the temples. Thus the balance of power changed drastically, and in the period immediately following the redistribution of property, the temples fell into a sharp decline. However, that period was a short one, as I have said in Chapter Two. Perhaps after realizing that economic prosperity within Kerala was not as close at hand as it had initially seemed, people in the areas surrounding neglected temples formed committees and reopened the temples; those who had achieved a measure of financial success by leaving the state and working in the Gulf donated loudspeakers to give them voice and thus life. From that point on, it was clear that temples had to reach out to members of surrounding communities in order to ensure their own survival. Donations from neighborhood supporters enabled temples not only to reopen, but to begin to celebrate the annual festivals which sponsored cultural programs on a scale previously unknown to small local temples.

According to conventional wisdom among Hindus in South India, a temple and its surrounding community are interdependent: in answering my questions about what the purpose of a temple festival is, a standard answer from templegoers was that they are conducted to ensure the prosperity of the temple, and that the prosperity of the temple, in turn, signifies or even enacts the prosperity of the whole locality. Given economic relationships of tenancy and dependence in old Kerala, the implied causal arrow may in fact have been more unidirectional than bidirectional: that if the land is fertile,

then the taxes upon the harvests which are demanded by the temple ensure that the temple, and the landlord family that owns it, prospered. When this family prospered, they had the means to patronize artforms and to stage performances as a part of the temple's annual festival. Some of these performances were not caste-specific, and so were given outside of the temple walls, theoretically open to the public. Others were the domain of temple-going castes, i.e. Nāyars and above, and were staged inside the temple, for the benefit only of the deity of the temple and those privileged castes who were allowed near the deity.

The nature of the interdependence between temples and their surrounding communities in today's Thrissur is therefore radically different from what it was before the social changes of the 20th century, including Temple Entry and Land Reforms. Because temple committees must rely on public donations to conduct festivals, committee members say that they also must arrange programs that will appeal to the public, rather than only to a high-caste elite.

The performance genres which are today most associated with festivals must be seen in this economic context. Although these are genres which didn't originate in festivals, I suggest that their movement into festival contexts, while initially surprising, can be understood in terms of the paradigm or cultural model of temple and community interdependence. The older performing arts and their performance contexts may be said to reflect the social structures and values of old Kerala. The new genres such as *gānamēḷa*, on the other hand, now occur in

festivals of temples which exist in a new relationship to their surrounding communities. These performances not only reflect the emergent values of a society which has undergone and is still experiencing rapid change, but indeed are part of the process of constructing and negotiating such values.

1.2 'Cultural programs' as cultural performances.

The performance genres with which I am concerned in this chapter fall under the category of *kalāparipāṭi*, generally translated as 'cultural program', and contrast with the kinds of music that are closely connected with the central rituals of the temple, such as those considered to be offerings to the deity.⁵ These *kalāparipāṭi* constitute 'cultural performances' in the most straightforward sense (Singer 1972:71), in that through them something called 'culture' is both reflected and enacted. 'Culture' here cannot be understood as singular and monolithic, stable, or even coherent. These cultural performances, their settings, and more importantly what people say about them, indicate instead the contours of cultural change and negotiation that characterize Kerala urban society at this complex moment in its history.

The types of programs staged vary according to type of temple. Large and famous temples, such as Guruvayur's Śrī Kṛṣṇa or Thrissur's Śrī Vāṭakkunāthan temples, program mainly

5. Groesbeck (1995) similarly distinguishes between musics that are 'central' vs. 'peripheral' to the ritual.

traditional temple arts associated with high-caste heritage, while smaller neighborhood temples program some traditional arts but rely on newer forms to attract a large audience. The heavily amplified re-creation of popular cinema songs by a live 'orchestra' is the most popular attraction at the festivals of these temples, and of churches.

Festivals are an integral part of Hindu observances, and as Welbon and Yocum note in their preface to a collection of studies of religious festivals in South India and Sri Lanka,

festivals -- special performances (or complexes of performances) at special times -- provide vital insights into the religious, aesthetic, social, economic, and political values and concerns in the societies in which they occur. [1982:vii]

In Kerala, Christian churches also sponsor festivals [*tirunṇāl māhōtsavam*, 'holy day great festival', or as they are sometimes called in English, 'feasts'] each year, concentrated especially in January and February. Christian festivals also include processions and stage programs, and are in some ways indistinguishable from temple festivals. People often say that Hindus and Christians support each others' festivals, and indeed, most people I spoke to who go to 'modern' festival stage performances at all will go to Christian and Hindu festivals, regardless of their own religion. Muslim holidays stand in contrast to both of these, in that they are generally focused around additional prayer times and lectures rather than public programs.

1.3 Technology as sign.

Contemporary temple festivals make use of modern technologies to the maximum extent they can afford in efforts to increase the apparent grandeur of the temple and the festival. One example of this trend is found in the printed flyers or brochures produced by festival committees, which announce the schedule of rituals and programs and sometimes include advertisements by sponsors. Although some continue to use letter-press printing, committees increasingly design and produce these schedules in full color on glossy paper, using computer graphic collage techniques allowed by programs like Adobe Photoshop. For one temple not far from my neighborhood, for example, the festival's name -- *karttika*, after the *nakṣatram* -- is depicted in three-dimensional lettering with digitally-rendered flames arising from the letters. On another, paintings of deities on the front of the temple are digitally replaced in the reproduction with crisper illustrations. Such creations and interventions index not just prosperity but 'modernity', and thus contemporary relevance.

Widespread use of electric lights in the temple is also a recent festival innovation. 'Sound electricals' companies serve all the electrical needs of festivals, both light and sound, and are thus very busy during festival season. Their work announces the festival to the surrounding area both aurally and visually. Their first job is to construct an elaborate temporary façade called an *alankārappaṇṭal*, or 'decorated pandal', which is built of modular sections of latticed painted wood, covered in lights, which gives the illusion of tall, flamboyantly elaborate,

castle-like edifices, masking the much more modest structures that actually exist. They also post fluorescent tube-lights throughout the temple area. Combined with palm leaves strung up as trimmings, the temple grounds are visually transformed.

Although such visuals are a crucial part of their business, these companies are not called light electricals but *sound* electricals companies; their main importance comes from the microphones, amplifiers, and loudspeakers they provide, which make the festival programs audible for a far greater distance than the decorations are visible. Stacks of loudspeaker cabinets generally flank the stage for programs such as *gānamēḷa*, *bhajana*, mimicry, and dance, and programs are commonly amplified to extremely high levels, generally challenging the capability of the loudspeakers. Furthermore, in some festivals, additional leads were also run from the amplifiers to horn-type speakers mounted outside the temple, carrying the sounds of the performances well into the surrounding community.

Section 2. Traditional or temple-based artforms.

Festival committees generally strive to offer a variety of artforms as *kalāparipāṭi*. In order to examine the roles various performance genres have in temple festivals, I first describe further both the traditional forms, and following that, the newer items.

2.1 Drumming-based forms: *tāyampaka*, *mēḷam*, *pañcavādyam*.

The indigenous genres of music performed at Kerala temples -- both for daily *pūja* and for festival occasions -- are based almost exclusively on drumming and the production of rhythm. The drumming genre most common in festivals is *tāyampaka*, a composition which features the *ceṇṭa*, a double-headed cylindrical drum about which the eminent Indian musicologist B.C. Deva wrote, "Few drums are so characteristic of their society as the *chenda* of Kerala" (1987:72). An excerpt from a performance by Mōhanan & Party, from a festival at Tr̥kkumāramkuṭam Temple, is provided on Track 8 of the CD.⁶ *Tāyampaka* is the subject of an extremely thorough analysis by Rolf Groesbeck (1995, 1999; Groesbeck and Palackal 1998), and I refer interested readers to those writings. In *tāyampaka*, the soloist performs a progression of rhythmic figures with the rhythmic accompaniment of a group of other *ceṇṭas* an equal number of *ilattāḷam*, pairs of thick bell-metal cymbals approximately six inches in diameter (Rajagopalan 1974:42). A variation of *tāyampaka* which is increasingly popular is 'double *tāyampaka*' [*iraṭṭū tāyampaka*], in which two *ceṇṭa* soloists trade rhythmic phrases with increasing velocity; the dynamic interplay between the two is very engaging for the audience. This variant was invented in the late 1940s (Groesbeck 1995:382), and today is at least as common in Thrissur temple festivals as solo *tāyampaka*.

6. This *tāyampaka* performance was also amplified via a single microphone through horn speakers which had been temporarily mounted at the edge of the temple compound. The recording excerpted here was made from a position nearer to the loudspeaker than to the ensemble, such that the amplified sound is prominent.

Tāyampaka has two principal performance contexts: as an offering to the deity during a pause in a procession, or as a performance inside the temple compound. In the latter circumstance, *tāyampaka* is performed inside the outer wall, near to the entrance to the central shrine, or *śrīkōvil*. Thus although the performance is not held in the very inner part of the temple, its proximity to the passageway to the *śrīkōvil* makes it clear that the music is contiguous to rituals of worship in a way that modern stage performances are not, as we will see below.

While *tāyampaka* is (relatively) a more intimate performance held amidst a smaller audience and near to the *śrīkōvil*, *mēḷam* is a much louder, more dramatic and public expression of grandeur and is generally held just outside the temple grounds. *Mēḷam* [from the Sanskrit (and Malayāḷam) *mēḷa*, 'an assembly, fair, marketplace, festival, meeting'], refers to a large ensemble of instruments, and in the context of temple festivals refers specifically to *ceṇṭa mēḷam*. Like *pañcavādyam*, which I describe in Chapter 2, this ensemble is not of determinate size, but depends upon the resources of the temple and the festival: the bigger (and louder) the better. A typical large group might include 45 *ceṇṭa*, 15 *kompū*, 15 *kurum kuzhal*, and 30 *ilattāḷam* (Groesbeck and Palackal 1998:933); the largest *ceṇṭa mēḷam* I have seen, at the Uttrālikkāvu *pūram* festival in northern Thrissur District, had between 150 and 200 performers. Also like *pañcavādyam*, *ceṇṭa mēḷam* can either accompany a procession or perform at the temple.

2.2 Older stage genres: *kathakaḷi*, *cākyār kūttū*, *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, *ōṭṭan tuḷḷal*.

The other performance genres at temple festivals generally occur on the proscenium stage. Some temples and churches have permanent stages built within the compound; more commonly, however, temporary stages are set up either inside the outer *prakāram*, or just outside, or both, with different stages designated for different performance genres. The question of whether the stage is located inside or outside the temple compound is a charged one, and will be addressed later in the chapter.

Internationally, the best-known performance art from Kerala is the colorful dance-drama *kathakaḷi*, literally 'story play'. The green-painted faces and bloodshot eyes of *kathakaḷi* actors are featured by the Kerala Department of Tourism on posters, literature, and even a recent CD-ROM.⁷ The *kathakaḷi* actor has become a recognized icon of Kerala traditional culture. *Kathakaḷi*, contrary to a common perception by Westerners, is not a ritual genre but is, as one organizer described it, "*pakkā* ['completely'] theater". It developed under the patronage of wealthy Nampūtiri and Nāyar connoisseurs, performed not in temples but in palace or household compounds (Zarrilli 2000:6); its association with temple festivals began only after the Nāyar *taravāṭṭu* began to break down in the late 19th century, adversely

7. *The Green Symphony*, an 'Interactive CD-ROM on Kerala, India', released in 2000 by Invis Multimedia, Thiruvananthapuram, in association with the Kerala Department of Tourism, was to be seen in all the high-end bookshops while I was in Kerala, such as those in airports and those directed towards tourists.

affecting Nāyar patronage of such arts. After that time, performances became a mainstay of Kerala temple festivals, lasting much of the night for several nights in a row. Now the place of *kathakaḷi* is shifting again, for while *kathakaḷi* continues to be performed in some village temple festivals, its popularity has waned in urban areas; in fact, none of the temple festivals in Thrissur town of which I was aware presented any *kathakaḷi* at all.⁸

Cākyār kūttū and *kūṭiyāṭṭam* are theatrical genres which have traditionally been performed by the high-caste *cākyārs* and *nampiyārs*. Performances were restricted to temples, and *kūṭiyāṭṭam* to the special structures called *kūttampalams* found in only a few large temples, such as Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan temple at the center of Thrissur. In *cākyār kūttū*, a member of the *cākyār* caste delivers a humorous, sometimes satirical monologue, acting the roles of several characters, with the accompaniment of a *mizhāvū* drum, played by a *nanṇiyār*, a female member of the *nampiyār* caste. As A. Sreedhara Menon describes it,

The entertainment is marked throughout by humour and sarcasm. The Chakiar is an ideal satirist and in the course of his exposition of puranic stories he draws parallels from contemporary life to establish or emphasise some moral or incident from the stories he is narrating. Custom has conferred on the Chakiar the privilege of

8. The only performances of *kathakaḷi* in town, to my knowledge, were presented by the Thrissur Kathakali Club, one of several such private cultural organizations in Kerala which started emerging in cities in the 1960s, in an effort by "groups of civic-minded connoisseurs of the traditional arts to fill what was perceived as a vacuum in the regular public presentation of Kerala performing arts, especially *kathakali*" (Zarrilli 2000:7). These performances were staged in a hall attached to Paramekkāvu Temple in central Thrissur, in a room brightly lit by fluorescent lights and with the audience seated on rows of plastic molded chairs, with large banners bearing the name of the club and various sponsors behind the actors.

immunity from interruption while performing *Koothu*. It is his exclusive prerogative to cut jokes even at the expense of the high dignitaries present in the gathering. The person who is the target of attack has no right to retort. If anyone dares to do so, *Koothu* comes to an abrupt end. [Sreedhara Menon 1996a: 113]

Although in the performances I saw there were no 'high dignitaries' to be seen, the *cākyār* did indeed 'cut jokes' at the expense of many individuals in the audience, including me.

Kūṭiyāṭṭam is a Sanskrit drama also traditionally acted by *cākyār* men and *nañniyār* women, accompanied again by the *mizhāvū*. In both, the drum is traditionally played by *nampiyārs*. *Kūṭiyāṭṭam* is presented only rarely, and then only by those temples that have a *kūttampalam*, while *cākyār kūttū* can be seen performed in the courtyards of smaller temples as part of festival programs. For authoritative accounts of *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, see Venu (1997) and Rajagopalan (1997, 2000).

G. Venu, who is among Kerala's leading promoters of *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, was quick to emphasize that although it has traditionally been restricted to temples and to temple-going castes -- and contrary to the assumptions of many Western scholars he has dealt with -- it is not itself ritual [*anuṣṭhānam*], but theater, or art [*kalā*]. Therefore, it is open to innovation. In fact, according to Venu, as a theatrical form, *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, *nañniyār kūttū*, and other such forms trace their development back to the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, the Sanskrit treatise on dramaturgy, and the *Nāṭyaśāstra* is clear that innovation is a crucial part of art, that one *must* innovate.

At Natana Kairali training center in Irinjalakuda, Thrissur District, which is run by Venu and Nirmala Paniker, changes of a

very practical nature have also been made in their treatment of such arts. First, they are training performers from outside of the traditional castes, and second, they are conducting performances outside of temples. In such efforts to preserve, promote, and advance such artforms, Venu has said that a great obstacle is presented, ironically, by Western scholars, who in his experience, have stifled innovation in an effort to preserve a textually-based, codified notion of the artform. In addition, he tells of Western scholars who come backstage to congratulate and encourage performers of the traditional castes, while ignoring those of other castes, who in Venu's estimation happened to be superior performers. Such conservatism forms almost as great an obstacle to sustaining these artforms in today's society as that of temples who refuse to allow nontraditional castes to perform within their walls.

Ōṭṭan tuḷḷal is a comedic and satirical mono-drama that is not connected with caste or ritual. Track 9 is an excerpt from a performance by Kalāmandalam Gītānandan & Party at a small temple festival. Its stories, which are based on themes from the *purāṇas*, were composed by Kuñjan Nampiyār in the late 18th century in colloquial Malayāḷam, such that any Malayāḷi could understand. *Ōṭṭan tuḷḷal* was furthermore a vehicle for social critique:

Social aberrations like the rapacity of rulers, the greed of courtesans, the corruption of officials, laziness of the nobles were exposed effectively. Obsolete institutions like polyandry, polygamy and caste system were severely attacked. The rich output of *tuḷḷal* literature during the eighteenth century became the instrument of social change.... It was humanistic, democratic and popular. It was a programme to civilize and socialize men and society

by ridiculing the acquisitive and libidinous people.
[Ramachandran Nair 1999:95, 117]

The actor tells stories by singing, often in conversational or call-and-response form with supporting singers, and by employing gestures or *mudras*, with the accompaniment of *iṭaykka*,⁹ *mṛdaṅgam*, and occasionally harmonium.

In the hands of a skilled actor, the stories are brought to life for a performance whose humor appeals to adults and children alike. The main performer's makeup and costume are similar to both *kathakālī* and *kūṭiyāṭṭam*: he wears green face paint, with red lips, bloodshot eyes, and black makeup applied horizontally around the eyes. His costume includes shoulder decorations which imply a shirt, and a skirt made out of starched loops of fabric; underneath he wears pink pants which he sometimes shows to the kids in the audience.

The recitation is continuous as it is passed back and forth between the actor and the supporting singers, and in a skilled performance, such as the one excerpted on Track 9, the actor cycles through all kinds of different emotions and moods. In this performance, the timing between the lead actor and the musicians was perfect; his hand gestures were met precisely by strikes of the drum. However, as is common, sound reinforcement practices interfered with the desired effect. In this otherwise dazzling performance, for example, the loudly amplified voice

9. The *iṭaykka* is a small hourglass-shaped tension drum which is played with a curved stick. The pitch of the drum is varied by squeezing the strings connecting the two heads with one hand, while beating the drum with the other. This ability to use pitch makes the *iṭaykka* a very expressive instrument.

heard on the recording is not the main actor, but the accompanying singer; the main actor's voice and the expressive *iṭaykka* drum were not amplified, and are very quiet on the recording. In addition, the *mṛdaṅgam*, which on its own is already a loud instrument, was also amplified. When after the show I saw a harmonium player leaving the stage, I was surprised because I hadn't heard it in the mix at all. Although *ōṭṭan tuḷḷal* is the most commonly presented of these dance-drama type performances, it does not draw large audiences: the best-attended performance I saw had only 30 people in the audience.

2.3 *Bhajana* and classical dance.

As discussed in the previous chapter, *bhajana* is today presented as a stage performance by professional troupes who establish their reputations by releasing cassettes, which are laid out for sale at the temple festivals where they perform. Professional troupes I heard consisted of Brāhmans, who were shirtless so that their 'sacred threads' were visible. *Bhajanas* are accompanied by 'classical' instruments, such as harmonium, *mṛdaṅgam* or *tabala*, and sometimes flute; in keeping with the nature of the genre, instrumental arrangements are simple. Each singer and instrumentalist is miked, and although audiences are small, the overall sound level in my experience is as high as possible. When I would inquire about why the sound was set to deafening levels when only 10-20 people were there to listen, I was told that it was for the benefit of the surrounding community.

Finally, a variety of 'classical' solo dance forms are sometimes presented. Often dance will be advertised in the schedule using the generic term '*nṛttanṛtṭyañṇaḷ*', or 'dances with *mūdras* [*nṛttam*] and dances without *mudras* [*nṛtṭyam*]' (Groesbeck 1995:218). Specific genres that may be presented include the Kerala form *mōhiniyāṭṭam*, the Andhra form *kuccuppuṭi*, and the Tamil form *bhāratanāṭyam*. *Nṛttanṛtṭyañṇaḷ* is often thought of as synonymous with 'semi-classical dance', or a non-specialist presentation of dance influenced by the above classical forms. Such performances are generally conducted with the accompaniment of cassette recordings of Karnātak music played back through the sound system.

Section 3. The rise of new artforms.

The genres I have briefly introduced above form the corpus of what are generally known as temple art forms, or *kṣētrakalā*. Although Malayāḷis will say that such artforms are important aspects of Kerala's cultural heritage, few show any further personal interest in them. When these are presented at temple festivals today, the audiences that come to see them are very small. Temple festivals do attract crowds; however, these crowds come not for the traditional temple stage genres, but instead for a new group of genres which are presented at temple and church festivals. Instead of drawing upon the *purāṇas* or the Hindu epics for their subject matter, these new arts derive their content and their vitality from more contemporary

concerns. Of these new genres, the earliest addition to festivals, drama [*nātakam*], initially took its subject matter from contemporary social or political concerns. Later additions -- *gānamēḷa*, mimicry, and cinematic dance -- assume their forms in direct relation to the commercially driven forms of cinema and television.

3.1 Drama.

Nātakam ['drama'] has a distinguished history as a very popular public entertainment in Kerala, and was the among the first 'modern' additions to temple festivals. The reasons for its popularity, as I have discussed in Chapter One, are highly embedded in Kerala's social and political history of the past century.

Staged drama performances were popular and well-attended in the 1950s, as the KPAC (Kerala People's Arts Club) and other theater troupes inspired by their example traveled around from village to village. Letika, a Nāyar woman who is a retired electrical engineer, remembers frequently attending dramas as a child with her family. Dramas would also be staged following political meetings and speeches; proceeds from the ticket sales benefited the party. The plays that became most popular dealt with social issues and expressed sympathy with the suffering of working people not only in the dialogue, but more importantly through songs, with lyrics penned by great poets such as O.N.V. Kurup.

Introducing *nāṭakam* into temple festivals can be seen as a logical progression from the genres of *kathāprasāṅgam* ['story-telling'], and preceding that, of *harikathā* ['story of Hari']. In *harikathā*, Puranic stories of the gods are the main subject, told through speech with some melodic inflections. *Harikathā* is almost never performed in temples anymore (and I have never seen it); its place has been taken by the more 'modern' *kathāprasāṅgam*. In *kathāprasāṅgam*, a single narrator tells a story, with occasional use of songs or isolated sung verses and instrumental accompaniment (generally a digital keyboard), which can be on any number of topics; these can include, as in *harikathā*, stories of the gods from the *purāṇas* or stories adapted from the Sanskrit poet Kalidasa, or they can also include stories about Kerala historical figures like Swati Tirunal, or more contemporary people of national interest, ranging from M.K. Gandhi to Phoolan Devi.¹⁰ If *kathāprasāṅgam* opened the door for 'nonreligious' content in festival programs, then drama, which included many actors, songs, and dance numbers, was the next step.

Today drama remains extremely popular in temple festivals, but much more so in Southern Kerala than in Central and Northern Kerala. V. Unni, a professional actor who lived in my neighborhood, acts with 'Jubilee Troupe', which does about 350 programs per year, mostly in Southern Kerala. During the heart of the temple season, from December to April, his troupe performs two programs each day, at two different temples; they

10. The story of Phoolan Devi was brought to international attention largely through the 1994 film *Bandit Queen*, by Shekhar Kapur.

are travelling constantly. Temple festivals form the vast majority of their programs, but some performances are also sponsored by fine arts societies. According to Unni, there are now over 300 troupes in Kerala, each doing over 200 performances per year.

The influence of television and cinema is also affecting popular drama presentations. In recent years, the kind of theater being presented has changed from the model established by the earlier generation, in that it is now more oriented more toward light-hearted entertainment of the kind that is popular on television, than toward social commentary. People involved with drama told me that, at least in terms of the plays being booked for festivals, the trend of having serious messages in drama is over; even the KPAC no longer addresses social or political issues in its plays.¹¹ As the actor Unni told me,

Those days are gone.... Now there are family stories with a lot to laugh at. People don't need/want [vēṇṭa] those big issues.... Comedy has got importance now; comedy is needed/wanted ['comedy'-kkāṇu prādhānyam ippōḷ 'comedy' vēṇam].

Furthermore, although songs were as critical to the success of early dramas as they are to today's cinema, they are increasingly less common in plays now. In fact, the two plays which Unni acted in most recently had no songs at all. Audiences have no patience for songs in dramas, he said, because dramas are performed on a stage of limited size, and lack the ability that cinema has to change backdrops, to shoot song and

11. Serious drama is still studied and practiced in institutions such as Calicut University's Drama School, which is located in Thrissur.

dance scenes in the Swiss Alps, for example, as some Malayālam films (and countless Hindi films) have done.

3.2 Mimicry: 'just like what we watch on TV'.

The interdependence of contemporary festival programs with mass-mediated public entertainments is exemplified very clearly in the case of 'mimicry',¹² specifically in relation to television. Imitation is an old form of comedy -- indeed, the humor of *ōṭṭan tuḷḷal* or *cākyār kūttu* performances, for example, often draws on the performer's ability humorously or sarcastically to caricature a publicly known person, an animal, or a person in the audience. It is thus perhaps tempting to see mimicry as an outgrowth from those forms. However, a number of important differences align mimicry much more solidly with television-based entertainment than with such traditional performance genres. One of the most apparent is that mimicry is an entirely one-directional performance: the actor performs, and the audience listens. *Kūttu* and *tuḷḷal*, in contrast, involve a good deal of interaction between the performers and the public.¹³

12. The first mimicry troupe in Kerala was founded by Kalābhavan in Kochi, as an expansion of its music school and orchestra troupe which had become very successful in the 1960s and 1970s. Kalābhavan continues today to be the top 'Western' and film music school in Kerala. In Chapter 4 I discuss further the connections between Kalābhavan's innovations and the Syro-Malabar Catholic Church.

13. I met one 11-year-old girl who expressed great interest in *tuḷḷal*, and hoped to study it herself. Interestingly, because she had only seen performances of it on television, never in person, she was unaware of the interactive nature of live performances.

Furthermore, the content and characters of contemporary 'mimicry' performances come directly from television and cinema. Also referred to as 'mimics parade', performances typically consist of a series of skits where actors mockingly imitate television personalities, movie stars, or politicians. The tight connection between mimicry and television, in particular, is illustrated by the following description by Ajita, a married woman in her 30s, of a performance at her neighborhood temple:

It was just like what we watch on TV. It is not something that they created separately. This time it was like ... M.G. Sreekumar's 'Sa Ri Ga Ma' program on TV.¹⁴ They spell it in reverse order, making fun of it. They sing the songs in comic manner, whereas there [on TV] it is serious. Then the program by Karthika [channel], 'Telefilm', which is actually called 'Telequiz', making fun of that also. Then songs of Kalābhavan Mani.¹⁵ ... Everything was like TV programs.

As can be heard on Track 10 of the CD, mimicry artists also make full use of their microphones for making sound effects to accompany their acts. At this small temple festival, a young man reenacted the American movie, *Titanic*, twice in two minutes, once with fake English dialogue (gibberish with an 'English' accent) and once in a 'Malayāḷam cinema' adaptation; both versions included sound-effects, such as of the ship breaking up

14. *Sa Ri Ga Ma*, which takes its name from the solfège syllables of Karnāṭak music, is a popular game show hosted by the famous playback singer M.G. Sreekumar. As Sreekumar sings a classic film song, along with a live studio orchestra troupe, the contestant must name it and the film in which it appeared, in order to win cash prizes. The program is popular among Malayāḷis all over the world; I have seen it broadcast on cable television in Chicago.

15. Kalābhavan Mani is an extremely popular comedian/mimicry artist, singer, and most recently, hit film actor. He began his career with, and got his name from, the Kalābhavan mimicry troupe in Kochi. The songs mentioned were undoubtedly from one of his many cassettes of parody songs of all kinds.

and sinking, made by exploiting the proximity effect of microphones in a way similar to that of 'human beat-boxes' in rap or hip-hop music.

3.3 Cinematic dance.

The most recent entry into the performance genres of temple festivals is 'cinematic dance'. In Malayālam films, as in Hindi and Tamil films, the frequent song sequences are also occasions for elaborately choreographed dances, often involving not only the hero and heroine who mouth the words, but whole choruses of dancers, such as a fleet of autorickshaw drivers, or a palaceful of courtesans. The dance style is a hybrid of many influences, from the gestures of Indian classical forms to those of Michael Jackson (an oft-cited reference point). Although a staple of films for decades, the genre has only recently moved onto the popular stage; I was told that it had only begun appearing in festival cultural programs in the last few years. In these performances, groups of dancers reenact the dance sequences in films, accompanied by an extremely loudly amplified cassette recording of the song.

Performances in smaller temples may feature a dance troupe may be made up of young people from the neighborhood, but semiprofessional cinematic dance troupes also exist in Thrissur. The genre has become quite popular; performances I saw, either at temples or elsewhere, were well-attended and enthusiastically

received, and one sees signs advertising training in cinematic dance posted about town.¹⁶ At one local temple festival, an evening's program consisted of semi-classical dance, cinematic dance, and finally mimicry, all conducted on a stage set up inside the temple compound, immediately beside the temple. Cinematic dance was clearly a high point for at least some audience members. During the semi-classical dance performance, a group of teenage boys, dressed up for an evening out, meandered around the compound and talked, seemingly bored. But when cinematic dance was announced, they snapped to; one said excitedly to another, 'okay, cinematic dance!' and proceeded to bust out some quick moves for his friends. They were completely entertained by the performance, sometimes dancing along in the open area behind the audience.

3.4 Cinema itself.

Although it's not commonly seen, I attended one festival where cinema itself was presented. Whereas cinematic dance, mimicry, or the performance of film songs are genres which are derivative of mass-mediated forms, in this case the mass media itself was brought into the festival. A screen and a 16mm film projector were set up outside the temple wall, and at dusk, a

16. In contrast, fifteen years ago Peter Manuel reported that cinematic dance was rarely seen as a live performance (1988:176).

print of the Malayāḷam film *Friends*¹⁷ was shown. A crowd of 250-300 people, mostly male but more gender balanced than usual, sat on the ground and really enjoyed it, laughing at all the jokes; it mattered not that the print was somewhat grainy, or that the soundtrack was scratchy and slightly distorted. The funds for the program had been donated by a Christian man who owned a successful plant nursery in the area, and who saw his donation more as a gift to the community than to the temple *per se*.

Section 4. *Gānamēḷa*: The live performance of cinema songs.

4.1 The development of the genre.

Without doubt, the biggest attraction at any local temple festival in Thrissur today is the *gānamēḷa*, the performance of the most popular songs from current films by an orchestra troupe. *Gānamēḷa* was introduced as a temple festival *kalāparipāṭi* ['cultural program'] only within the past ten years or so. Whereas before that time, musicians tell me, such performances were often held as ticketed concerts in halls such as Thrissur's Regional Theater (a large indoor theater with seating capacity of several hundred), today orchestras are heard almost exclusively out in the open at festivals, their sound

17. This film had been popular a couple of years earlier. It is a typical Malayalam movie, featuring the obligatory song, dance, melodrama, violence, and so forth.

amplified by thousands of watts of power reverberating through the surrounding neighborhoods.

The popularity of *gānamēḷa* owes to much of the same history as that of *nātakam*, in that Malayāḷi cinema songs themselves grew out of the songs popularized initially by the KPAC in the context of their dramas. The most highly respected composers of Malayāḷam cinema songs, such as G. Devarajan and M.S. Baburaj, and poet-lyricists such as O.N.V. Kurup and Vayalar Rama Varma, were either associated with the KPAC or began their career in it. Only after gaining tremendous popularity in the world of drama did they go on to the world of cinema. The legacy of these and other composers in today's cinema music is clear. Many later famous Malayāḷi film music directors can trace their artistic lineage to these pioneers; for example, the composers Johnson and Ouseppachan worked as assistants with Devarajan for many years before getting recognition as music directors themselves. Mohan Sithara, who is one of the most prolific and best-known music directors working today (and was the composer of the song heard on Tracks 11 and 12, discussed below), in turn got his start by working with Johnson and Ouseppachan in Thrissur's Kalāsadan orchestra.

The popular music of contemporary films is not the *lālitasāṅgītam* ['light music'] of yesteryear, but is instead described by the term *aṭipoḷi*. Derived from the verbs *aṭikkuka* ['beat, hit'] and *poḷikkuka* ['demolish, break to pieces, smash'], the term came into use among musicians to refer to music that was really 'cool'; it is defined in my dictionary as slang for 'smashing, terrific' [Warrier et al. 2000]. A

musician friend said that the term was quite common in his milieu well before it entered the popular lexicon. It is now known and used by nearly everyone, although its meaning has shifted: instead of meaning a song is 'good', it refers principally to music with heavy beats or strong rhythms, pop music that invites dancing.¹⁸ Today, in many minds the term marks a generational divide: young people like *aṭipoli pāṭṭu*, while their elders prefer the 'old and gold' film songs.

The instrumentation of an orchestra troupe has changed in important ways as styles and as available technology have changed. In photos I was shown from the early 1970s of Thrissur's Kalāsadan orchestra, which was founded by the Syro-Malabar Catholic Church (which connection is discussed in Chapter 4), the orchestra consisted of a section of violins, a section of electric guitars, flutes, *tabala*, triple drum (a set of high toms played with the hands), and harmoniums. The troupes were large, and the total sound of the groups was 'orchestral'. Today, orchestras play a very different music, and the instrumentation reflects that difference. The digital synthesizer has taken a central role, and the number of instruments needed to supplement its sounds has shrunk considerably; troupes rarely have more than one violinist, flutist, or guitarist. On the other hand, bass guitar has been added, and the importance of percussion has increased. In addition to *tabala* and triple drum, there is now also 'jazz'

18. Of course, because the origin of the term seems to date to the time that Ilayaraja and A.R. Rahman came onto the scene, it is likely that the music that young musicians were saying was 'good' also had such heavy beats.

(rock drumset), sometimes congas, and a prominently featured electronic 'rhythm pad'.¹⁹

4.2 The festival performance context.

The *gānamēḷa* performance situation varies depending upon the size of the temple, in terms of its importance, its network of support, and the physical space available to it. If the festival committee raises enough funds to hire a well-known troupe, then the performance will attract a crowd of thousands. For example, Tiruvāṇattū Śrī Kṛṣṇa Kṣētram is a small temple in western Thrissur which held a very modest series of programs as part of its festival: the bhajana, mimicry, and cinematic dance performances were all given by local amateur troupes, and were attended by audiences of less than 100, sometimes much less. But for the *gānamēḷa* performance, which was the climactic final event on the schedule, the temple committee brought in a famous troupe from Palakkad, called the Palakkad Nādam ['divine sound'] Orchestra. The temple still has small fields on two sides, and so a temporary stage was set up in one of them for the orchestra. A crowd of many hundreds gathered; women sat on the left side, and men (who greatly outnumbered the women) sat on the right and milled about in the back.

19. A 'rhythm pad' or 'drum pad' is an electronic instrument with a surface divided into several regions. Each region is assignable to a variety of sampled or synthesized percussive sounds, such as cymbals, snare drums, toms, purely electronic sounds, and so on, and the pad is played with drumsticks as if it were a drum set. It makes no sound on its own but must be connected to an amplifier and speakers.

The performance begins in a typical way. The orchestra's lead singer, whose voice is treated with digital echo and reverb, begins by naming the temple and the festival, and thanking the committee. He then announces that the first selection will be an old devotional film song by G. Devarajan, originally sung by (and thus indelibly identified with) the most popular Malayāḷi playback singer of all time, K.J. Yesudas. Beginning the program with a devotional song functions as a nod to the religious nature of the festival; if they are hosted by a church, then they will play a Christian devotional song, if a temple, then a Hindu song. But after that, the crowd gets to hear what they came for: *aṭipoli* songs. The singer announces that it's time to play some film songs, and that the first is from the current hit, *Tenkāśipaṭṭanam* [roughly, 'town south of Kāśi'], and they launch into one of that film's several hit songs, *Oru Siṃham* ['a lion'], to cheers from the crowd. The rest of the concert consists almost exclusively of recent film hits, not only from Malayāḷam films but also interspersed with the most popular Tamil and Hindi songs. In a conscious attempt to appeal to a wide audience, occasionally an 'old and gold' film song is thrown in. With these songs also, there is a broad consensus about which songs are the best: for example, every orchestra and every bandset I heard had the song '*Pennāḷe Pennāḷe*' ['O servant maid'], composed by Salil Chowdhury, from the classic Malayāḷam film *Cemmiṉ* (1965) in its active playlist.

When a *gānamēḷa* performance is going on at a neighborhood temple, the neighborhood is transformed. Towering stacks of speaker cabinets are set up on each side of the stage, and cassettes of film songs are played through these speakers before

the show begins.²⁰ Crowds come from outlying areas. Aside from cinema, there are no other public entertainments; a *gānamēḷa* concert is a night out. The crowds are generally thought of as unruly; alcohol can be smelled on many breaths. D. Sasindran, my neighbor who is an English teacher at a local college, gently informed me about the class associations of evening festival programs such as *gānamēḷa*, and those who attend them, in terms of class and gender:

DS: And there is one more thing, the gentry folk generally don't go in the evening. Up to 7-8 [o'clock], then they return. So [after that] it is the other type of people who are sitting there.

EK: Like what type of people?

DS: What do you say, lower middle class, maybe. They want such things. And not even the womenfolk. Not much of the womenfolk will go in the night.

EK: Yeah, it's mostly men.

DS: And then they are found dancing there, according to these beats. So they want such music.

As Sasindran implies, the *gānamēḷa* performance is occasion for behaviors unbecoming of the 'gentry folk', such as drinking

20. Orchestras generally provide their own sound-system; the top orchestras own their own system, and the rest employ a trusted engineer and hire out equipment for each show. In this way *gānamēḷa* orchestras can be assured of being mixed in roughly the same way for every performance, and therefore are not plagued by the poor mixes and heavy distortion that often is a part of smaller festival programs, which are handled by electricians rather than sound engineers. Indeed, given that orchestras have a substantial electronic component, such that (aside from the percussion) there is little natural acoustic stage volume independent from the amplified sound, engineers are as responsible for constructing the group's total sound as are recording engineers. Engineers I observed did far more than simply set levels and leave them; they changed levels dynamically throughout the performance, for example bringing keyboard levels up and down for different sections of a song. For these reasons engineers are rightly considered part of the orchestra.

alcohol, and dancing, but which are expected of the 'lower middle class, maybe'. At Śāṅkaramkuḷaṅgara temple, for example, the *gānamēḷa* performance by the orchestra Thrissur Waves brought huge crowds, and a heavy police presence was evidently thought necessary to prevent unruliness.

At such performances, one often sees young men dancing about, while women sit quietly, in a separate area which is marked off with ropes.²¹ These gender roles are mirrored in the behavior of the male and female vocalists who front orchestras. While in the original film sequences, both male and female actors often dance in an overtly sexualized fashion, in the live *gānamēḷa* performance, females avoid presenting themselves sexually at all. Thus while male singers would strut about the stage while singing, dancing a bit or cinematically thrusting their hips, female singers always stood utterly and completely still and expressionless while singing.

4.3 *Gānamēḷa* performances outside of festivals.

Although the majority of an orchestra's work comes from festival programs, orchestra troupes also perform for public functions organized by local arts 'clubs'. Some of these clubs have names which index Sanskritic high-culture, such as Yuvajana

21. Spatially separating males from females is a part of a cultural practice found in other public spaces as well -- for example in buses -- of protecting women from the unpleasant attention from men who are apparently presumed incapable of preventing themselves from acting inappropriately, such that the only way to prevent it is to prevent males and females from even occupying the same space.

Kalābhavan ['young people's arts abode'], and some newer ones have tough-sounding English names like 'Deadly Boys' and 'Rebels'. Despite the difference in names, however, these clubs are essentially similar in social function. The clubs place a positive emphasis on community service, and one way they express this is by presenting cultural programs [*kalāparipāṭi*] for public enjoyment.²² Members are young men, who typically stop their engagement with club activities after getting married. Yuvajana Kalābhavan in Añcēri, a village area on the outskirts of Thrissur, had been active as a club for over 20 years. In addition to *gānamēḷas*, they also presented annual dramas, acted out by members of the club. Funds raised from such performances were used to supply books to poor students, and medicine and financial support to the elderly.

Rebels, a club located in the Arimpūr 'suburb' of Thrissur, had existed for only a year. I came to know about them when they presented an evening of cinematic dance followed by a *gānamēḷa* performance by Trance Orchestra, one of Thrissur's leading orchestras, on a temporary stage set up in an empty plot of land just off the main road. They went about arranging the performance much as a temple festival committee does: by going about in their community soliciting donations. The representatives of the club that I spoke with were very invested in *gānamēḷa*, and spent time going to performances whenever possible. However, Rebels was interested not only in such 'modern' entertainments, but also had plans to organize a

22. In their emphasis on community service and in their social structure, these clubs somewhat resemble the 'fan clubs' in urban Tamilnadu that Sara Dickey (2001) writes about.

performance of *tiruvātirakaḷi*, a nonspecialist women's 'folk' dance which has declined in recent times (cf. Venu 1990:89-95), during the next Ōṇam festival period.

4.4 Repertoire and reproduction.

The repertoire of a typical orchestra is essentially identical to that of a typical brass band, or 'bandset', despite their great differences in both instrumentation and performance contexts. Bandsets consist of several trumpets, clarinets, perhaps a euphonium, and a compliment of marching-band style drums, occasionally augmented with a *ceṇṇa* drum. Although in Tamilnadu and elsewhere in India, brass bands are primarily associated with wedding celebrations (Booth 1990, 1993; Boonzajer Flaes 2000:82), in Kerala they do not have such an association. Instead, their main role is to accompany religious festival processions. Most of their work comes from Christian festivals and processions, such as the *ampū perunṇāl* ['arrow holy day'] celebrated as part of St. Sebastian's feast, described in Chapter 2. They also frequently accompany Hindu *kāvaṭiyāṭṭam* or *kāvaṭi* dancing, which is generally associated with Murukan temple festivals.²³

When bandsets or *gānamēḷa* troupes perform, they play the most popular film songs of the day. When I asked M.D. Paul,

23. *Kāvaṭi* dancing is a form of penance or ritual vow fulfillment as practiced in Tamilnadu and among Tamils elsewhere (e.g., Collins 1997); in Kerala, however, it has become a conventionalized form which is performed in procession by paid professionals.

keyboardist and music director of Trance Orchestra, how he decided which songs to add to the repertoire, he replied (with a laugh), "According to the popular film. In India you know, film is the main art." Because repertoire is fully determined by popularity of songs as determined by star power and exposure on television channels, there is a great deal of overlap in the repertoire of different troupes. In addition, troupes must be ready for requests of older popular songs, and so keep a stock of these practiced as well. The same factors apply to bandsets.

The working schedules of both bandsets and *gānamēḷa* orchestras are determined by the calendar of the festival season; they have a few performances at Ōṇam time, and then are busy from November through April or early May. Troupes spend the rainy season every year learning all the new songs. Orchestra troupes learn new songs from the original studio-produced and commercially-released cassette. The music director -- generally the keyboardist, but in some older troupes like Kalāsadan, which predate the dominance of the synthesizer, the guitarist -- transcribes each part from the cassette, and hands out these parts to the other members. These written parts supplement members' own careful listening to the cassette. Members also practice their parts individually along with the cassette, in order to emulate the studio performance as precisely as possible. Although they are able to learn a few additional new hits during the busy festival season, by the next monsoon their songs are already a little out of date.

The festival season for bandsets begins slightly earlier than that of *gānamēḷa*, because they participate in the rituals

surrounding a Jacobite Christian function known as *koṭṭikkāyitam* ['flag-hoisting'], which begins in Kunnankulam in early September, and is celebrated on each church's anniversary day. This function exemplifies the long hours of playing generally required of bandset musicians. For this function, the bandset arrives at a church at 5:00 p.m. and begins playing while processing from house to house until 8:00 p.m. After a short rest, they start again and continue all night, until early morning. They then rest in the church until noon, have lunch, and then begin again. After visiting every house in the parish, they return to the church and are finished. Bandsets will have a program like this every week from September through November; occasionally there will be one also in December. Following that, the temple and church festival season is in full swing, and the bulk of the work consists of *ampū perunṇāl* and *kāvaṭiyāṭṭam*. One bandset leader estimated that 80% of the year's programs are church festivals. Despite this predominance of Christian performance settings, I was told that most of the bandset musicians are Hindu.²⁴

4.5 Feeding the floppy: digital technology and performance strategies.

When an orchestra troupe learns a new song, then, they do so with the utmost possible faithfulness to the studio recording. Originality is valued neither by audiences nor by

24. Pushpan, of Pushpan Bandset, estimated that 60% are Hindu, in which case they are represented proportionally to their total population in the state.

musicians themselves; rather, the skill and fidelity with which the orchestra re-creates the song is what audiences are looking for and what performers strive for. On the surface, then, the project of the orchestra seems straightforward: the music director transcribes the songs, each instrumentalist learns his part,²⁵ they rehearse as a group, and perform the songs. And in an earlier era, such indeed was the extent of the process. Today, however, because studio recording techniques have changed so drastically, re-creating a song live on stage is no longer such a simple matter. The manner in which orchestras use digital sequencing technology to solve this problem blurs the distinction between prerecorded and live music, and creates a dilemma for musicians as well as for listeners.

The single biggest change in the sound of film songs today is their use of electronic, rather than acoustic, instruments. Digitally synthesized or sampled instrument sounds can be used either for a specifically electronic effect, or to imitate existent acoustic instruments; in most contemporary songs, they are used in both ways. In the former case, the most widespread use of electronic sounds is to create heavy rhythms and percussive effects, as well as other kinds of purely electronic 'special effects' that add to the intensity of a song. Furthermore, such sounds are often sequenced, or programmed, in such a way that no human instrumentalist could replicate it, or at least not with the machine-like precision with which the computer can execute it. The Tamil film composer A.R. Rahman is

25. As far as I saw, instrumentalists were exclusively male.

generally credited with popularizing these kind of sounds, and they are now ubiquitous.²⁶

By using digitally synthesized sounds to imitate acoustic instruments, the costs of recording become very much reduced, for the simple reason that a song can contain a greater number and variety of instruments while fewer musicians need be hired. Of course, certain instruments can never be satisfactorily approximated by a digital synthesizer, such as a *nāgasvaram* or *vīṇa*, where *gamakas* or ornaments can be only very crudely approximated by the pitch-bend wheel of the MIDI keyboard; when such instruments are called for, they are nearly always recorded by actual acoustic instrumentalists. One does hear synthesized versions of Western instruments like saxophones and trumpets, however, and presumably these are acceptable because the sound of the actual instruments is less familiar to the audience of Malayāḷam film songs, and so the subtleties of the instruments' sound as played by a human performer are not missed.

The job of the orchestra troupe, then, is to reproduce in live performance a complex piece of music that was recorded using these digital techniques. The only way for the orchestra to do so, according to musicians, is to adopt digital sequencing or programming techniques themselves, and every orchestra in Thrissur has done so. The MIDI [Musical Instrument Digital Interface] keyboard is the central instrument in today's orchestras. These keyboards -- ones I saw in use include the

26. As noted above, it is such songs with heavy beats, and which generally contain a noticeable electronic component, that Malayāḷis refer to as *aṭipoli* songs, and that are thought to be most popular among the younger generation.

Korg N364, the Ensoniq TS10, and the Roland D-20 -- are equipped with 3.25" floppy disk drives and are capable of programmable multitimbral polyphony, which means that they can play the parts of several instruments at any one time, and all the keyboardist need do is to open up the correct MIDI file from a floppy disk and press start. The keyboard will then be supplying the drum machine part, the violin section, the chorus of flutes, as well as miscellaneous instrumental interludes that occur between verses or elsewhere in a song. If there is a violinist on stage, for example, chances are that he is at most playing along with an invisible chorus of such sequenced, synthesized 'violins'.

In fact, the keyboardist in contemporary orchestras need do little else other than press start; most of his work is in the preparation of the performance, rather than in the performing. And increasingly, for many members of the orchestra, including the violinist, flutist, guitarist, and electronic rhythm pad player, much of the performance is in creating the appearance of playing. I often listened very hard to try to hear the instruments I was seeing on stage, and in many cases concluded that their sound was present in the final mix, but only at a very low level, such that most of the work was indeed being done by the keyboard. The instruments that are still played 'manually', and obviously so, are the acoustic drums: *tabala*, triple-drum, and 'jazz' (rock drumset), although they are also often accompanied by presequenced electronic percussion.

A comparison of Tracks 11 and 12 on the CD will serve to illustrate this practice. Both are performances of the song

'Kannīrmazhayattū' from the 2000 hit Malayāḷam film, *Joker*.²⁷

The first is the original studio version, dubbed from the commercially-released cassette, and the second is from a live performance at a temple festival by Thrissur Trance Orchestra, recorded directly from the mixing board. This performance features Trance Orchestra's very accomplished flute player, who I was told also accompanies K.J. Yesudas, Kerala's premier playback singer, in live performance. Throughout the piece, Trance also makes use of a good deal of preprogrammed orchestration to effectively recreate every nuance of the original recording. The tempo and timing of these two versions are essentially identical, and so in the following description, timings will apply to both tracks.

The song begins with flute, synthesizer, and percussion. On the original version, the upper overtones of the flute are augmented with a clearly electronic sound, but Trance chooses to double the flute with a flute-like sound on the keyboard, giving the effect of a chorus of flutes. At 0:10, string orchestration makes its first entrance and an alto saxophone melody begins. On the original, actual saxophones are used, but Trance Orchestra covers both the string orchestration and saxophones with the synthesizer. The string parts are preprogrammed, but the saxophone line is performed live on the keyboard; saxophone 'gamakas' are performed using the pitch-bend wheel. The augmented flute line enters again at 0:20, once alone, and the second time doubled with a string section. The flute interlude

27. *Joker* was directed by Lohitadas. The music director for this film was Mohan Sithara, and the lyricist Yousaf Ali. 'Kannīrmazhayattū' was sung by K.J. Yesudas.

from 0:31-0:35 is supported by preprogrammed harmonization on the keyboard; when the same interlude is repeated at 0:40-0:45 it is accentuated with preprogrammed strings.

Aside from percussion, almost all sounds heard on the Trance version are in fact coming from the keyboard. In the instrumental interlude from 1:20 - 1:51, synthesized saxophone is followed by a featured string section, and when the vocal returns at 1:51, it is accompanied by occasional accents of strings or flute. Again, the flute is played by a flutist, but the strings are all preprogrammed and automated. The strings continue in the background until the end of the piece.

Throughout, percussion parts, too, are augmented by presequenced electronic percussion. It is often difficult to tell what is being played live and what is sequenced, but there are a number of clues to the presence of electronic percussion. One is that the performed version is the same tempo and length of the recorded version, indicating the absence of human rhythmic fluctuation. Another is that at the percussion interlude at 2:48-3:08, it becomes apparent that the fast drum solo is sequenced and played automatically rather than 'manually'. On stage, this part appears to be played by the electronic rhythm pad player, who is in fact featured at center stage. His role was to appear as if he were actually playing, which he did very enthusiastically and often convincingly; however, his part in this song and many others, as confirmed by members of the group, was in fact preprogrammed.

Although universally followed, this practice of 'feeding', or 'feeding the floppy',²⁸ as it is known, is a controversial one. On the one hand, audience members judge a performance by its faithfulness to the original, and it is safe to say that they know the original version very well: at any one time, there is a relatively small pool of songs which are popular, and these are in heavy rotation on television music channels and music programs, as well as in 'hotels' [restaurants], cassette stalls, and elsewhere. Even for me, as a visitor to Kerala, it did not take very long after my arrival to be aware of and to recognize the currently popular songs. Thus any deviation from the studio-recorded version of a song would certainly be noticed by audiences, and musicians have told me that audiences will shout and jeer if any such deviation occurs. Therefore, given the multiplicity of instruments and, more importantly, the very quick and mathematically precise performances that MIDI programming allows, orchestra members say they have no choice but to employ the same technology in re-creating the songs.

The problem is that audience members don't like to see an orchestra troupe performance which is fully automated; naturally, they have come for and want to experience a live performance, and musicians say that audience members will also protest vociferously if they suspect that 'feeding' is going on. Yet apparently, orchestras generally get away with it. In several interviews with *gānamēḷa* fans, the fans told me that while they know some orchestras use it, they also know that their favorite orchestras don't. One group of organizers even

28. The English words are used.

went so far as to say that, in hiring a particular orchestra for a program, they had stipulated that no feeding be used. They were satisfied that the condition had been met. However, the music director of the orchestra they hired told me in a separate interview that in fact, three-quarters of their songs for that performance (16 out of 21) were mostly programmed. Orchestras are thus publicly somewhat secretive about their use of 'feeding', and do their best to present the appearance of a live performance.

4.6 Distance, divinity, and *gānamēḷa*.

Because film song performances are a recent addition to temple festivals, there is a sense of uncertainty and experimentation in the planning process. After many conversations with committee members, temple devotees, and others who live in the vicinity of temples, I came to see that there is a certain amount of ambiguity regarding the proper role and function (and thus content) of festivals today. Temple committee members are in a process of redefining boundaries, of charting out a new role for festivals that may be acceptable in an era where previously existing boundaries have been soundly rejected, but where preserving a sense of sacredness or divinity in the temple seems to mandate that some boundaries are still necessary. Notions of preserving ritual purity by maintaining spatial distances, recalling practices around 'distance pollution' (discussed in Chapter Two), persevere, if ambiguously.

The first sign of this ambiguity was when committee members flatly denied any connection between the stage programs and the festival. When I first began inquiring about the role of *gānamēḷa* and related arts in temple festivals, I was on more than one occasion politely interrupted and told categorically that there is no connection between the *gānamēḷa* performance and the temple festival: at one temple the (adult) son of a committee member said, "It's not a part of, I beg your pardon, it is not a part of our temple festival." Likewise, when I attended the outdoor screening of a popular film that was a part of another temple festival (mentioned above), a committee member I met insisted that "there is no connection with the temple and this cinema." Such statements are initially puzzling, because of course by certain obvious criteria, the performance *is* connected to the festival: the event is listed in the festival schedule, and is held on or adjacent to temple property during the temple festival.

The connection being denied is one between the performance and the ritual observances that are ostensibly at the heart of the festival. What, then, is the status of such performances within the context of a festival? Why are they a part of the festival at all, and on what grounds are they deemed either desirable or unacceptable to different observers or participants? In order to address these questions, my assistant Ambika Menon and I carried out a series of interviews with people living in the area surrounding Śaṅkaramkuḷaṅgara Temple during the last days of its festival, where *gānamēḷa* and mimicry performances had drawn very large crowds. Perhaps because the interviews took place during the day while men were out working,

most of the interviews (including those quoted below, unless otherwise noted) were with women, nearly all of whom were of the Nāyar *jāti*.²⁹

Those who found the performances to be a fine addition to the festival did so by right away establishing a form of distance between the performance and the temple's rituals. In one interview with a woman living nearby the temple, my assistant Ambika's questioning was answered in the following way:

AM: You said that there was *gānamēḷa* here. There were *aṭipoli* songs for *gānamēḷa*. I heard that there were film songs and all. What do you think? Is it good?

Ajita: No problem. It is not inside the temple, it is here, outside. When [in the past] it was there in the temple, the songs were devotional. [Now] it is outside, in the ground; they haven't entered the temple.³⁰

Another woman, Janaki, answered a similar question by saying, "There is no problem. It will start only after the evening *pūja* at 7:30." For neither woman is the music concert connected in any way to the ritual, but each measures its detachment differently. For Ajita, and others who answered similarly, the issue is one of spatial distance from the ritually important area, while for the second woman, the bounds of ritual activity are established temporally.

29. As is the practice throughout this dissertation, names for all individuals other than those deemed public figures are pseudonyms.

30. The *gānamēḷa* concert was held within the temple grounds, in an area bounded by an outer wall, but outside of the temple itself, separated by a low wall about three feet high.

The issue of the spatial layout of the temple, and specifically the spatial relationship of the performance area to the temple's *śrīkōvil*, was central to many discussions of the role of the 'modern' entertainments to the temple festival. Arts such as *kūttū*, *kūṭiyāṭṭam*, or *ōṭṭan tuḷḷal*, which were described by an elderly Nāyar woman as "approved Hindu arts", may be performed inside the temple, but the new performance genres are in a decidedly different category. That spatiality was a contentious issue is illustrated by the fact that Archana, describing the same temple and the same festival as the women above, felt that the distance was insufficient, and thus disapproved of the *gānamēḷa* performance:

Since it is very near to the temple here, I don't think that it's right. There would be no problem if it were *bhaktigānamēḷa*.

Similar yet stronger sentiments were expressed by Sundari, another woman in the same neighborhood, again describing the same temple. In the following excerpt, Sundari expresses concern that the temple has been desacralized by its association with cinematic forms. For her, the space of the temple is defined not just by distance but by the sounds which fill it, and thus characterize it. If the temple is purified by the sound of a bell and mantras, then the sounds of *gānamēḷa* can interfere with that process.

S: We will never be ready to agree with it [having *gānamēḷa*]. As far as I am concerned, we don't need it. It [a festival program] should be something related to temple. I hate it very much. How to say -- we are going to god because he has got enormous power, so we can say that he doesn't like all these [*gānamēḷa*, mimicry, etc.]. He should have his own artforms, temple arts, that's my opinion. Then we can have a *bhaktigānamēḷa*. Now, there is no

difference between a cinema theatre and a temple compound.

AM: Do you think it is some kind of nuisance to the temple? Are these artforms like songs and mimicry any way harmful to the temple?

S: Now this *kalaśam* [ceremony for purification of the *pratiṣṭa*, or image] is done here from many days ago. The day before yesterday, the bell was ringing there, and here [in the ongoing stage programs] there is clapping and songs and all kinds of tumultuous noise [*bahalam*]. I believe that the *pavitrata* ['purity, holiness, sacredness'] is destroyed by this.

Some people I spoke with, particularly but not exclusively those of higher social standing (in terms of socio-economic status and/or caste), brought a social critique against the performances. One of my neighbors in particular -- a well-educated, Nāyar man who is married, has two children in college, and works as an engineer for the electricity board -- was very clear in his criticism not only of the daily temple broadcasts discussed in Chapter 2, but also of modern festival events, describing the latter as "very substandard activities". At the same time, he emphasized that he is "very much interested in temple activities and temple programs, [such as] this *tāyampaka*, *ceṇṭa mēḷam*, *pañcavādyam*," and attended such performances, and also that he appreciates and listens to cinema music in his home. However, the performance of such songs in public attracted a crowd with which he did not care to interact:

Naturally, mostly *gānamēḷa* is conducted in temple nowadays. But the audience are not standard people, they will be drunken people, and they will make unnecessary noise and shouting, so I am not at all interested in that noise. ... It is mostly for the interest of that type of audience. So I am not at all interested. That is the reason.

He also felt that *gānamēḷa* was not welcome on festival programs on the grounds that it is "entertainment. It is not at all

related to the temple activities." He makes this point especially in contrast to temple drumming genres, which are part of both a religious and a 'communal' tradition:

They are part of the communal tradition, and actually, this *tāyampaka* and *mēḷam* belongs to some god-ism also. It's divine [*daivīkamāyi kāryam*], related to god and goddess. When the idol is taken out onto the elephant, at that time the *mēḷam*, *tāyampaka*, *pañcavādyam* is going on, so it is related to god. It is a traditional *mēḷam*.

The issue of how various performances are or ought to be mapped onto the spatial layout of the temple has been addressed legislatively by the Cochin and Travancore Devaswom Boards, which manage most temples in central and southern Kerala, respectively. Temples are forbidden by the Cochin Devaswom Board from staging non-temple art performances inside the temple grounds. But exactly what constitutes 'inside' the temple, or on the temple grounds but 'outside' the temple, was ambiguous, and open seemingly open to interpretation from temple to temple. As an official of the Cochin Devaswom Board expressed it to me, "Such arts are not allowed within the temple compound. . . . In all temples we do not permit such arts in the compound walls." The problem in interpreting this prohibition is that every temple has at least two levels of walls, and I wasn't able to get consistent answers about which walls the performance had to be outside of (see Figure 3.1).

The prohibition could not refer to the *nālampalam* walls which surround the *śrīkōvil*, since no *kalāparipāṭi* of any kind ever happen inside the temple itself. But if it refers to the walls of the *prākāram*, then the rules are openly disregarded at many temples. Unless a performance is clearly outside of temple

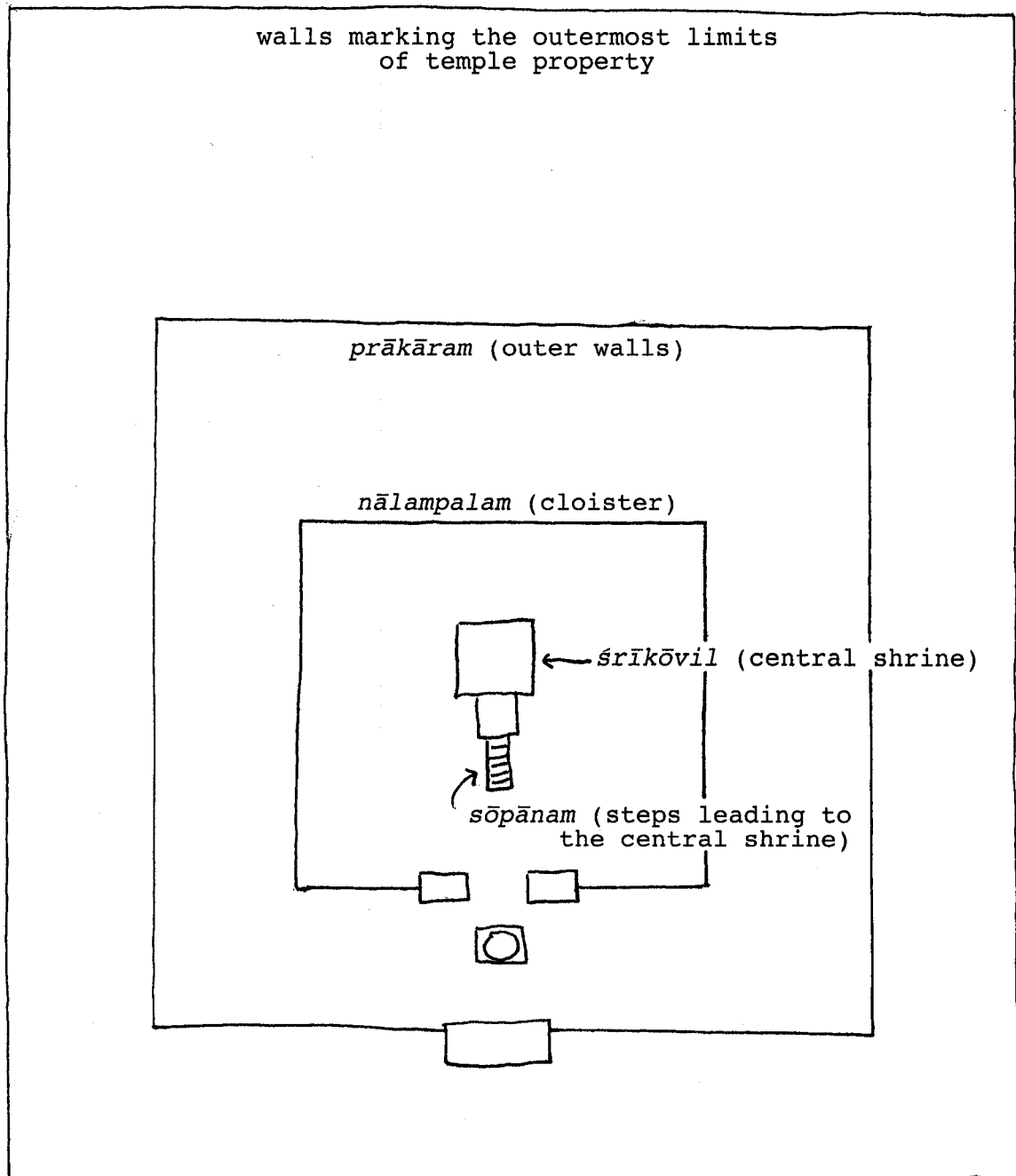


Figure 3.1 The spatial layout of a temple [*kṣētram*] (adapted from Groesbeck 1995:86).

property altogether, then subjective interpretations of relative distance come into play, and the propriety of the performance can be interpreted differently by different observers. Thus those who attended and approved of *gānamēḷa* performances agreed with others who clearly disapprove of them, in that the performances need to be kept a certain distance from the ritual center of the temple.

It is important to remember here that such notions that certain arts should be held inside and others outside the temple are nothing new. *Kathakaḷi* itself was not presented in temple festivals before the nineteenth century, and when it began to be presented in festivals it was also specifically held *outside* the compound walls, as noted above. Today, however, despite the insistence by connoisseurs, artists, and presenters, that it instead falls into the category of pure theater, many have come to think of it as a religious or ritual artform. This, apparently, was the thinking of the Cochin Devaswom Board official quoted above who told me that "classical music and *kathakaḷi* are permitted in the temple compound as part of the temple festival."

4.7 Connecting the temple with *gānamēḷa*.

In another sense, however, the temple does not want to be 'distanced' from the event at all: the event is after all hosted in order to draw crowds to the temple. When asked directly if the goal of the festival is to attract high numbers of attendees, committee members always said no, that they are

interested in qualitative rather than quantitative greatness. Nonetheless, it seems that at least on some level events are judged by the number of people who come to participate in them. There is no doubt that a large program is thought to add to the prestige and renown of a temple: one temple secretary said that the reason they had hired a famous orchestra troupe was so that "the name of Tiruvāṇattū Temple will become known to others".

In specific ways, temple festival committees show a great eagerness to associate these popular performances with not only the temple, but the deity itself. At Śaṅkaramkuḷaṅgara Temple, for example, a banner with the following message emblazoned across it was displayed on the front of the *gānamēḷa* orchestra stage, such that it occupied a single visual frame with the performers, thereby explicitly connecting the performance on the stage to the worship of the goddess:

*dēvī sahāyam
śrī śaṅkaramkuḷaṅgara kṣētrattile
pratiṣṭā dināghōṣam*

The first line can be approximated as, 'may the goddess help or protect us', and the second and third lines announce the purpose of the festival, the 'celebration of the anniversary of installing the image of the deity at Śrī Śaṅkaramkuḷaṅgara Temple'.

For one woman living nearby, the performance established its connection to the temple -- and thus its legitimacy -- by virtue of beginning its set with one or two devotional songs, as is the standard practice for church or temple shows: "They didn't sing film songs only. They started it with devotional

songs." Thus even though those first one or two songs were the only devotional ones of the performance, they were enough to establish an authentic connection to the purposes of the festival.

Because organizers and committee members know that the *gānamēḷa* will attract far more people than any other event in the festival, it is in fact often scheduled to coincide with ritual events at the temple for which they hope to have good attendance. At my neighborhood Murukan temple festival, *kāvaṭi* dancers, along with *nāgasvaram* ensembles, were scheduled to move in procession from Vaṭakkunāthan temple at the center of Thrissur, beginning at 9:00 p.m., and to arrive at our temple at midnight. A *gānamēḷa* performance was scheduled to insure that people would be there to greet them, as the president of the temple committee explained to me:

When the *kāvaṭi* dancers comes to the temple, late at night, only the *kāvaṭi* dancers and their people are there. But if we arrange an orchestra like this, they [an audience] will stay for that. Then they'll be there when the *kāvaṭi* arrives at midnight.

A Brāhman insurance salesman who lives in the neighborhood echoed the same sentiment, from an audience member's point of view:

Here also in that particular festival, that *puyyam*, the *kāvaṭi* is coming at about 1:00 [a.m.], so the people have to wait from 7 until 1:00 to see that. So, in between that time, some *gānamēḷa* orchestra, that will be very enjoyable.

Summary.

The cultural programs of temple festivals constitute an arena in which the place of temples in a changing social context is actively redefined. Presenting musical and performance genres which are intertwined with the forms of mass media, particularly cinema and television, allows temples to reinvent themselves as modern and as relevant in contemporary society. Presenting such arts is also seen more pragmatically by committee members as a means to attract people to the temple, and thereby to receive donations needed to support the temple. As a result of the Land Reforms, temples are no longer parasitic landlords, and thus in order to support the temple and its festival, committees must raise the funds by soliciting donations from the public at large by going door to door and asking for donations at each house. Rarefied and elitist artforms such as *kathakali* do not attract crowds, and they do not attract great financial support from the general public either. Temple festivals now exist in a context of the variety of entertainments offered on cable television channels, and essentially must compete with such offerings in order to draw people to the temple. For this reason, many cultural programs staged at today's festivals are, in form and content, more indebted to television than to traditional temple arts.

The live performance of current cinema songs by a *gānamēḷa* 'orchestra' is the biggest attraction of contemporary temple festivals, and orchestras remain busy with performances throughout the long festival season. Presenting studio-produced music in live performance presents a number of interesting

issues concerning the boundaries between live and recorded music. For example, orchestras rely heavily on digital sequencing technology, or 'feeding', in performance, a matter which is controversial among audiences.

As the new genres of *gānamēḷa*, mimicry, and cinematic dance have entered into temple festivals, previously existing 'secular' forms such as *kathakaḷi* have, due to longstanding association or proximity with the temple festival performance context, become reconfigured in the popular imagination as 'religious', rather than as purely theatrical. At the same time, people struggle with how to reconcile the new arts, which bring to the festival a new frame of reference -- namely that of commercialized entertainment and mass-mediated cultural forms -- with the social and the physical space of the temple, even as the temple itself is recontextualized within the framework of a very different society from the one in which it developed. The complexity of this process is illustrated in that while temples clearly value being associated with the technology, modernity, and contemporary relevance which are indexed by the performances, there is also ongoing negotiation within the culture about the relative sequencing or placing, whether spatial or temporal, that must be effected between the ritual space of the temple and the performances.

CHAPTER FOUR

IDENTITY AND ELECTRONICS IN THE NEW LITURGICAL MUSIC OF THE SYRO-MALABAR CATHOLIC CHURCH

Introduction.

In this chapter I narrow my focus to a particular community, that of the Christians of the Syro-Malabar Catholic Church. I focus specifically on the liturgical music of its main ritual, the Sunday morning *qurbāna* or Celebration of the Eucharist, and to a lesser extent on the closely related Christian devotional music which is released on cassettes and intended for home use. Specifically, I analyze the place of this music with relation to an ongoing debate within the Syro-Malabar Church concerning how best to implement the Second Vatican Council's call for 'inculturation', or the manifestation of the liturgy through locally meaningful forms, in the context of what has been described as "an identity crisis" for Syrian Christians (e.g., Mundadan 1984:102).

Ethnomusicologists have repeatedly demonstrated in different ways that music is a powerful vehicle for creating and expressing social identities (e.g., Stokes 1994; Waterman 1990;

Hebdige 1987; Lockard 1998). In this chapter, I argue that Syro-Malabar liturgical music has arrived in its current form primarily in response to pressures to fashion a specifically Indian Christian identity for Syro-Malabar Catholics, in a context which prominently includes the forces of popular culture and technologization which are embodied in mass media, especially television and cinema. The new music introduced in the 1960s was originally intended and functioned successfully as a form of 'Indianization' which promoted a sense of group belonging that emphasized India's independent, secular modernity rather than its Hindu-dominated cultural heritage. Within the past 10-15 years, however, with the pervasive influence of electronic instruments and commercial cinema song styles, for many participants the increasingly technologized and commercialized music connotes a variety of 'Westernization' which appears to problematize the aims of Vatican II.

In order to understand the ways in which groupness is signified by the music of the Syro-Malabar *qurbāna*, a Peircean semiotic analysis along the lines proposed by Turino (1999) will be useful. The music of the *qurbāna* functions both indexically and iconically to support the construction and maintenance of social identity in ways that have changed since a new genre was introduced in the 1960s. My analysis pays particular attention to the music's indexical significations. As Turino remarks,

Indices are grounded in one's personal and social life and thus are constitutive of identity -- both in the sense of being part-and-parcel of one's personal past, as well as being signs of shared social experience. . . . [I]ndices are frequently harnessed for the construction of social identities -- in advertising, in mass political rallies and propaganda, and in ritual and ceremonies -- because of

their emotion-producing potentials and as pre-existing signs of identity [1999:235, 236]

The music of the *qurbāna* carries implications for how Syrian Christians understand their cohesion as a group within a complex network of relations. By virtue of a diverse set of musical references, including Syrian chant, cinematic 'light music', Karnātak vocal flourishes, Western harmonies, recent Hindi and Tamil popular music, and electronic instruments, this network includes their Indian ancestry, their East Syriac religious heritage, the Western Catholicism with which they are now in allegiance, and a 'modern', capitalist, secular, cosmopolitan India which is increasingly interconnected with a technology-driven world.

For the Syrian Christians of Kerala, questions around how to understand one's own groupness or 'cultural identity' are not new. Kerala Christians have for nearly two thousand years lived in an unsteady balance between the cultural worlds of West Asia, their immediate environment, and the various forces of European Christianity they have encountered. Most recently, the Second Vatican Council of 1962-1965 brought the issue of cultural identity to the forefront, when it encouraged congregants around the world to celebrate the mass and express the Christian message through local cultural forms. In India, then, the project taken up was one of 'Indianization' of the mass. At first such an idea seems straightforward, but implementing it has proven exceedingly complicated for a country which has always been involved in international trade with both West and East Asia, and for a religious group which is a minority culture within that country, and which has maintained close cultural and

religious connections to the Mesopotamian church for over fifteen hundred years. Furthermore, Kerala's international connections have only expanded in recent years. Given such a complex scenario, when the Church says to celebrate the mass through local cultural forms, which of the many cultural roots get prioritized? Although Malayāḷi Christians do see themselves as deeply Indian, they conceptualize what 'Indianization' of the mass may mean in divergent ways. Indeed, in the context of a very rapidly changing society, the very idea of what it is to be 'Indian', and what is 'Indianness', is at issue. For example, can what is traditionally 'Indian' be separated from what is 'Hindu', and should it?

In the Syro-Malabar Church's implementation of Vatican II, there has been a great deal of debate and disagreement about what kind of cultural identity is the right kind for Kerala Christians. One priest articulated what he saw as the problem quite clearly as follows:

And now the present thing is, this is a big historical problem: there is an identity crisis for Indian Christians. Because we don't have a strong local culture, still. We are not deeply rooted in the local culture. At the same time, in this implemented culture, we are not so strong, the Syrian or the Latin. So we are in between. We are in what I would call a cultural dilemma. Therefore in Kerala, in church singing we have a combination of all these three. We have a mixing of Indian style -- *rāgas* and *tālas* will come -- at the same time we have Western music mixing -- all synthesizer, Western notation, Western instruments, everything is coming -- then at the same time Syrian style of singing. There is a mixture of all these three or four traditions.

Examining the ways in which participants talk about or evaluate the music of the mass illuminates the ways in which culture and cultural identity are constructed, for the question at hand is

that of what kind of musical forms are appropriate in order to support or signify a coherent cultural identity. In this chapter I discuss two strains of development: first, I consider the actual path music has taken over the past 30 years within the Syro-Malabar Church, and seek to understand the various meanings the music has for participants. Following that, I take up alternate paths which have been and are being proposed, most notably the perhaps more radical goals of 'Indianization' of the liturgy which are represented by the National Biblical, Catechetical and Liturgical Centre (NBCLC) in Bangalore and actively pursued by the Dharmaram College in Bangalore,¹ but which have been slow to attain popular acceptance.

Methodologically, I make use of observations of church musical performances, and discussions with musicians, composers, clergy, and ordinary church-goers about the music itself and its significations. Discussions include casual conversations with friends as well as more formal 'interviews', for which my assistant, Ambika Menon, aided in translation as necessary. We talked with Christian neighbors of mine to whom I was introduced by my Christian next-door neighbors, and we also walked through the entirely Christian neighborhood of Aranattukara, knocking randomly on doors and interviewing whoever answered. In such cases we were generally received warmly, thanks in great part to Ambika Menon's impressive social skills.

1. Dharmaram College, though located in Karnataka rather than Kerala, is the central training center of the Syro-Malabar priests of the order of Carmelites of Mary Immaculate (CMI).

There are several categories of *qurbāna*, which is Syriac for 'offering' but is commonly referred to in English as the Eucharist or using the more Latinized 'mass'. In this chapter I am concerned with the primary religious service which is performed every Sunday morning, known as the *pāṭṭuqqurbāna*, or 'musical mass'.² Considering the *qurbāna* as a cultural performance, a central way that Syro-Malabar Christians in Thrissur reinforce their cultural and religious identity is by regularly attending the *qurbāna*, where they sing and pray together as a group. These regular meetings in the church are an integral part of the cultural life of most Christians.³ With only one exception (an unmarried man who described himself as "losing [his] belief in god"), everyone in the houses we dropped in on claimed to go to church at least every Sunday, and often - like their Hindu neighbors -- every morning.

2. On weekday mornings, a simple mass without choir, or *ottaqqurbāna*, is performed. There are several other forms of *qurbāna* as well. Observances of the *rāza*, or most solemn mass for the living and for the dead, still consist of Syriac chants in the pre-Vatican II style. I do not discuss this genre here; for documentation and discussion of Syriac chant, I recommend the CD, *Qambel Māran: Syriac Chants from South India* (Palackal 2002), and also Palackal 1995 and 1999.

3. As one Catholic priest pointed out, a salient difference between Christianity and Hinduism is that the former is a 'group cult' and the latter an 'individual cult': Christians go to church together every Sunday, some every morning, and if they are absent, I was told, someone will ask them why. Hindus, meanwhile, may also go to the temple every morning but they do so in a solitary fashion, not to meet others and to be a part of a group ritual but rather to perform their own rituals, alone.

Section 1. *Qurbāna* in cultural context.

1.1 A Syro-Malabar *qurbāna*.

It is nearing 6:30 on a Sunday morning and people are still walking down the street towards St. Mary's Church. Men and women often walk together to the church, but as they approach the building they separate and approach different entrances. Most slip off their shoes as they enter, but some do not. Men fill the pews on one side of the church and women, with sari or *kavaṇi* cloth drawn up over their heads, on the other. The church is a large one, built in European-influenced style, but with wide open doors and windows and spinning ceiling fans extending from the vaulted roof to allow circulation in this tropical climate. A colorful image of a light-haired Jesus on the cross is depicted in bas-relief on the wall behind the altar. The church is full this morning, as usual, and people are still coming in through the side entrances. I switch on my minidisc recorder just as the ringing of church bells outside coincides with the ringing of microphone feedback through the loudspeakers inside as the music begins; this atonal feedback is gradually brought under control.⁴

The Sunday morning *pāṭṭuqqurbāna* begins with one song performed by the choir alone, and then a number of songs in succession which contain parts sung in alternation by the priest, the choir, and the congregation, lasting for the first 20-25 minutes of the service. These songs are part of the

4. Track 13 on the accompanying CD.

liturgy itself, and the congregation can follow along with the Malayālam text in small orange books which are provided.⁵ In consonance with the model of sonic immersion which I discussed in Chapter Two, the music is loudly amplified through loudspeakers which are mounted in the front of the church and along both side walls. The most prominent instrumental sounds are those of a digital keyboard and amplified percussion. In other Syro-Malabar churches, electronic drum sounds are commonly heard, but here *tabala* and other hand drums are used to give rhythmic energy to each song. As with contemporary cinema music, many verses are sung by solo male and female vocalists and are interspersed with instrumental interludes which sound like they are being played on a variety of instruments, but which are all synthesized on the keyboard.

The vocal style, both in terms of vocal timbres and of stylistic features, sounds quite similar to that heard in contemporary popular cinema songs, and the loudness and electronic orchestration underscore that association. In my conversations with church-goers, I found that people often had mixed responses to this new music, which has been developing in the church since the 1960s. Whether individual participants said they liked or disliked the new styles, the way they spoke of their personal way of interacting with the sensory environment of the *qurbāna* indicated something of their perceptions of the relationship between the church and its multiple heritages -- West Asian, European, Indian, and perhaps

5. *Sīrōmalabār sabhayude kurbānakramam*, or 'the order of the Syro-Malabar Qurbāna' (no date, publisher, or other information provided).

most notably, the rapidly changing society of which it is most immediately a part, which is in many ways increasingly cosmopolitan, in step with a capitalist, entertainment-oriented, technology-driven world.

The story I tell in this chapter is that of just one denomination of Christians in Kerala, albeit the most populous; the music in other Churches has followed different trajectories from that of the Syro-Malabar Church, and it is in this pluralistic context that the development of music in the Syro-Malabar Church must be seen. For example, the atmosphere at Ignatious Syrian Orthodox Church, which follows a West Syrian rite, is decidedly 'Oriental'. Sunday morning worshippers sit on a floor which is carpeted with rough matting, and many different styles of lamps hanging in matched pairs hang from the ceiling. As can be heard on Track 14 of the CD, the service consists of vocal chant by the congregation in the Syriac style, without instrumental accompaniment except occasional bells, led by the priest, whose microphone is routed to four 'Soundcraft' speaker boxes. The Protestant Church of South India (CSI), in contrast, very much resembles the Protestant church in Minnesota to which I was brought week after week as a child. The congregation wears shoes into the church and sits in pews. The choir consists of eight women and sixteen men dressed in choir-robes who sing without microphones, and are accompanied by a console organ which, though electric, is analog (rather than digital) and sounds to my ears like a 'church organ'. As can be heard on Track 15, the choir sings Protestant hymns in the European musical style, but with Malayālam lyrics. Of the various denominations in Kerala, only the music of the Latin

Catholic Church has much in common with that of the Syro-Malabar Church. Before describing the recent development of Syro-Malabar Church music, however, it will be useful to back up and consider the history of the Syrian Christians in Kerala.

1.2 Syro-Malabar Christians in Kerala society.

Christians in Kerala occupy a different category than they do in other regions of India. The election of the Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Parishad ('Indian People's Party', or BJP) to lead the Government of India in 1998 was a major victory for Hindu fundamentalist groups associated with the BJP such as the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh ('National Volunteers Association', or RSS), and Bajrang Dal, and the Vishwa Hindu Parishad ('World Hindu Council', or VHP). These fascistic groups have been in operation for a long time -- Gandhi's assassin was a Hindu Brāhman member of the RSS -- but since the 1998 election, they have asserted themselves by perpetrating extremely violent attacks against Muslims and Christians in Gujarat, Orissa, and other states, reaching as far south as the state of Karnataka. The attacks against Muslims have received the most attention, but incidents involving Christians have involved Hindu men raping nuns and killing monks, nuns, and priests, as well as vandalizing or destroying places of worship. The attacks have coincided with demands from the RSS, the ideological parent of the BJP, that Christian churches either leave India or else 'Indianize'. K.C. Sudarshan, leader of the RSS (and advisor to Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee), says that he fears that foreign-controlled churches are conspiring to

undermine Hinduism through conversion and thus to destabilize India.⁶

Such anti-Christian sentiment has been largely absent from Kerala, however, in part because the history of Christianity in this state is unique in India. Even K.C. Sudarshan recognizes Kerala Christian churches as indigenous or 'swadeshi', and holds them up as a model for churches elsewhere in India to follow.⁷ Thus although the RSS does have a strong presence in Kerala, its aims appear to be different, at least in that Christian churches are not among their most active targets. One reason for this is that it is generally taken for granted that Christians do 'belong' in Kerala. Kerala Christian identity is perceived by both Christians themselves and others as of a different category than that of Christians elsewhere in India. As a Hindu friend related it, while Christians in Maharashtra, for example, may say that they are Christians first and Maratha only second, Christians in Kerala are Malayāli first, and Christians only second.

This unique sense of cultural belonging of Kerala Christians is rooted in the fact that Christianity is not a recent arrival in Kerala, but is in fact considered to be as old there as it is anywhere else in the world. According to the generally accepted story, the Apostle Thomas came himself to Kodungallor (called Cranganore by the Europeans) in present-day Thrissur District, which by the first century C.E. was well-

6. 'Set up swadeshi church: RSS', *The Hindu*, 8 October 2000.

7. 'RSS, Church leaders meet', *The Hindu*, 28 November 2001.

established in trade with West Asia (cf. Karayil 1995:31; Thomas 1993:17). The subsequent history is a long and exceedingly complex one; here I will provide only a superficial sketch, in order to provide a sense of the forces and shifts in allegiances which may have influenced the St. Thomas Christians' sense of groupness over the centuries, and thus of what is at stake in this discussion of a 'Kerala Christian identity' in this post-modern world.⁸

The Syro-Malabar Church is the largest of many Christian churches in Kerala. At present there are three major groups of churches, each of which contains numerous subdivisions: Syrian Christians (of which the Syro-Malabar Church is one subdivision), Latin Catholics, and Protestants. The Syrian Christians, also known as St. Thomas Christians, are the most numerous and by all accounts the oldest, since it is they who trace their origins to conversions by the Apostle Thomas himself. The population was bolstered by Syrians who migrated to Kerala in the fourth and ninth centuries, bringing with them bishops from Baghdad and elsewhere in Mesopotamia, and introducing Syrian liturgical forms (Thomas 1993:23).

Well before the Portuguese arrived, the Syrian Christian community was in many ways 'indigenized', or accepted as a part of the local society. But in Kerala, Swami Vivekananda's 'madhouse of caste', this meant that rather than existing outside of the 'caste system', Christians were integrated into a

8. For more on the general topic of Christianity in Kerala, see e.g. Bayly 1989, Brown 1982 [1956], Mundadan 1970 and 1984, Thomas 1993, Visvanathan 1993.

system of group differences; historically, Christian groups have thus assumed positions as castes within the Hindu-oriented social structure. Tradition holds that Thomas converted the first Christians mainly from the Brāhman caste, and the group rights historically claimed by the Syrian Christians were in accord with a status on a par with Nāyars (cf. Bayly 1989:284). Furthermore, in order to preserve their high social status, they have been "reluctant to baptize and accept low-caste Hindus into their religion. Hence, the growth of their community is conditioned mainly by the natural process of births and deaths" (Rajan and James 2000:111).

When Portuguese missionaries arrived in Kerala with Vasco de Gama in 1498, then, they found a Syrian Christian community whose manner of dress and daily habits appeared almost indistinguishable from those of their high-caste Hindu neighbors, both Nāyars and Nampūtiris (Mundadan 1970:66, 121-125), but whose liturgical forms, including language and music, were Syriac (Palackal 1999:177). The Syrian Christians are often said to have lived in 'two worlds', as in the following histories from the late 1960s:

They had been living for centuries in two worlds at the same time. The first of these two worlds was the geographical, political and social environment of Malabar; the second, the ecclesiastical world of the East Syrian or the Chaldean Church, whose prelates governed them, whose faith, whose laws and whose mode of worship they shared. [Mundadan 1967:1]

The Christians of St. Thomas appear to have lived in two worlds at the same time, but with no consciousness of tension between them or disharmony within themselves. They were Christians of Mesopotamia in faith and worship and ethic; they were Indians in all else. In church they professed belief in one Almighty God, out of church they observed omens and propitious days and were content to

recognise the existence of Hindu gods, though they did not worship them. [George Kurien, *The Indian Family in Transition*, p. 35, cited in Koshy 1968:16]

Like Nāyars, the Syrian Christians engaged in military service; the Christians also shared many customs with the Nāyars such as tying a *tāli* in marriage ceremonies, vegetarianism during mourning and ritual bathing to remove death pollution (Visvanathan 1993:3), and observing pollution avoidance following childbirth (Kariyil 1995:32). For an extensive account of customs practiced in common with Nāyars and also with Nampūtiri Brāhmans, see also Brown (1982).

The arrival of Portuguese missionaries meant that the Syrian Christians "were prepared and initiated into a life in three worlds" (Mundadan 1967:1), as the newcomers insisted that local practitioners assume Latin Catholic rites. Rivalry between the Syrian bishops, to whom Kerala Christians were loyal, and the Portuguese continued for a century. The situation came to a head in 1599 with the famous Synod of Udayampērūr (usually anglicized as Diamper), where the Portuguese "induced the entire Syrian priesthood to repudiate their allegiance to the west Asian Catholicos, to abjure all un-Catholic doctrines and observances, and to swear allegiance to the Roman See" (Bayly 1989:266). Kerala Christians were unhappy with being forced to align their cultural and religious practices with these foreign newcomers. The result of this discontent was the Koonen Cross Revolt against the Portuguese in 1652, which as Bayly explains, had long-lasting effects on the ways in which different groups of Kerala Christians have identified with various cultural traditions:

[A]lthough the Syrians had always possessed an unstable system of church leadership, it was this collision with the Portuguese which created a lasting cleavage between Roman Catholic Syrians owing allegiance to European missionary bishops, and those known as 'Jacobites' or 'Orthodox' Syrians who recognised the authority of the hereditary Pakalamarram metrans. After the so-called revolt of the Koonen cross, the St Thomas Christian Syrians were left with a divided structure of authority which was to generate dissension and violence for the next 200 years. [Bayly 1989:269]

By 1930 the Syrian Christians were divided into five independent churches: the Syro-Malabar Church, which is the largest and the focus of this chapter, the Church of the East (Nestorian Church), the Syrian Orthodox Church, the Syro-Malankara Church, and the Mar Thoma Church. The liturgy of the first two of these is known as Chaldean, and was originally in the East Syriac language, and the liturgy of the others is known as Antiochean or more commonly as Jacobite, and was originally in West Syriac. Of these, the Syro-Malabar and the Syro-Malankara are Catholic faiths which maintain allegiance with the Vatican; their liturgies have been translated into Malayālam. The Syrian Orthodox and Mar Thoma churches, however, still conduct liturgies at least partially in Syriac (Palackal 1999).

In sum, it seems that ever since the arrival of the Portuguese, Kerala Christians of all denominations have been occupied with the task of trying to refigure the place and shape of Christianity with respect both to the dominant Christian leaderships abroad, and to the dominant local culture at home. These tensions between dominant cultures at odds with one another have helped to shape the dynamic nature of Christian identity in today's rapidly changing world(s).

Section 2. Composing culture.

2.1 Vatican II: Innovation, Indianization, and Inculturation.

For the purposes of my analysis, this story begins with the Second Vatican Council (commonly referred to as Vatican II). Vatican II was announced by Pope John XXIII on 25 July 1959 and convened in Rome in 1962, with the explicit goal of a "positive engagement of the modern world" (Schreiter 1999:159). Previously, the church and papal policy had been oriented against the projects of 'modernity', with modernity here considered as the result of the European Enlightenment. In his 1864 *Syllabus of Errors*, for example, Pope Pius IX condemned ideas such as the separation of church and state, and at the turn of the twentieth century the church condemned historical-critical scholarship as undermining the authority of the church. Councils, too, had in the past been held in response to perceived threats to the church; indeed, Vatican I was held in 1869 "to reassert the church's position over against the forces of liberalism and other consequences of the Enlightenment" (Schreiter 1999:158-159). In this historical context, the decision to hold a council not to condemn but to positively engage modernity represented a sea-change in the attitude of the church.

Two of the most immediate and best-known results of Vatican II center around the goal of increasing the congregation's sense of *participating* in the mass. These are found in the first document to be issued from the Council, the *Sacrosanctum concilium* (*Constitution on the Sacred Liturgy*). The first was

that instead of leading the congregation in prayer by facing the nave, with his back to the congregation, the celebrant of the liturgy face the people. This change in orientation implies a theological and psychological shift in focus from a god which is beyond the people but accessible to the leader, to a mutual celebration of the deity's immediate presence between those assembled. Within the Syro-Malabar Church, there is apparently some resistance to this change in Changanassery and other southern dioceses of Kerala where there is stronger loyalty to the Chaldean (Syrian) liturgical forms, but people I spoke to in Thrissur felt that the change led to a greater feeling of participation in the liturgy (cf. Kanichikattil 1992:58).

Concomitant with this newly introduced intimacy, masses all over the world were translated into and performed in local vernacular languages, rather than in Latin or, in the case of the Syro-Malabar church, Syriac. The act of conducting the mass in a language readily understandable to all had profound implications for people's ability to understand and to feel as if they were an integral part of what was happening.⁹

The move to local languages placed the final stamp on the new sense of participation, confirming an engagement with people's sense of themselves as free, participating agents in their own future. [Schreiter 1999:163]

People in Thrissur who remembered the change spoke of being able to understand what was being said, of being "in the know of

9. In the case of Kerala, however, one might speculate that since the dominant Hindus conduct their rituals in the language of their gods, Sanskrit, it might not have seemed strange or unusual at all for Christians to conduct rituals in the even more distant, mysterious, and therefore powerful language of Syriac.

things", only after this shift, and find the Malayālam liturgy very satisfying.

While the *Sacrosanctum concilium* describes a change in the way people participate within the context of ritual, later among the Council's sixteen documents we find others which address the ways in which human beings in general come to 'participate' in their worlds. What becomes more developed in the 1970s as the doctrine of inculturation has its roots in the documents *Gaudium et spes* (the Pastoral Constitution dealing with the Church in the Modern World), *Ad gentes* (the Decree on Missionary Activity), and *Nostra Aetate* (the Declaration on the Relation of the Church to Non-Christian Religions). These documents have particular resonance for the so-called 'mission churches', a category which includes the Kerala churches.¹⁰ The documents express a relatively sophisticated notion of 'culture' in which it is acknowledged that it is only through culture that people become fully human:

It is one of the marks of the human person to reach true and authentic humanity only through culture, that is, by cultivating natural gifts and values. Whenever human life is involved, nature and culture are intimately connected.

In its general sense the word 'culture' stands for everything by which human beings refine and develop their various capacities of mind and body. It includes efforts to control the cosmos by knowledge or by work, as well as ways of humanizing social life within the family or civic community through the progress of customs and institutions. [Paragraph 53, cited in and translated by Gallagher 1998:37]

10. There is some irony in this, given that Christianity has existed for a much longer time in Kerala than it has in Europe.

The Church first officially recognized the plurality of cultures in 1944, with an address given by Pope Pius XII wherein he declares that local usages and customs should be preserved and developed, showing that the Vatican had accepted that they would have to somehow work through local cultures in order to maintain relevance in the contemporary world.¹¹ With the documents that emerged from Vatican II, the Church provided for the first time a theological or doctrinal underpinning for this necessity.

The idea that liturgy should be reformed and adapted "especially in the case of the administration of the sacraments, the sacramentals, processions, liturgical language, sacred music, and the arts" (*Sacrosanctum concilium* 39, cited in Mattam 1976:69) came to be included in the larger concept of 'inculturation'. According to this central notion, not only such liturgical forms but simply the day-to-day aspects of living a Christian life must be made manifest through local practices:

Inculturation is the incarnation of the Christian life and of the Christian message in a particular cultural context, in such a way that this experience not only finds expression through elements proper to the culture in question (this alone would be no more than a superficial adaptation) but becomes a principle that animates, directs and unifies the culture, transforming it and remaking it so as to bring about a "new creation". [Fr. Pedro Arrupe, S.J., in a *Letter to the Whole Society on Inculturation*, 1978, cited in Burns 2001:84]

The process of implementing Vatican II in Kerala's Syro-Malabar Church has been long and divisive, continues up to the

11. Pope Pius XII, 'Address to Pontifical Mission Aid Societies', cited in Burns 2001:91.

present, and will doubtless continue to guide decisions made by Church leaders well into the future. This is perhaps in the nature of the project; as one Malayāli Christian scholar notes,

Inculturation can not be a 'fait accompli' at any time. It has to go on as a process. Accordingly it demands continuous questioning, evaluation, reformulation, reformation and reliving of the tradition in the context of particular cultural realities. [Mulloor 1991:3]

In what is sometimes described as a debate between liturgical *renewal* and liturgical *reform* (e.g., Kanichikattil 1992), opposing positions have been staked out and sometimes bitter factions have formed. Positions on issues from what form of music best suits the mass, to what other liturgical practices should be followed, in large part come down to differences in the way the question of 'what/whose tradition is our tradition' is addressed. Kerala, a connecting point on ancient trade routes, continues to find itself pulled between opposing cultural forces: the Syro-Malabar Church's arrow of tradition is variously pointed towards Syria, Rome, an ancient India shared by the Hindus, or a cosmopolitan India in step with a technology-driven world.

2.2 The appropriation of 'light music' for liturgical purposes.

At the time of Vatican II, the headquarters of the Syro-Malabar Church was in Ernakulam, under the leadership of Archbishop (later Cardinal) Joseph Parecattil. This diocese began a 'modernization process' in response to Vatican II which was to have profound effects not only on the music of the Syro-

Malabar Church, but also on the evolution and culture of film music in Kerala society quite broadly. In the liminal period during which the mass was being translated by numerous groups and various translations awaited approval from the headquarters in Rome, a new translation by a young priest named Fr. Abel Periyappuram, of the Carmelites of Mary Immaculate order (CMI), was brought out and set to music. Originally, the familiar Syriac melodies were still sung, but with Malayāḷam words rather hastily substituted. However, it was felt that the fit was not right, and that new melodies should be composed which would be more apt vehicles for the Malayāḷam words and which furthermore would be in a truly Malayāḷam style themselves. Thus Fr. Abel came to collaborate with the composer K.K. Antony with the goal of honoring Vatican II by composing new liturgical songs and music which would somehow reflect a musical approach that was purely Malayāḷam.

The problem was that while Malayāḷi Christians had traditions of vocal music and dance, such as *mārgamkaḷi* and *caviṭṭunāṭakam*, these existed in spheres separate from that of the liturgy and were not influential when it came to revamping the mass along indigenous lines (cf. Palackal 1995). Furthermore, Malayāḷi Christians lacked strong traditions of 'classical' art music. Classical Karnātak music was understood to be the domain of Hindus, and Christian children were discouraged from pursuing it. Thus when it came time to develop new music for the mass, Abel and Antony had little within a given Christian musical tradition to draw from.

What they did have, however, was the newly created musical genre of Malayāḷam film songs, which were sweetly sung with the quiet accompaniment of harmonium, violin, flute, guitar, and *tabala*. This was a purely 'Indian' and specifically Malayāḷam genre which in one sense was notable for its lack of indexical or symbolic power: unlike Karnāṭak music, it had no particular semiotic association with any caste or community. The music of films, which at that time fell under the category of *lālitasāṅgītam* ['light music'] can be said to be the first musical tradition which is essentially secular in India, tied to a public economics of popular taste and popular entertainment rather than to a specifically restricted sphere of religious or ritual functionality. The way this genre arose is itself intimately caught up in the unique political and social movements in Kerala of that time, which included the free election of a Communist state government in 1957 and which paved the way for the social, economic, and educational advances which have become known as 'the Kerala model' of development (e.g., Franke and Chasin 1994; Jeffrey 1992).

As described in Chapter One, this new genre of song had been developed in the 1950s primarily by the Kerala People's Arts Club (KPAC), in order to help the Communist Party to popularize its message through theatrical productions.¹² The

12. At this time Malayāḷam cinema was quite new: the first film studio in Kerala was built only in 1949, and most films made up to this time had a distinctly Tamil flavor. The first Malayāḷam film using 'playback' technology, whereby the actors were not required to sing their own song but only lip-synced while a professional singer filled in the voice, was *Nirmala*, made in 1948 for a Kerala company by the Tamil director P.V. Krishna Iyer. Up to the 1950s, film songs generally made use of preexisting Tamil or Hindi melodies.

tremendous popularity of the KPAC dramas is attributed by many to these 'melody songs', with lyrics by highly regarded Malayāḷi poets like O.N.V. Kurup, and set to music by composers like G. Devarajan. These were indeed the first truly Malayāḷam songs: preceding the work of KPAC composers, films were generally in either Tamil or Hindi, and the few Malayāḷam films that had been made generally included songs taken from already popular Tamil or Hindi melodies. "It was KPAC that first gave us songs rooted firmly in our own soil with the smell of '*malayala mannu*' ['Malayāḷam earth']" (John 1996).

Because the genre had been instrumental in successfully creating a statewide sense of 'Malayāḷiness' or *kēraḷīyata*, but was without community-specific associations, it was employed in the post-Vatican II project of embracing modernity by creating a Kerala Christian identity through locally meaningful forms. Like the popular film songs of the day, the songs which Abel and Antony composed were lyrical and simple, with a sweetly melodic voice accompanied by minimal orchestration. While film 'orchestras', or *gānamēḷa* orchestras, consisted of harmonium, guitars, several violins, and *tabala*, the instruments which were adopted in Syro-Malabar Church 'choirs',¹³ as they were and still are called, was a more pared-down ensemble consisting simply of harmonium, triangle, and sometimes violin. The songs were not only distinctly Indian, but specifically Malayāḷi, and they were distinctly cinematic, though that aspect of them was perhaps

13. The English word 'choir' is used by Malayāḷam speakers to refer to the entire musical ensemble accompanying a church service, and not (as in American English usage) to refer only to a group of vocalists. In the Syro-Malabar Church, then, word thus refers to the instrumentalists who accompany the solo or duo vocalists.

understated in popular awareness. As a violinist who has been active as a performer and composer in church music since this time put it,

Kerala style . . . means part Hindustani, part Karnātak, and part Western chords. More to the point, it means cinema song style. The modern trend in church music is to have this style.

The music that Antony composed for Abel's lyrics and translations fit squarely in this category of 'melody songs' or 'light music'. Although the style of songs were used in films, the genre was at that time larger than the category of 'film songs' would imply. This was a style of song which had been popularized through KPAC dramas, and was also to be found in the films of the day, but the genre was more properly characterized as 'Malayālam songs'. Abel and Antony composed songs in this musical vernacular without apology. The new genre of 'light music' was available to all, and was appropriated by the Syro-Malabar Catholic Church in order to indexically signify and to reify a notion of groupness coherent with the conclusions of Vatican II.

2.3 Kalābhavan and the emergent connection between church and cinema music.

Composing music for the mass was the Ernakulam Diocese's primary objective; however, the project that Abel took on expanded far beyond that goal. Abel, under the auspices of the Ernakulam Diocese, ended up founding the premier and longest-standing performing 'orchestra' in Kerala, as well as founding

what has become the largest and most prestigious school for the training of 'Western' music. As Abel told me,

As I said, I have translated songs from Syriac. When I translated and distributed among the priests, there were some artists who helped me. I wanted to help them in return. So I made an orchestra troupe. That is how it happened. Orchestra troupe in Kerala means all cinema songs. Then only we will get bookings [for performances].

The joint endeavor comprising the troupe and the school was first named the Christian Arts Club. After one year in operation, the famous playback singer¹⁴ K.J. Yesudas joined the club as Director, which gave the fledgling organization a huge boost in terms of its prestige. Upon his suggestion it was given a new 'Indian' name, Kalābhavan, which is derived from the Sanskrit words *kalā*, 'art', and *bhavan*, 'place of abode, place where anything grows'. Adopting this Sanskrit name was a move which firmly established the organization as an indigenous enterprise, distancing itself from perceptions of Western cultural domination which are often associated with Christianity in India (cf. Kunnappally 1991:14). Coming from an organization with a name like 'Kalābhavan', both Christian devotional music and cinema songs would have to be taken as 'fully Indian'.¹⁵

In this triple move of composing new liturgical music, founding a music school and an orchestra, one can see a kind of strategy not only for ensuring the perpetuation of the new

14. In Indian films, the actors generally do not sing their own songs. Instead, they mouth the words while the voice is filled in by a professional singer who is known as a 'playback singer'.

15. One slogan of the movement for inculturation through indigenization was 'fully Indian, authentically Christian' (e.g., van Leeuwen 1990).

Christian music, but also for establishing, for the first time, a musical culture for Christians which could be accepted as truly Indian. As I have mentioned, up to this point Christians had no significant tradition of formal education in music at all; the folk genres mentioned above required no special schooling. Classical music [*śāstriyasāṅgītam*] was mainly the domain of high-caste Hindus. Karnātak vocal music is almost exclusively based on Hindu devotional themes, but even instrumental music traditions are based upon essentially Hindu philosophical foundations (e.g., Rowell 1992). Given this situation, Christians generally elected not to pursue musical training. If the Christian church was to be involved in Indian culture, and if 'culture' includes an idea of the arts, including music, then the Christians needed to begin an association with the arts.

Kalābhavan soon became widely recognized as the premier orchestra in Kerala. Today it not only plays concerts throughout Kerala but has also travelled to the Persian Gulf and to Europe on world tours, the latest of which is documented on a popular VHS videocassette. The close association between the Christian community and the new musical culture does not stop with Kalābhavan, however. Building upon Kalābhavan's success, in 1970 the Thrissur Diocese of the Syro-Malabar Church founded a similar troupe/school combination, and called it Kalāsadan (from the Sanskrit *sadan*, 'seat, dwelling'). Several of the founding members of Kalāsadan I spoke with are still active in music in Thrissur today; Kalāsadan itself ranks up near Kalābhavan as one of the top orchestras in the state. Under the auspices of both Kalābhavan and Kalāsadan, many musicians who

later went on to become famous film composers, music directors, and playback singers had the opportunity to develop their talents.¹⁶

Thus close networks of association were established early on between the Christian Church, and specifically the Syro-Malabar Church, and the world of film music. The schools of Kalābhavan and Kalāsadan were the primary training centers in Kerala for the Western instruments that formed the core of film song orchestras, and the deep involvement of the Church in these endeavors had the result that Christian names appear disproportionately on lists of famous music directors, and based on my observations, Christians also seem to make up a larger proportion of the membership in working *gānamēḷa* orchestras. Another, perhaps unforeseeable result, however, was that not only would Christians influence the development of popular cinema music, but that as cinema music developed and changed, these later developments would come to influence Christian devotional and liturgical music as well.

16. Kalābhavan has continued expanding its enterprise into the film world. Toward the end of my fieldwork, *The Hindu* reported that Kalābhavan Studios Limited, "a sister concern" of Kalābhavan, "has firmed up plans for setting up a 'film city' complete with the latest facilities for film and television software production and shooting locale" that "would be the best in the country" ['Kalabhavan planning to set up film city', 23 June 2001].

Section 3. Contemporary Music and Contemporary Issues.

3.1 'Tunes according to the times'.

In the 1960s, the instrumentation of church choirs was simple, consisting of harmonium, violin, triangle, and either bass drum or *tabala* (Palackal 1995). While some of the instruments are also to be found in Karnātak or Hindustani settings, in church choirs the instruments are played in the decidedly Western posture of sitting in a chair; instruments such as *tabala* or harmonium are placed on a small table in front of the performer, and the violin is played by holding the instrument out from the body in the European style, rather than resting against a foot, as in Karnātak performance. Depending on availability, as an ensemble got larger it followed the general model of the film song orchestra, adding electric guitar, flute, or additional percussion. Like film songs, the new church songs emphasized either solo or duet singing, rather than ensemble singing, although ensemble singing on the part of the congregation continued to form a part of the liturgy.

Both instrumentation and repertory have continued to change and evolve since that time. Rather than continuing exclusively with the simple melodic songs introduced after Vatican II, church choirs continued adding to the older songs in their repertories with new songs which seem to parallel trends in film music: "tunes according to the times", as one church keyboardist put it. In Malayāli film music, music directors have responded to innovations introduced by Ilayarajan and A.R. Rahman in Tamil films, such as heavy electronic beats and rhythm sequencing which are nearly impossible for a human player to

replicate, as well as to similar trends which have arisen in Hindi pop music. Thus Malayālam film songs have gotten faster, louder, and more rhythmic, and give 'more importance for instruments' (as I repeatedly heard). In short, they have become 'aṭipoli'.¹⁷ That the new songs place more emphasis on instruments and fancy orchestration at the expense of meaningful or even comprehensible lyrics is a commonplace observation.¹⁸ In the following conversation, for 44-year-old Raphael and his wife Laila, this trend demonstrates the influence of foreign musics (Tamil, Hindi, English) which counteract a form of 'mild' light music which Raphael holds is more essentially or authentically a Kerala style:

EK: Do you think the music style has changed in the past twenty years?

R: Yeah, certainly.

EK: How has it changed?

R: Changed because 15 years back, there was no importance for music,¹⁹ only that vocal singing was there. Now they are giving more importance to music

17. I discuss trends in cinema songs and the concept of 'aṭipoli' further in Chapter Three in the context of *gānamēḷa* performances in temple festivals.

18. According to Nabeel Zuberi, the same "oft-repeated melancholic refrain, 'where have all the lyrics gone?'" is also heard in North India. He continues:

Many critics see the increasing emphasis on rhythm as a regrettable encroachment on song structure. Synthetic dance beats have, according to this view, upset the fine balance between words and music in the filmi geet. [Zuberi 2002:243]

19. As with many Malayālis speaking English, by 'music' Raphael refers to instruments and instrumental accompaniment, as opposed to singing.

. . . . In everywhere it is like that, in Jerusalem also it is like that.²⁰

EK: But has the style of singing changed?

R: That's not that much. Style means, here in Kerala that melody is there. Now for the last few years, there is a little change, connected with this English culture, or this Tamil/Hindi music. So there is some change.

EK: What kind of change?

R: That clear melody, that music.

EK: What do you mean, it's changed? How did it change?

R: Because that, in film songs, they are giving more preference to music. Drums will be there, guitar will be there. But in Kerala actually, they use this *tabala*, violin, harmonium, that type of mild, mild instruments.

L: *ippo aṭipoli pāṭṭu* [Now the songs are *aṭipoli*].

To demonstrate, Raphael played two cassettes for me. The first was a release of about 20-25 years earlier by K.J. Yesudas, the famous Christian playback singer: a touching song "about a bud which has fallen", in which Yesudas sings a pleasant, ornate melody to a subdued accompaniment featuring violin and *tabala*.²¹ The second is a cassette of recent Malayāḷam film songs; the song begins with synthesizer pads and repetitive rhythmic electronics, and soon a heavy bass-laden beat enters. Raphael comments:

20. 'Jerusalem' is the name of a Christian retreat center or *dhyāna kendram* near Kochi, one of several such centers which are part of the extremely popular Charismatic Movement. The role of amplified music in these centers would make a fascinating study in its own right.

21. *Sweet Melodies of K.J. Yesudas*, music by V. Daksinamurti, lyrics by Trikumaran Tambi.

R: Here the music is vibrating [with beats] like anything! Nowadays the music is like this. But even now, we prefer this [Yesudas]. This [new music] is only because of the influence of Hindi, Hindi and Tamil, no? Tamil is also music is like this. Ilayaraja, [A.R.] Rahman, so the influence of Tamil and Hindustani music.

EK: This is a Malayālam song, right?

R: Malayālam. But we are not in a position to recognize it, that is why. The words is like that, they are twisted like anything. Formerly, actually the lyrics, they are giving the importance to the lyrics, and the music comes afterwards. Here [in the new music], music is the first thing, and the lyrics is accordingly added to the music.

EK: You said they're twisted? What do you mean?

R: Words are not clear, no? Words are broken.²² Here [with Yesudas etc.] the words, you will get the correct meaning, what they are saying. But here [in the new music] we are not getting that. Some words, jiggling words, that's all.

Church choirs have kept up with such shifts in instrumentation which originate in film music: every church -- at least every church I visited in the city of Thrissur -- now features an electronic keyboard, and if available, an electronic drum pad and electric guitar. These electronic and electric instruments, along with one or two vocal microphones, are plugged into an amplifier and sent through speakers which line the walls of the church to the congregation at what generally seems to be the maximum volume allowable before the microphones feed back. In churches I visited, the speakers were sometimes

22. By 'broken', he means that because the music is written first and lyrics are added later, the flow of the words is not natural, but rather conforms to the music, rather than the other way around.

driven to distortion and decibel levels were very high, often surpassing 100 dB(A).²³

In contemporary practice, choir music often conforms very closely to the standards of contemporary cinema songs not only in instrumentation and orchestration, but also in performance style and performance practice. The number of vocalists in a typical choir is generally quite small, generally as few as one or two, and even in a big church, such as St. Thomas Church in the Christian area of Aranattukara, is only four or five. As illustrated on Tracks 16-19, a sampling of songs from different Syro-Malabar *qurbānas*, the songs are lively, generally including some steady rhythmic support from percussionists. In the churches I visited, percussion is performed on *tabala*, triple-drum, and usually also electronically, whether performed 'manually' on an electronic rhythm pad, or sequenced on the polyphonic MIDI keyboard. The songs are generally polished, with a varied orchestration accomplished by using different programs available on the synthesizer. Choir directors told me that if they do not have sufficient time to rehearse a given song, then its parts will be sequenced or pre-programmed on the keyboard, so that its multiple parts -- percussion, violin, even whole string or brass sections -- can be played at the touch of a button. This practice is locally referred to as 'feeding' or 'feeding the floppy' (since sequences are stored on removable floppy disks), and is also common among *gānamēḷa* orchestra keyboardists, as discussed in Chapter Three.

23. This sound level has been likened to that of a jet passing overhead at 1000 feet (cf. Rossing 1990).

Many described the music as modern or *putiya model* ['new model'], to distinguish the genre from the songs which preceded them, although both the songs of the earlier period and the songs being introduced today bear a close relationship with the cinema music of their respective times. The difference, I propose, is that while in the 1960s, the basic genre of popular song was perceived as fundamentally and categorically 'Malayālam', and was used both in films and in church choirs, today the basic genre of popular song is perceived as that of cinema music, which then become appropriated for use in the church. This notion is illustrated in Figure 4.1, below. Thus the opposition between film music and church music was not an operative one in the 1960s, when both were simply different kinds of 'Malayālam songs'. Today, however, church music in the new style is perceived as directly related to film music.

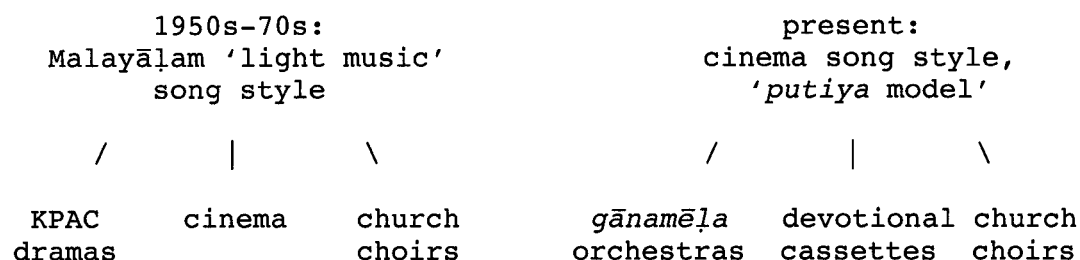


Figure 4.1 Dominant popular musics: Malayālam 'light music' and 'cinema music' styles.

3.2 Participation, *bhakti*, and the significations of contemporary church music.

Many Christians are very happy with what they see as improvements and advances in the music of the church. A retired Christian couple that lived on our street, Chacko and Mariyamma, commented that the present songs are better than the old ones, and that they feel like singing along by hearing them. The amplification is an improvement too, they said, because in the past the people sitting in the back of the church couldn't hear, and now they too can sing along. Mariyamma much prefers the sound of the synthesizer to that of the harmonium, and Chacko the sound of the electronic drums. Another elderly woman and her husband we spoke with were also very much in favor of the technology, saying that before amplification, "we weren't able to understand the harmonium [*manasilāyilla*, lit., the harmonium 'doesn't enter the mind/heart']", but that the speakers help them to understand, or to hear properly. To many, young and old, the music is not only enjoyable but also indicates the church's prosperity and relevance in the modern world.

However, for others I spoke with, the 'cinematization' of religious music is cause for concern. What began as an appropriation of a 'light music' form for liturgical use now carries with it the connotations and associations of the contemporary world's media implosion, of commercialism and the marketplace, and of emotions or feelings that derive from the values of cinematic entertainment rather than those of communion with the divine. The conversations I had with churchgoers, church musicians, and clergy spoke directly to a set of concerns about the intended goods inherent in the mass, the negotiation

of identity, and the validity of tradition in the face of an increasingly commercialized, globalized, and rapidly changing local reality.

In my discussions with people, the issue of 'participation' came up spontaneously and frequently with regard to their evaluations of the new music. As we have seen, one of the most significant intentions of Vatican II was to increase the people's ability to participate fully in the mass, through such measures as having the priest face the people and by conducting the liturgy in the local vernacular language. In the documents pertaining to the notion of 'culture', Vatican II sought to encourage worship to work through locally meaningful forms, which would thereby encourage a more heartfelt participation by individuals for whom those forms were meaningful. For people I spoke with, participation is often directly linked to 'devotional feeling' [*bhakti*], a principal good that is expected of the *gurbāna*.

Thus when the degree to which people are able to participate fully in the mass on a personal level is questioned, the fundamental value of the mass, and by extension the advances of Vatican II, are potentially undermined. The question of whether or not people feel enabled to participate in the service hinges directly on questions of meaning and identity: What kind(s) of persons are those for whom amplified electronic instruments convey meaningful devotional or celebrational forms? Among those who had difficulty identifying with the music themselves, such a question was very often answered in generational terms. The younger generation was often held to be

the motivational factor behind the drive for change and 'progress' in church music, in that many felt that it is they who enjoy such music, and that it is such music that attracts them to church in the first place. The older generation just goes along with it, but actually prefers the sweeter, slower songs of yesteryear. This is the line of thinking that says that Malayāli culture as a whole is undergoing a shift, and that the new generation is more comfortable with a mode of religious expression that indexes popular culture and high technology, which are after all inevitable, and must be accepted as such.

Despite frequent assertions that young people like the new music more than older people, however, in my interviews I found that young and old alike were equally likely to positively or negatively evaluate the contribution of the new songs. Nonetheless, the commonly expressed opinion that young people favor the new music thus endorses a sense of Christian identity which is indexically advanced by the music: one that is forward-looking, technology-savvy, and open to innovation, in short, values which emphasize adaptability in a time of societal and global flux. And indeed, many debates about church music are not specific to the domain of the *qurbāna*, but rather carry over to or from people's opinions of popular music and popular culture in general.

Some of the parameters of Malayāli Christians' complex sense of social identity, and the way these are tied to the emotional experience of *bhakti* in the experience of *qurbāna*, are well-illustrated by remarks by Jose, keyboardist in the choir of the Syro-Malabar church in my neighborhood. Jose has two basic

categories for songs that are performed in the church: (1) 'church songs' [*paḷḷi pāṭṭu*] which have a 'church effect' [*paḷḷi 'touch'*], referring to the older songs from the 1960s which are still in use, and (2) new '*aṭipoḷi*' songs, such as film songs. This notion of the *paḷḷi touch* is central in his understanding of the proper effect of devotional music. Cinema tunes don't have it. Only the tunes which are based on 'foreign' Christian tunes have it. The difference is in the *effect* that the two kinds of songs have on the listener. The *paḷḷi touch* is such that anyone who hears it will immediately feel its religious nature, and will be inclined to put their hands together [*kaikuppam*]. As Jose explains,

Church songs have simple tunes, and they might seem monotonous. It'll be liked by those above 40. People [above 40] will hum and sing loudly. When people come to a *qurbāna* there'll be different age groups. A youngster [*ceruppakkāran*] would say, 'what kind of song are you playing? Change it and play an *aṭipoḷi* song'. Tired of listening to church songs. There's a particular type of song called *paḷḷi pāṭṭu*; it's still here, not undergoing any changes. Even a young boy knows what a *paḷḷi pāṭṭu* is, and he would also know what a temple song is. There was a certain base made for the church tune, to produce a church effect. The tunes are made such that people listening can focus on Christ. One would feel *ēkāgrata* [concentration, single-mindedness]. Only then can we focus well. We won't get that from film music.

The shared understanding and immediate emotional response to *paḷḷi pāṭṭu* that Jose describes rest upon its function as an indexical sign.

The use of songs that resemble film music in style and instrumentation can inadvertently have the result that *bhakti* is not experienced, or that peace of mind is not achieved. Thus

Davis, a young man who years ago had sung in the church choir himself, answers my assistant's provocative question as follows:

AM: Introduction of electronic media is not good. Do you say so, what is your opinion?

D: Electronic media is a necessity. Shouldn't we move according to the time? But songs of these days are not helpful to us. . . . We are coming to church to get peace for our mind. But when we come here we lose such peacefulness.

In an interesting reversal of the generational argument, a 60-year-old woman was in favor of the new electronic instruments, but her daughter-in-law, quoted below, objected that too often the choir is imitating cinema tunes:

Words are not so meaningful. Because of the [instruments], they're not getting the correct meaning, and so there is less *bhakti* feeling. . . . In this choir, instruments are more, so devotional feeling is less.

Two members of another family shared a similar perspective:

Varghese: [In the church] it is fully, *enta parayām* [how do you say], *aṭipoli* style songs they are selecting.

EK: But you think the *aṭipoli* songs are good for the church?

V: I don't think.

EK: No? Oh.

V: But when we hear these songs, we are enjoying. But I don't think that is good for a church. Because we are going to church to get a mental satisfaction, from this music we are not getting any sort of mental satisfaction, we are getting only a -- sound of music.

EK: So you enjoy the music, but it doesn't feel like it's deeper than that, or something?

Simon: What he means to say is, you won't get a concentration in the mass if you put this type of songs; the concentration goes. Yeah, I also think

that way. But now you can't go back. It's already changed. If I want to go back, it's not possible.

Simon makes reference here to an idea that comes up elsewhere in the conversation, and which is discussed further below, that not just the music of the *gurbāna*, but the whole culture is changing, rapidly and inevitably, with respect to the global economy.

Two brothers, Davis and Johnson,²⁴ describe the sound level in the church as a 'total congestion of sound', or *śabdakōlāhālam*,²⁵ and contrast this with a desired quality in devotional songs, that of 'clarity'.²⁶ Immediately after bringing up the subject of song styles in the church in our first conversation, Davis and Johnson bemoan the transformation

24. On the Saturday afternoon we first met Davis and Johnson, Ambika and I began walking through the streets of Aranattukara and heard the sounds from the same movie emanating from all of the houses; the weekend Malayāḷam movies broadcast on Doordarshan are very popular, so much so that schedules are arranged around them. As the church organist Jose recounted:

There is a movie on Doordarshan every Sunday, and on certain Sundays, the film is really good. If we were to conduct a prayer in church at that time, the attendance would be very poor. Some people may come to church, thinking 'we have watched many films'. Except for such people, many youngsters may think, 'let me sit in front of the TV. I'll go to church later.' We set a time for our prayer according to the program on TV, and we conveniently change the time of our prayer.

Because we wanted to interview Christians in the area, we picked a house at random and knocked on the door, and these two brothers, Davis and Johnson, were more than a little surprised to see the odd pair of people at their doorstep but invited us in, graciously switched off the movie, and engaged us completely in what was to be the first of several enthusiastic discussions of church music. Davis, the younger of the two at 30, had years earlier sung in the local church choir himself, and the two are active consumers of devotional cassettes.

25. *śabdam* is 'sound' and *kōlāhālam* is 'noise, clamour, hue and cry, conclamation, shout, shindy' (Warrier et al. 2000).

26. The English word was used in otherwise Malayāḷam speech.

from devotional songs to filmi tunes. These latter songs lack 'devotional density',²⁷ because of their resemblance to orchestra. Earlier tunes however, such as the early devotional songs by Kalābhavan, did have devotional density.

D: Old songs are rarely heard. Now they are imitating 'cinema music'.

J: There is no devotion in them.

.

D: Songs played in the church won't have devotional density. It is played with the organs [digital keyboards]. They have high [loud] sound. Feels like *gānamēḷa*.

J: Artistes of earlier days from Kalābhavan had given music to some songs. Those songs have devotional density. There was an artist, K.J. Thomas by name. His songs have even now great popularity. Those songs have so much 'clarity'. His preliminary works are being played even now.

If I want to hear good devotional songs, they offer, they'll put on one of Yesudas' many cassettes for me. Note that even though the early music of Kalābhavan was closely related to the cinema music of its day, its association with cinema music was not and is not its salient feature, since the cinema songs of that time were also sweet, meaningful, and melodious songs. Rather, the comparison generally being made is between older songs -- be they originally devotional or from the cinema -- and the new cinema songs which 'feel like an orchestra', as illustrated above in Figure 4.1.

27. *bhakti sāndrata*, with *sāndrata* translated as 'density'; *sāndra*, the adjectival root of *sāndrata*, connotes 'solid, dense, full, soft, pleasing, agreeable, thick'.

The digital technology available literally at keyboardists' fingertips to recreate the sounds of studio-produced cassettes is influencing choir performance practices in a way that some listeners find troubling. Church musicians and others comment that continual exposure to cinema and devotional songs recorded using lush electronic orchestration with electronic drumbeats has led audiences to develop a set of expectations regarding what music should sound like. Musicians take these perceived expectations very seriously. These days, music is generally composed and recorded in the studio using digital MIDI sequencers, with the result that the music is of absolutely 'perfect' timing and execution. Consequently musicians, whether in church choirs or in *gānamēḷa* orchestras, feel obliged to use sequencing in the performance of songs which are familiar to listeners through the studio-recorded version. Thus the keyboardist at another church commented that although "it's very interesting to play in real", i.e., 'manually', he is obliged to use sequencing because people expect to hear the kinds of sounds they hear on cassettes, "flute, jazz, and all".²⁸ While indeed listeners have expressed to me such expectations, some also bemoan the lack of involvement of keyboardists who "just press one button", and find that such an automated musical environment falls short of motivating their own personal involvement in the songs.

28. 'Jazz' refers to (the sound of) a standard rock drum set.

3.3 Christianness and Christian music in a global context.

Despite continued emphasis on the 'indigenous' nature of Christianity in Kerala, many Kerala Christians continue see themselves and their religion as 'foreign'. Although originally motivated by a project of inculturation, the introduction of the new music may ironically have heightened this feeling of dependence on foreign influence, in that the electronic instruments on which it is made are themselves foreign, and are often perceived as 'Western'. Furthermore, they have been obtained by virtue of the ability of Malayāli workers to take advantage of labor demands in the Gulf states. In this way, the use of such instruments in the church index the relative prosperity of Malayālis, and their potential to succeed in an increasingly global economy. By the same token, it also signifies a form of Westernization, as some of my interviews reveal.

For example, the church keyboardist Jose has an ambiguous understanding of the origins of church songs, and Christianity itself, and of Christianity's relation to India and to being Indian. In the following interview excerpt, Jose sees himself as a part of an explicitly foreign population. This idea emphasizes the role of Syrian immigrants of the 4th and 9th centuries in building the Christian population over and above the tradition that the early Christians were converted by St. Thomas himself. My assistant Ambika and I start by asking about what the music was like when he began playing harmonium in the church choir 23 years earlier, at age 13:

- J: First it was Malayālam church songs. After three years, we started other songs as well.
- AM: what kind of songs?
- J: We can say they were melody songs [*melody pāṭṭū*]. Are you asking me about the melody?
- AM: Were the tunes typical church tunes? Can you say exactly what kind of music it was? Does it have a name?
- J: What to say . . . It wasn't our Indian music.
- AM: Not Indian music? When you learned it, did you refer to notation?
- J: Yes. To say exactly, what we call church tune is foreign. *Nammude Indian music alla* ['It wasn't our Indian music']. It was copied into different languages and different melodies [*rīti* 'way', 'procedure'].
- AM: So you were just using Malayālam words in foreign music?
- J: We were leaning [depending] on foreign music. In India, we Christians came from outside and started living here. To say the truth, we [Christians] have a foreign culture, it's not our [Indian] culture. Especially Christians have a foreign culture [*vidēśa culture*]. Because of this, we are still maintaining the foreign ways.

Jose's feeling of foreignness extends even to the very instruments which are played, especially his own instrument, the electronic keyboard or 'organ'. What is of interest here is that his impression of the foreignness of the instruments doesn't seem to refer to 'actual' but rather to perceived foreignness: the harmonium also came from Europe, but both Jose and Ambika both perceive it to be indigenous, based on its longstanding familiarity and acceptedness within Indian culture.

J: In those days, there were no modern equipments/tools [upakāraṇam]. Let me tell you. Up to about 1985, the keyboard had not been introduced.

AM: Did you have the keyboard even before that?

J: In those days it was the harmonium. This is the way you move your hands [demonstrates]. I had one. After that the keyboard came. Tunes came. Everything foreign. We don't have anything of our own. The whole equipment is foreign, except harmonium.

. . .

AM: Didn't anybody object to [the introduction of the electronic keyboard]? Isn't the harmonium ours, and wasn't it used at the beginning?

J: In fact they were happy. People started liking this keyboard, because the harmonium made only one sound. When it was changed to keyboard, people wondered how a new sound was coming out from the church. They wondered where the church got a foreign thing. Like that, they started liking it.

That the keyboard is of foreign origin was observed by many of the people I spoke to, and as Jose indicated, this foreignness is not generally cause for a negative evaluation. Instead, the keyboard is a prime signifier indexing the relative prosperity and cosmopolitanness of Malayāḷis.²⁹ There is a pervasive awareness that Malayāḷis have made themselves at home in many far-flung corners of the globe, including Australia, Canada, the U.S., and of course the Gulf countries, and that the well-being of those at home increasingly depend upon connections with those abroad. During the period from 1972 to 1990, the annual remittances from abroad ranged from 15 to 30 percent of

29. The price of a digital keyboard of the type commonly used in church choirs and in *gāṇamēḷa* orchestras is in the range of 40,000 Rupees, or nearly \$1,000, an extremely high sum in India.

the state's total income.³⁰ Equipment such as the electronic keyboard signifies Malayālis' ability to play a successful part in the process of globalization.

In an interview with several siblings, Simon, a 30-year-old man who, like his father and one of his brothers, works for the Merchant Navy and has thus travelled to many foreign ports, identifies the keyboard as church music's main Westernizing element, and notes that it has become common here in the last 10 years:

M: We got a lot of openings to the foreign countries now... like people are going there, so they can get the stuff, bring the gadgets from foreign countries to here.

EK: Do you think those instruments are less common in other states in India where people are not going to the Gulf?

S: Yeah. That's a fact.... Here because we got an opening to Gulf, so that things are flowing. But if you go to a place like Orissa, it's not that common. But Punjab is an exception, because a lot of Punjabis stay in Canada; they got an opening to foreign countries. But the music is changing but it's going towards the Western style. You've tried listening to old songs and these things? You can compare that to film songs, old film songs and new songs. You can see the difference.

EK: Old film songs and new film songs, you mean? How about with church songs?

S: You can see the difference. Same difference.

30. T.N. Krishnan, paper presented at the 1994 *International Congress on Kerala Studies* in Thiruvananthapuram (cited in Tharamangalam 1998). According to a report by the Center for Development Studies in Thiruvananthapuram, in 1998, remittances from Malayālis living abroad made up 11% of the State Domestic Product (Zachariah, Mathew, and Rajan 2000:26).

For Simon and his brothers, the trend of both devotional and popular music has been one of accepting influence from the West, rather than developing along 'indigenous' lines:

EK: [to the group] If you can remember 25 yrs ago, what was the music like at that time at St. Mary's?

S: It was totally different. What I feel like, everything is coming to a unity form. Like, lot of western mix. Nothing is going from here to Western countries, everything is taking it from there. So that is mixed up with our style of music. I think the trend is toward one music, it's growing up. Aim is like, towards the western style.

Simon's point of view reflects the complicated, somewhat conflicted feeling that I occasionally came across that Kerala is losing its traditions but that it may be better, after all, to accept -- and to be a constructive part of -- an encroaching global monoculture. Although he recognizes that Malayāli culture is on the losing end of this bargain, and that the trend is driven by economic factors rather than by creative ones intrinsic to Kerala culture, he, like many others, is very much in favor of the changes he sees in the music.³¹ When I ask explicitly if the change is a positive one, there is a slight hesitation, and Simon's brother Varghese answers with a laugh, somewhat resignedly, that the change is "a necessary change". Simon, however, jumps in and elaborates his ambiguous outlook:

I think it is a good change. I enjoy it. . . . But the sad part is, we had our own culture. We are going to miss that soon. But I think if all around the world if you have got one culture, it may be good.

31. In fact, he himself recently brought back an electronic drum pad from Dubai, for home use.

3.4 Television, cassettes, and the attitude of 'entertainment'.

To others, the new music of the *qurbāna* did not signify Westernization as directly, but rather pointed towards the encroachment of the ideals of popular culture generally, including commercialization and passive reception of 'entertainment' after the model of watching television, which activity has become extraordinarily pervasive over the past 8-10 years, since the spread of cable channels. Several people I spoke with worried that the attitude or frame of reception which people assume while watching television is automatically carried along when they go to church. Their worry is amplified by the presence in the church of music which is so reminiscent of what might be on television.

This concern is in the back of the church keyboardist Jose's mind when he comments that devotional songs in the style of film songs won't have a devotional effect on listeners. Rather than directly indexing *bhakti*, there is a cognitive distance: people evaluate them as a musical performance, rather than as a devotional experience:

Now we have this new generation. People like [Tamil film composer] A.R. Rahman, and a lot of others are composing *bhakti gānams*. Christians, Hindus, Muslims, are all composing such devotional songs. *To promote a person's religious conviction, these songs do not help.* When they listen to such songs, they will comment on how enjoyable the song is. They'll make comments like, 'he played the keyboard well', and 'the song is good', and 'we remember the film from which the song came', but this will not be said by a person over 40 or 45 [who will instead ask], 'What kind of song are you playing? Why don't you play a church song [*paḷḷi pāṭṭu*]?' Why they want *paḷḷi pāṭṭu* is to have a *paḷḷi* 'touch'.

In a separate interview, Markose, a man in his mid-30s, similarly made a direct reference to an attitude transposed from the world of mass media entertainment, resulting in decreased participation:

Earlier it is prayer, songs are always like a prayer. But now it has become cinematic songs. Like we are watching a movie, and there are songs.

The theme Jose and Markose touch on here appeared in more subtle ways as well in many of the conversations I had with churchgoers: the fear that the choir ensemble resembles an orchestra so completely, that the public perceives their music as a form of entertainment to be passively observed, rather than as a ritual expression in which they become involved in a participatory way.

3.5 '*Bhakti* has changed into business': Commercialization and market pressures.

The idea of 'entertainment' is not only tied to an attitude of reception but also brings into the church larger socio-economic issues of commercialization and the pressures of the marketplace which appear to drive musical innovation in the church. Although some younger people do prefer the newer songforms -- particularly those who play instruments themselves -- many also told me that they too prefer the less *aṭipoli* songs when their goal is devotion rather than entertainment. The brothers Davis and Johnson, for example, reported that they have often heard young people saying as they leave the church,

'What type of song, there is no meaning, no devotional feeling, we are not able to understand the words.' That

type of comments are also, people are telling like that.... They say, 'We are coming for a good purpose to the church. We can get a lot of fast type of songs in the market, so why do they come and listen to that type of songs in the church?'

This link between overtly cinematic songs and the marketplace is an important one. Churchgoers point to the influence of mass culture when asked about recent changes in the music, and draw connections between popular culture and the desire for a 'modern' or 'new model' music in the *qurbāna*. According to my interviews and surveys, more people now listen to music through the television than through radio or cassettes, on one of the several cable channels which are entirely devoted to music videos or song sequences from films. For Christian devotional songs, however, the primary mode of distribution is still the cassette. People draw their expectations for what music should sound like from cassettes, but some are also skeptical of a too-apparent connection between music performed in the church and market pressures.

Heavy marketing of devotional cassettes is a significant factor in influencing church choir practices. The practice in the Syro-Malabar Church of maintaining 'tunes for the times' is motivated by choirs' exposure to popular devotional cassettes, and results in a relatively steady turnover in choir's repertoires. Choirs are continually learning new songs from popular cassettes and introducing them into the service, with the result that some in the congregation can't keep up with them, and thus are not able to participate on the level of singing along, simply because they do not know the tunes. The impetus to learn new songs is related to the sheer number of

devotional cassettes which are released each month, and the intensity with which they are marketed. Christian devotional cassettes have become big business in Kerala in recent years; at the Round in the center of Thrissur one can always see new posters plastered on walls advertising new Christian devotional cassette releases, and every cassette shop has a large selection to choose from. Furthermore, as I mentioned in Chapter Two, cassette producers benefit from the practice at most churches of broadcasting devotional songs over outdoor loudspeakers at 5:00 each morning, which serves as free advertising. Thus Davis and Johnson commented that the cassette industry increasingly tries and succeeds in marketing spirituality, saying that "*bhakti* has changed into business". In the following interview excerpt, Joy, a well-off Christian businessman, expresses concerns about the continually changing repertory of church choirs:

EK: So what's your opinion of the change in instruments, the shift to electronic instruments?

Joy: When the music shifts to electronic instruments, some people like the younger generation always like it.

AM: What's your opinion?

J: I prefer that instead of using this music that the whole people join together and sing, and that it becomes devotional songs. Now the devotion has gone, and most people sit idly when the choir sings . . . and our concentration goes out of the service. And we sit idle in the church. We think about other things not about the service.

EK: Rather than participating or singing. So people are singing less because of these instruments, is that it?

J: [Yes.] In earlier days the whole people coming to the church sing the song, and in earlier days there were some songs we had been singing continuously for 10-15 years, and everybody knew the songs. And now

the trend is that every 6 months there comes a new book, new songs, and when there comes a new book we have to restudy. So the older generation will become tired of this, so they never tried to sing the song, like that. [pause.] Every 6 months come new music cassettes also. The cassette industry has come up. So the cassette companies also, those who are selling the prerecorded cassettes, they compose a song, give the music, and sell the cassette, put an advertisement in the paper. And so some people go and collect the cassettes. And . . . the church choir go and learn the [new] songs and sing it. The past Christian church idea is gone: that the [same] song is there, the [traditional] music is there and it's going on [without change].

Section 4. Contrasting ideas of 'inculturation' and proposals for change.

4.1 Restoration vs. indigenization.

Perhaps not surprisingly, conversations I had with people about the music of the Syro-Malabar liturgy never seemed to appeal to a concept of 'tradition'. Other churches, such as the Orthodox Syrian and the Protestant Church of South India (CSI), mentioned above, apparently hold a notion of tradition as more dear, although each of these churches appeals to a different cultural tradition both liturgically and musically [cf. Tracks 14 and 15]. The Syro-Malabar Church exhibits a different attitude, and the music is one of ways this difference is signified and performed. It is perhaps this difference which makes the Syro-Malabar Church feel more 'modern', and thus more in line with a concept of Indian identity which doesn't rely on a parochial vision of an ancient India but rather embraces its

position in the crosscurrents of an increasingly globalizing world.

It is also this sense of lacking a strong underpinning which causes anxiety for those who feel that such a readiness to accept the path of modernity may be antithetical to a religiosity which, according to Vatican II itself, must be grounded in and expressed through culture in order to fully come into its own. Two distinct groups of priests are thus advocating change within the Syro-Malabar Church, both intending to root the liturgy more deeply in ancient cultural traditions. The two groups differ, however, in their choice of *which* ancient culture Syro-Malabar Christians should more fittingly embrace as their own: the Archbishop at Changanassery in southern Kerala would like to see the church revert to incorporate more of the originally Syrian or Chaldean elements, according to a notion of an 'Oriental Christian' identity shared with the West Asian churches, while a group of priests associated with Dharmaram College have long been advocating reappropriating aspects of Hindu culture and philosophy, including traditionally Hindu musical genres, in a Christian context. The first group is in favor of 'restoration', and the second of 'indigenization'; these positions are summed up by Mundadan (who is himself in favor of indigenization) as follows:

While one stresses the restoration and the achievement of patriarchal or some other type of autonomous status in the present framework of the Oriental Catholic Churches, the other group seems to stress the emergence of a fully indigenous, autonomous and Oriental Catholic Church in India. In the view of the latter group [those who favor indigenization] restoration is a futile attempt, because it would mean the reconstitution of a Church with Chaldean overtones which according to them are as foreign as western

Latin overtones. They want the Church of St Thomas in India to shed as much as possible all foreign elements, both Latin and Chaldean, and assume more of the Indian elements. [Mundadan 1984:102]

The actions of both groups are consistent with Vatican II, but according to vastly different conceptions of what culture is the culture of the Syro-Malabar Christians.

The history of divisions and rivalries within the Syro-Malabar Church hierarchy is long and complex, and I will not attempt to recapitulate it here.³² Owing in part to a lack of centralized leadership within Kerala, such that liturgical decisions must be sent to Rome to await approval, local dioceses have often been at odds concerning the appropriate path to take. Thus while Fr. Abel in the Ernakulam Diocese had translated many liturgical texts and set the stage for the music discussed above, in some cases the Archdiocese at Changanassery has overseen its own translation of liturgical texts and its own music. For example, in the Service for the Dead [*mariccavarute rāza*], the Kalābhavan version by Abel and K.K. Antony skilfully adapted Malayāḷi musical forms, while the Changanassery version maintains a purely Syrian style.³³ Changanassery has instituted changes which seem to counter the post-Vatican II reforms instituted elsewhere. For example, it has reintroduced the Manichean Cross, and also reverted to having the liturgical officiant facing the altar rather than the congregation. In an interview with Fr. Abel, he spoke quite strongly against such

32. See Popidara 1976, Kuriedath 1989, Kanichikattil 1992, Mundadan 1984 for insider accounts of this history.

33. I thank Joseph J. Palackal for this observation.

changes, saying that the Archbishop of Changanassery had "destroyed the liturgy", despite opposition on the part of twenty-two other bishops.

Those in Changanassery hold that the East Syrian rite of the Syro-Malabar Church does not need to be Indianized, since by virtue of its long presence in Kerala, and given the inherent pluralism of Indian culture, it should already be considered thoroughly Indian. As the Exarch Rt. Rev. Mgr. A.D. Mattam of Changanassery put it,

We have seen how the Syro-Malabar liturgy was adopted by the St. Thomas Christians and has been in use among them for the last 14 centuries or so. It has become part of the religious culture of the Malabarians. As the Malabar Christians are Indians their ancient culture forms part of Indian culture. Now after so many centuries, if any one is to say that their rite is foreign or un-Indian, it is an affront to the St. Thomas Christians. [Mattam 1976:70]

For Mattam, it is not simply a matter of fourteen centuries, but also that because of intrinsic cultural and geographical connections, the East Syrian liturgy fits an Indian predisposition. He claims that "India has many things in common with the Judeo-Christian culture of Mesopotamia", and that "the East Syrian rite is more akin to the thought, aspirations and customs of the Indian people and very much appealing to their mentality" (1976:73).³⁴

34. To support his point, Mattam cites the following speech by Swami Vivekananda, delivered in Los Angeles in 1900:

Many times you forget also that the Nazarene himself was an Oriental of Orientals. With all your attempts to paint him with blue eyes and yellow hair, the Nazarene was still an Oriental. All the similes, the imageries, in which the Bible is written -- the scenes, the locations, the attitudes, the groups, the poetry and symbol -- speak to you of the Orient: of the bright sky, of the heat, of the sun, of the desert, of the thirsty men and

Finally, Mattam objects to incorporating 'Hindu' elements on political grounds. Some of the main targets of European Christian evangelizing are members of the oppressed lower Hindu castes, and Mattam points out that in parts of North India, Adivasis and Harijans "express their resentment against Hindu customs like the caste system and despise the Hindu religious books." He asks, "What would be the effect of Christian preachers going about among these people sanctifying the very scriptures they have despised?" (1976:75).

4.2 Inculturation through Indianization and Sanskritization.

Meanwhile, other priests within the Syro-Malabar Church have proposed liturgical texts whose approach could not be further removed from Changanassery's position, but which are instead rooted in the insistence that an Indian identity necessarily stems from a cultural inheritance which is shared with the Hindus. According to the Malayāli priest and historian Mundadan, the Indian Church needs to grow away from its Syrian heritage:

The East Syrian connections of the Church, though advantageous to the community in many ways in earlier times, today pose a threat to the development of an Indian identity with an Indian theology, an Indian Christian form of worship and an Indian Christian way of life. [1984:202]

animals; of men and women coming with pitchers on their heads to fill them at the wells; of the flocks of the ploughmen, of cultivation that is going around; of the water-mills and wheel, of the mill-pond, of the mill-stone. [quoted in Mattan 1976:73-74]

Cardinal Joseph Parecattil of the Ernakulam Archdiocese expresses a very similar view:

Acculturation is at the very root of the *raison d'être* of rites. For a rite is the expression of the Christian message and the Christian worship through a particular culture. So those who oppose Indianisation in an effort to safeguard the Chaldean rite, which has its root in a foreign culture, are cutting the ground from under their own feet.

Our cultural identity is Indian, not Chaldean. Hence what has to be restored is our Indian identity, and Indian Mass is a humble effort to that effect. [Parecattil 1987:A71-72]

The Indian Mass referred to here is known as the *Bhāratīya Pūja* -- pointedly using the Sanskrit word *pūja*, which is also used to denote Hindu worship rituals -- and was prepared by the Liturgical Centre of the Archdiocese of Ernakulam in 1974. Its basic structure is like that of the Syro-Malabar liturgy, but incorporating Indian elements. Perhaps most controversially, before the reading of the scriptures, it includes the following 'pilgrim song' from the *Bṛhadārāṇyaka Upaniṣad*:³⁵

Lead us, Lord,
From the unreal to the real,
From darkness to light,
From death to immortality.

In defending the use of this prayer, Parecattil points out that the same passage was quoted by Pope Paul VI in a 1964 speech he gave in Bombay (1987:A71).

The *Bhāratīya Pūja* takes its hymns from another Indian Mass, *An Order of the Mass for the Indian Church*, which was prepared by Dharmaram College, the study center of the CMI

35. See Parecattil 1987:82, Amalorpavadass 1982:367.

priests, and first celebrated in a conference held there in 1969. The Dharmaram College text is a much more radical in its appropriation of Sanskritic elements, for example adopting important terms and concepts such as *Om̐* and *saccidānanda*³⁶ in prayers "formulated against the religious background of India" (Kanichikattil 1992:74), and gestures found in Hindu ritual such as lighting oil lamps and performing *ārati* (the waving of lamps, incense, and flowers) at the altar. The anaphora of this text, furthermore, "was developed having in mind the 'Cosmic Sacrifice' (*Yajna*) of the Vedic Religion" (ibid.).

It is apparent, then, that supporters of the Indian Mass hold that inculturation and Indianization should not stop at simply using local forms, but that Christianity can benefit at a theological level from the insights of Hindu philosophy. Thus the parish priest at the church in my neighborhood told me that

Indian philosophy and art has got a characteristic color, scent, and character. That is, our idea of oneness, which is the basic idea, the basic insight of India. . . . If you know that, then you know; otherwise you don't know.

This priest spoke highly of the theology of Raymond Panikkar, himself of Malayāḷi (and Spanish) heritage, according to whom the task of Christianity in India is to "unveil the Christ hidden in Hinduism" (Mundadan 1984:198). The priest shared a Christian theology which, like Panikkar's, is "based on Indian philosophy: God is not outside, but is the innermost inner."

36. *sat* 'truth, being'; *cit* 'knowledge, consciousness'; *ānanda* 'bliss'.

For many Catholic priests, an Indian cultural identity is inseparable from Hindu aspects, which are reimagined as 'cultural' rather than 'religious'. As another told me,

Any Christian who is brought up on Indian soil, although by faith he's a Christian, by culture he's a Hindu.

The priest at my neighborhood church expressed a similar sentiment:

Kerala Christians and Muslims are different from all other Christians and Muslims in India. We are more indigenous, integrated into the culture; all communities live together. In other parts, they say Christians, you go to Rome. But we here are just like Hindus. Hindu[ism] is not a religion, it is a way of culture.

And Corinne Dempsey reports her surprise and momentary disorientation upon hearing a Kerala Orthodox Syrian priest with whom she was speaking exclaim, "I am a Hindu! We are all Hindus in India" (Dempsey 2001:66).

In accord with such sentiments, a movement has arisen, centered at Dharmaram College, to encourage the use of 'Indian' music in liturgical celebrations. Since the 1970s, Dharmaram has sponsored the creation of *bhajan*s, which (as discussed in Chapter Two) are traditionally Hindu devotional song structures in which the names of god are repeated over and over, often in a call-and-response format. Dharmaram College has produced cassettes of such *bhajan*s in many different Indian languages and distributed them. However, Christian *bhajana* singing seems not to have caught on in Kerala beyond its use within religious communities such as seminaries, for example at Dharmaram College itself.

Some favor the replacement of the Syrian-Western-filmi style of contemporary church choirs with truly Indian music, by which they mean -- in keeping with the Sanskritic nature of Dharmaram's Indian Mass -- Karnātak music, the classical music tradition of South India. One of the main proponents of this movement is Fr. Paul Poovathingal, a Malayāli priest of the CMI order who is in his tenth year of training in Karnātak vocal music in Chennai, and has furthermore conducted extensive research on Christian involvement in Karnatak music, and the influence that Karnatak music has had on Christian music, from a historical perspective (cf. Poovathingal 2003, 1997).

When he returns occasionally to his parish in Thrissur, Poovathingal leads a *qurbāna* at his home church in which his liturgical chants are sung according to Karnātak *rāgas*, rather than in the style of the Syrian chant [[Track 20](#)]. He keeps the main pitch or *śruti* by means of an electronic *śruti* box which is placed on the altar. The mass is not wholly Karnātak; the normal choir still performs its regular repertory. The choir also controls the sound system, and adds electronic reverb to Poovathingal's voice, as can be heard on the recording. He told me afterwards that he has repeatedly asked the choir not to put reverb on his voice, but -- in a move that perhaps illustrates the agentive power that choirs have in the evolution of music in the church -- they persist, apparently feeling that the solemn *rāgam*-based chanting is improved by electronic modification.

Poovathingal's mission is not only to introduce Karnātak music into the liturgy, but to establish a sense of Christian culture which is inclusive of South Indian musical heritage more

generally. Put in terms of social identity, the goal is that Christians would hear Karnātak music as 'their' music. He is working toward this goal by working to cultivate an appreciation for Karnātak music within the Christian community, and also through his research and efforts to revive historical contributions to Karnātak music by Christians. He notes that in the Hindu tradition, there are two types of singing traditions: liturgical music, i.e. singing for *pūja*, and performance music, or art music. In the Christian tradition, however, there is only liturgical music, and it is this fact that he wishes to change. He attributes the resistance within the Christian community to Karnātak music to the fact that "Karnātak music was very much confined to one religion, and in one religion very much confined to one caste, Brāhmans. They were not ready to open." Now the field has opened; a few Christians such as he have gone for study of Karnātak music, but still, when there are "concerts on radio, TV, no Christian will listen ever." Christians are alienated by both the Hindu religious themes and the language of Sanskrit itself, he said, and so in addition to reviving Christian Karnātak compositions which he has rediscovered, he is experimenting with singing *kritis* and *kīrttanams* in Malayāḷam, and about Christian themes, for example about Christ and Mary.

In keeping with the orientation of Dharmaram College, where he was trained for the priesthood, Poovathingal's commitment to music is based on a theological interpretation of the shared significance of music in both Hindu and Christian scriptures, such that *Ōm* is interpreted as equivalent with both

the Jewish creation myth and with the New Testament principle of *logos*:³⁷

PP: *Om̐*, *Om̐kāram*. When you say, for example [sings '*Om̐ jagadīśvara*'], it is Sanskrit, *jagadīśvara*, 'the lord of the world'. *Jagat-īśvara*. *Om̐*. It's the pronounced, it's praise, just praising, the lord of the universe. We can call it Father.

EK: *Om̐*?

PP: Yeah, the *Om̐*, meaning is, [laughs] it is a very big word in that sense, you cannot explain its real meaning. And if you explain musically, *Om̐* includes all the sound. For example [sings *Om̐-omm̐*] when you speak in terms of voice production, it is coming from abdomen, diaphragm, and moving towards and up to lips. The *mmmm* sound. So in between all the sounds are included. So that is the universal, especially in the Hindu tradition they call it *pranavākāram*. *Om̐kāram*. And they say all the sounds are included in this *Om̐kāram*. So it is a primordial sound. First sound. And it is beyond all religions. It has existed right from the beginning of the creation. For example, I heard a particular comparison between Hindu style of singing and Christian biblical thinking. For example, Hindus call god *nādabrahman*.

EK: Yeah, I know about that.³⁸

PP: You have heard about this. *Nāda* means sound. The god of sound. See, that means, in the beginning there was only sound. That was the first. The same way, when we come to the Christian tradition, especially the Old Testament, Genesis chapter one, there the Lord said 'let there be'. It's a word, or words. Sound, only sound. 'Let there be.' It is with sound only, that vibration he created. And of course when you go ahead, if you come to the New Testament, especially the Gospel of John: 'In the beginning was the word, and the word was God.' . . . So, what I am trying to interpret is, this word is called *vāk*, in Sanskrit. So this *vāk* can be, word

37. A similar Christian approach to the 'theology of *Om̐*' can be found in Vineeth (1982:125-131).

38. See Karel 1997.

can be as a sound. So that is *śabdham*, in Indian music. So this *śabdham*, when it becomes musical, it becomes *nādam*, musical sound. And this *nādam*, if it becomes a little more musical, it becomes *gītam*. When it is much more organized we call it as song, *gītam*. And still it proceeds, it becomes *saṅgītam*. *Saṅgītam* is the word for music, Sanskrit and also Malayālam. So coming to John's saying, 'in the beginning was word'. That word means, 'music'. Because I am just logically coming to, *nādam* or *gītam* or *saṅgītam*. So in the beginning was word -- in the beginning there was music, or whatever it is. So that music was with God, and that music was God.

For Poovathingal, the project of making Karnātak music a part of Christian observances and cultural life is clearly not simply a matter of superficially decorating a definition of cultural identity, but rather one that finds deep motivation in a shared Hindu-Christian theology and worldview.

In contrast to their clergy, Christian lay people that I spoke with were generally uneasy with the idea that Christianity and Hinduism had anything theologically in common. Nonetheless, they were quite happy to acknowledge using a Hindu-style *vilakkū* (brass oil-lamp) in the home, or sharing other customs, such as the tying of a *tāli* at a wedding. Still, as one young woman insisted:

See, even the dress, even the *vilakkū*, it has nothing to do with Hinduism and all that. We worship God that is all.... We think it's a little more devoted feel, lighting this lamp, a little more devoted like that, only that difference. Nothing to Hinduism and all.

This woman's feeling that the *vilakkū* adds a more devotional feeling to her Christian observances, without in any way referring to Hinduism in her mind, supports the intentions of the Indian Mass: locally meaningful forms, even ones which are or have been predominantly associated with Hinduism like the

viḷakkū, can be recontextualized such that an Indian Christian religiosity is well-expressed through them. Through use, they have become indexical of the sentiment of *bhakti* itself, and not of a particular tradition.

Despite their openness to using such equipments, Christians I spoke with were generally resistant to the idea of incorporating Karnātak music into the church service. Most posed the issue as one of relative familiarity: they didn't know anything about Karnātak music; they didn't 'understand' Karnātak music. Often people imagined the incredibly ornate, complex virtuosity of a solo vocal recital, and concluded that there would be no way the congregation could sing along. When I redirected their imagination toward the simple, populist *bhajana* song style, most still expressed resistance, but thought that with time people might adjust to something of the sort. Although I suspected that many didn't like the idea because Karnātak music is so strongly associated with Hinduism, only a few people were willing to say so, for example Joy, from whom we heard above:

J: I don't know this Karnātak music, but when they sing the *bhajan*as like the way the Hindu sings -- just go there, sing *jīvēśvara*, *mahēśvara*, and all that -- when we hear that song in the church, we think, 'why are we hearing a Hindu song?'

EK: Oh really? So it just sounds Hindu?

J: We don't mind when we go in a bus, or a hotel, and we hear the Sabari Mala song.³⁹ We hear it. [chants a

39. Joy is referring to the annual pilgrimage to Sabari Mala, the mountain temple of the god Ayyappan, which is undertaken by hundreds of thousands of Hindu men each year. For the duration of the pilgrimage season, buses and caravans carrying devotees dressed in black can be

sample '*śaraṇam Ayyappa*']. But when we hear this type of song inside the church we won't like it.

Others were willing to admit the possibility that the future may hold different trends, and that with increased familiarity tastes can change. Poovathingal and others take their duty to be one of educating the public and creating this familiarity, and they are optimistic.

Summary.

The Catholic Syrian Christians of Kerala are inheritors of a complex set of cultural allegiances. In the 1960s, the Second Vatican Council made issues of culture explicit, and in response to the call to express Christianity through locally meaningful cultural forms, a new 'light music' was introduced into the liturgy which was intended to signify and to nurture a sense of groupness or identity which, like the music, was both Malayāḷi and modern. Like the translation of liturgical texts into Malayāḷam, this change increased congregants' feelings of participation in the mass.

This genre of music shared its parentage with that of cinema music, and as time passed the two have continued to bear significant family resemblances. While the contemporary liturgical music is widely popular among church-goers, some are also troubled by its tight connection to commercial film music

seen and heard careening through Thrissur and out towards Sabari Mala, all the while singing the devotional chants to Ayyappan, most commonly '*śaraṇam Ayyappa*'.

and to a television-like 'entertainment' frame of reception. Some groups of priests, too, take exception to the current form of liturgical music, based on a plurality of notions of how Indian Christian identity should most meaningfully be constituted.

CHAPTER FIVE

CONCLUSION

In this thesis, I have attempted to illustrate that analyzing emergent musical practices can serve as a uniquely instructive way to understand general cultural processes of change and adaptation. In order to investigate the ways in which Kerala public culture has been and continues to be refigured in relation to far-ranging social changes and the spread of electronic mass media, I have specifically explored the uses of amplified sound in three different domains.

In each of these domains, I have argued that amplified sound -- whether cassettes broadcast through loudspeakers, or mass-mediated genres performed on electronic instruments -- exists at the interface of the process through which Kerala cultural groups continue to redefine their communities and themselves with relation to social changes broadly encompassed in what has been called 'global modernity' (e.g., Appadurai 1996). I have emphasized that the uses of amplified sound should be considered as kinds of cultural performances which do not simply reflect preexisting cultural values and beliefs, but participate actively in the ongoing negotiation of emergent social spaces.

I have focused on the sounds of religious practices because religion is at the forefront of social life in India. It is a keystone for group identity, and observances connected with religion are not compartmentalized off from daily life as they often may be in the West. Even in Kerala, where the Communist Party has held sway in coalition governments for most of the period from 1957 until the mid-1990s, atheism was never a rallying cry and as a result has not been a mainstream position. Instead, religious practices and beliefs remain very meaningful aspects of life for a majority of people in areas like Thrissur.

In suggesting that sonic practices are key to temples' and churches' refiguring of their place in contemporary society, I have analyzed music not so much in terms of specifically 'musical' qualities such as pitches, durations, rhythms, and so forth, but rather in terms of its relationships to global technologies and mass media, and its effectiveness as a social phenomenon in a dynamic social network. Throughout this dissertation, I have detailed the ways in which technologies are appropriated by religious institutions to further locally-meaningful ends.

In Chapter Two, I showed that temples performatively declare a place for themselves in contemporary society by broadcasting devotional songs through temple loudspeakers. I emphasized that the broadcasting of devotional cassettes through temple (and church) loudspeakers can be seen as an extension of cultural models of loudness and space, and of early mornings as times of particular openness to influence. At the same time, the broadcasts bear imagined material connections to wealth

acquired abroad, and signify temples' rejuvenation and refiguration following radical upheaval in the social and economic networks in which they developed. Broadcasts are a means by which temples announce their prosperity and their presence, but within the increasingly complex social environments of contemporary neighborhoods, the social space they presume to construct is not always coterminous with the plurality of social spaces being lived. This and the other chapters thus illustrate that the issues highlighted by uses of amplified sound are sometimes ones of conflict rather than harmony within a community.

The spread of mass media has led to concerns that the most powerful representatives of mass media in the West would come to dominate and quickly suppress local representations which are not backed by huge and greedy multinational corporations. While such concerns are entirely justified, the unique position of Kerala, speaking both geographically and culturally, provides an instructive counter to the notion that cultural hegemony spreads only, or even mainly, from the West to 'the rest'. With a large and rapidly increasing percentage of homes in Thrissur wired to cable television providers, there is no doubt that people are increasingly exposed to images and musics from the West. But they are also increasingly exposed to images and musics from major centers of commercial culture elsewhere in India, especially Mumbai and Chennai, which have had more influence than those coming from the West.

Studying uses of amplified sound and musical forms offers a unique insight into the issues of purity versus hybridity of

cultural beliefs or practices which are often involved in discussions of cultural globalization. It has been noted that at the level of persons and personal networks, Indian culture is built upon notions of difference and distinctiveness, under the model that society functions because different kinds (i.e., *jātis*) of people contribute differently to the whole. Kerala culture has been characterized to perhaps an even greater degree by acknowledgement and acceptance of such inherent diversity, partially due to the coexistence of its multiple religious groups beginning far earlier than the radical increase in cross-cultural contact associated with global modernity.

At another level, Malayāḷi culture is in many ways fundamentally defined as a distinctive kind of mixture between Hindi and Tamil cultures, and as a result, in Kerala there is no question of choosing to maintain some kind of Malayāḷi cultural purity as preferable to hybridity. Although certain art forms are considered to be 'indigenous' to Kerala, the culture at large is largely defined by its place even within India as a crossroads between Sanskritic/Hindi and Dravidian languages and cultures. Even in terms of language, although Malayāḷam is a Dravidian language which is very close to Tamil in its structure, grammar, and vocabulary, it has a much higher incidence of Sanskrit-based words than does Tamil, such that many Malayāḷis with whom I spoke assumed that their language was more closely related to Hindi than to Tamil. A similar perspective is widely held with respect to musical traditions. Because of its relation to two much older cultures to the East and North, Kerala culture sometimes seems young in comparison, as this guitarist and cinema music composer commented:

The thing is, the music and everything in Kerala is very new. That's the thing about Tamilnad, it has a very big history. We don't have that kind of history. So everything is relatively new. So we -- even the language is half Sanskrit, half Tamil. The music is also like that -- half Hindi, half Tamil. There is no Malayāḷam music actually; it's hybrid stuff, coming from here and there.

What this musician says here does not contradict the widespread notion described earlier in the dissertation that the *lālitasan̄gītam* developed in the 1950s and 1960s was not felt to be a uniquely Malayāḷam music, but rather emphasizes the effect of the two strongest influences upon the music, not only at that time, but continuing into the present.

Western music is a presence on cable television, but does not seem to have a strong public presence; trends in Hindi and Tamil film music are really what drive Malayāḷam music, and the popular *gānamēḷa* performances described in Chapter Three consist only of Malayāḷam, Hindi, and Tamil film songs. Nonetheless, while listeners are aware of foreign influence on Malayāḷam songs, the source of that influence is ambiguously understood: I have heard certain musical elements such as electronic percussion -- whether occurring in devotional songs, cinema songs, or the music of the Syro-Malabar *qurbāna* -- be described variously as 'Western', Hindi, or Tamil, seemingly arbitrarily. This ambiguity underlines the contemporary reality that spheres of influence are multiple and overlapping.

Chapters Three and Four both took up the role of mass-mediated forms and their accompanying technologies in live music performances conducted as part of religious festivals (Chapter Three) and rituals (Chapter Four), and show that regardless of whether musical forms or styles stem from foreign influence or

local innovation, they are put to locally-specific purposes. Cultural programs staged at temple festivals, including the live performance of cinema songs by orchestras, were shown to be indexical and performative of the changing emplacement of temples and their festivals with relation to the communities that support them. These performances index the passing of high-caste control over temple arts, and participate in redefining the semiotic relationships between the space of the temple and Kerala public culture at large.

The study of liturgical music in the Syro-Malabar Church similarly highlighted the changing relationship between a religious space and a surrounding culture where the pervasive influence of mass-mediated forms is increasingly felt. More than the other chapters, Chapter Four was specifically concerned with the role of music in helping to construct the social identity of a particular group. The Second Vatican Council acknowledged the value of the diversity of the world's cultures, and urged churches worldwide were to celebrate their Christianity through locally meaningful forms, according to a concept of inculturation. Because of the Syro-Malabar Church's multiple cultural roots, inculturation was not a straightforward proposition. As a result, the liturgical music of the Syro-Malabar Church is continually negotiated according to possible semiotic networks consisting of many cultural reference points, in a process that still continues.

As Kerala culture continues to change, it will no doubt do so with reference to the tensions between, on the one hand, participating in an ever-increasingly internationalized world,

and on the other, the need to preserve and promote a sense of cultural distinctiveness. Whatever the future shape of Kerala society, investigating cultural performances, such as those detailed in this dissertation, will provide a unique insight into such tensions and emergent strategies for resolving them.

GLOSSARY

<i>ākāśa</i>	aether; space. Ch. 2, p. 58.
<i>ampù perunṇāl</i>	Feast of St. Sebastian, involving the procession of St. Sebastian's arrow [<i>ampù</i>]. Ch. 2, p. 84.
<i>aṣṭapadi</i>	literally 'eight lines', a genre of <i>sōpānasaṅgītam</i> sung by Mārārs.
<i>aṭipoli</i>	slang term referring to cinema songs containing heavy or fast rhythms. Ch. 3, p. 144.
bandset	brass band consisting of trumpets, clarinets, euphonium, and drums. The repertoire of Kerala brass bands consists almost exclusively of arrangements of cinema songs, which are played at top volume and maximum energy. Ch. 3, p. 150; <u>Track 7</u> on the CD.
<i>bhajana</i>	devotional songs, sometimes based on <i>mantras</i> , generally sung in groups.
<i>bhakti</i>	'devotion'.
<i>bhaktigānam</i>	'devotional songs'.
<i>cākyār kūttū</i>	theatrical monologue associated with the <i>cākyār jāti</i> , accompanied by <i>mizhāvū</i> . Ch. 3, p. 128.
<i>ceṇṭa</i>	double-headed cylindrical drum, featured in <i>ceṇṭa mēlam</i> and <i>tāyampaka</i> , among other forms (see Groesbeck 1995 for a thorough study). Ch. 3, p. 126; <u>Track 8</u> on CD.
<i>ceṇṭa mēlam</i>	genre of temple music, including approximately 15 players playing the left head of the <i>ceṇṭa</i> , 30 players keeping <i>tāla</i> on the right head of the <i>ceṇṭa</i> , 30 <i>ilattālam</i> , 15 <i>kompū</i> , and 15 <i>kurum kuzhal</i> ; there will be more or fewer depending on the size of the temple or festival (Groesbeck 1995:180).
cinematic dance	performance of dance sequences from films.

<i>dīpārādhana</i>	'worship with lamps', Hindu temple ritual performed in the evening.
drum pad	see 'rhythm pad'.
<i>gamaka</i>	'ornament' in Karnātak music.
<i>gānamēḷa</i>	literally 'gathering or festival of songs', and is not actually genre-specific; thus <i>bhakti gānamēḷa</i> refers to the performance of <i>bhakti gānañṇaḷ</i> , or devotional songs. When used by itself, however, <i>gānamēḷa</i> refers to the performance of cinema songs. Ch. 3, pp. 143-168.
<i>ilattālam</i>	pairs of thick bell-metal cymbals about 6 inches in diameter, used to provide <i>tālam</i> in most drumming ensembles.
<i>iṭaykka</i>	a small hourglass-shaped tension drum which is played with a curved stick. The pitch of the drum is varied by squeezing the strings connecting the two heads with one hand, while beating the drum with the other. This ability to use pitch makes the <i>iṭaykka</i> a very expressive instrument.
<i>illam</i>	Nampūtiri Brāhman house-and-land unit; also called <i>mana</i> (cf. Moore 1985).
<i>jāti</i>	'genus', often mistranslated as 'caste' (cf. Marriott 2002).
jazz	term used in Malayāḷam and English to refer to a standard rock drumset.
<i>kalāparipāṭi</i>	cultural programs
<i>kathakaḷi</i>	'story-play', a theatrical artform specific to Kerala (see Zarrilli 2000; Jones 1983; Jones and Jones 1970).
<i>katinaveṭi</i>	popgun used as an offering in Hindu temples; from <i>katina</i> 'a thick iron tube usually filled with gun powder, a kind of salute gun'; <i>veṭi</i> 'firing, sound of firing, shooting, shot' (Warrier et al. 2000).
<i>kāvaṭi</i> dancing	a form of penance or vow fulfillment generally associated with trance states and accompanied by fast and loud drumming,
<i>kēraḷīyata</i>	'the quality which shows the Kerala Culture and tradition' (Warrier et al. 2000).
<i>kompū</i>	'horn'. Ch. 2, pp. 73-79.

KPAC	Kerala People's Arts Club. Ch. 1, pp. 24-26.
<i>kṣētrakalā</i>	'temple arts'
<i>kūṭiyāṭṭam</i>	Sanskrit theater tradition contiguous with the <i>Nāṭyaśāstra</i> , dating back to the 7 th -9 th centuries CE, performed by men and women, accompanied by the <i>mizhāvū</i> drum (cf. Rajagopalan 1997, 2000).
<i>kūttampalam</i>	a theater built inside a temple compound specifically for <i>kūṭiyāṭṭam</i> . Very few exist; one is in Thrissur's Śrī Vatakkunāthan Temple.
<i>kuzhaḷ</i> , or <i>kurum kuzhaḷ</i>	a simple double-reed instrument, capable of crudely approximating <i>śrutis</i> but mainly functioning to add loudness to ensembles such as <i>ceṇṭa mēlam</i> .
<i>lālitasaṅgītam</i>	'light music', genre of Malayāḷam songs created within the context of KPAC dramas.
<i>mana</i>	Nampūtiri Brāhman house-and-land unit; also called <i>illam</i> (cf. Moore 1983).
<i>mandalam</i>	period when men undertake the pilgrimage to Ayyappan's temple at Sabari Mala.
<i>mantra</i>	"word, formula verse (especially from scriptures) or sound believed to have magical, religious or spiritual power when recited, muttered, sung or meditated upon" (Coward and Goa 1991:81).
<i>mēlam</i>	"'assembly, combination, blending'; 1) that which is performed by musical instruments, especially in <i>kathakaLi</i> (<i>kathakaLi mēlam</i> = <i>kathakaLi</i> drumming) or in a temple festival. 2) an abbreviation of <i>ceṇṭa mēlam</i> . 3) An aesthetic, according to which the drummer should leave little silence in a certain section; he should fill up the space with a variety of sounds" (Groesbeck 1995:838).
MIDI	Musical Instrument Digital Interface; "a standard interface and digital code for transmitting control and timing information in real time between synthesizers, sequencers, computers, drum machines, etc." (Rossing 1990:591). Sequencing information can be programmed and saved as a 'MIDI file', which can then be played back on any device capable of reading a MIDI file.
mimicry	a topical comedy routine whose content is derived from the mass media, and whose origins

	are associated with Kalābhavan's 'Mimics Parade' troupe.
<i>mṛdaṅgam</i>	double-headed, barrel-shaped drum, which is the main percussion instrument in Karnātak music.
<i>nāda brahman</i>	the notion in Sanskrit philosophy that the ground of all Being [<i>brahman</i>] is a primordial sound [<i>nāda</i>] (cf. Beck 1993).
<i>nāgasvaram</i>	large double-reed instrument, commonly used in South Indian temple ritual music; also called <i>nādasvaram</i> .
<i>nāḷukeṭṭu</i>	type of Nāyar house, 'a space with four built-up sides' (Moore 1983:203; see also Moore 1990).
<i>nāṭanpāṭṭu</i>	folk song styles.
<i>nātakam</i>	'drama', plays acted out on a stage, related to a similar genre in the West (see V.M. Ramachandran 1999).
<i>Nāṭyaśāstra</i>	'treatise on drama', probably compiled in the first two centuries CE, and attributed to Bharata. "The work is a comprehensive guide to all aspects of early Indian theater, including the mythical origin of drama, theater design and construction, dedication rituals, playwriting, acting, declamation, dancing, music, poetry, casting, costume, makeup, and emotion. Six (or in some editions, seven) chapters on music provide detailed information on the theater orchestra and its various instruments, the system of pitch, rhythm and meter, musical form, songs, singing, and drumming" (Rowell 1998:23-24).
<i>orchestra</i>	In Malayālam, the English word 'orchestra' has come to refer specifically to an ensemble that performs cinema songs. The instrumentation of a contemporary orchestra typically includes digital keyboard, electric guitar, electric bass, one or more violins, flute, and percussion, including <i>tabala</i> , 'triple-drum', electronic drum pad, and sometimes congas.
<i>ōṭṭan tuḷḷal</i>	comedic and satirical mono-drama. Ch. 2, p. 132; <u>Track 9</u> .
<i>pañcavādyam</i>	literally 'five instruments'; Kerala percussion ensemble of varying size consisting of <i>timila</i> , <i>maddalam</i> , <i>iṭaykka</i> , <i>kompū</i> , and <i>ilattālam</i> .
<i>pañcāyattū</i>	village council.

<i>pāṭṭu</i>	'song'.
<i>pēriya mēḷam</i>	the pan-South Indian Hindu temple ensemble which consists usually of <i>nāgasvaram</i> (double-reed instrument, similar to oboe, but larger and louder) and <i>takil</i> (double-headed drum, struck with stick and finger caps; called <i>tāvil</i> in Tamil). It is outdoor music, and these instruments maximize high volume. Variations of the ensemble can be found from state to state; in Karnataka, for example, the ensemble commonly includes the alto saxophone.
<i>perumai</i>	'bigness', 'greatness' (Mines 1995:242-300).
playback singer	In Indian films, the actors generally do not sing their own songs. Instead, they mouth the words while the voice is filled in by a professional singer who is known as a 'playback singer'
<i>prakāram</i>	outer temple walls.
<i>pūja</i>	worship.
<i>pūram</i>	festival held at the time of the <i>pūram nakṣatram</i> ; the most famous is Thrissur <i>pūram</i> , held at Śrī Vaṭakkunāthan Temple in April-May.
<i>qurbāna</i>	Syriac for 'offering', commonly referred to in English as the Celebration of the Eucharist or as 'mass'; central ritual of the Syro-Malabar Catholic Church.
<i>rāgam</i>	"In Karnatak music, the term <i>rāga</i> encompasses the concepts of scale, mode, tonal system, melodic motifs and themes, microtones, ornaments, and improvisation within a three-octave range" (Kassebaum 1998:89).
rhythm pad	also 'drum pad'; an electronic instrument with a surface divided into several regions. Each region is assignable to a variety of sampled or synthesized percussive sounds, such as cymbals, snare drums, toms, purely electronic sounds, and so on, and the pad is played with drumsticks as if it were a drum set. It makes no sound on its own but must be connected to an amplifier and speakers.
<i>śāstriyasaṅgītam</i>	literally 'scientific music', generally translated as 'classical music'; refers to the Karnatak music tradition.

<i>śinkāri mēḷam</i>	<i>Śinkāri mēḷam</i> is a recent innovation for an ensemble of <i>ceṇṭas</i> and <i>ilatāḷam</i> which involves cyclically increasing and decreasing tempos, and choreographed movements by the drummers. It is not performed by <i>Mārārs</i> , the traditional Hindu drumming <i>jāti</i> , and <i>Mārārs</i> I knew spoke disparagingly of this genre.
<i>sōpānasangītam</i>	ritual music performed by the <i>Mārār</i> temple musician caste at the stone steps [<i>soopānam</i>] leading up to the central shrine. It is based on <i>rāgams</i> , most of which are identical to <i>Karnātak rāgams</i> and others specific to Kerala, and encompasses the vocal genres of <i>tyāṇi</i> [from the Sanskrit <i>dhyāna</i> , 'meditation'], <i>aṣṭapadi</i> ['eight lines'], and <i>kīrttanam</i> [devotional songs, similar in form to the genre of Hindu group singing known as <i>kīrtan</i>] (Groesbeck 1995:183-188). See also Omcherry (1999).
<i>śrīkōvil</i>	central shrine of a Hindu temple.
<i>śruti</i>	pitch.
<i>suṣiravādyam</i>	wind instrument.
<i>tabala</i> [<i>tablā</i>]	pair of drums which are the primary percussion instrument in <i>Hindustānī</i> (North Indian) classical music; also common in light music and devotional music in the South.
<i>takil</i>	also known as <i>tāvil</i> ; a double-headed drum played with a stick in one hand and finger-caps on the other, accompanies the <i>nāgasvaram</i> in the <i>periyamēḷam</i> ensemble.
<i>tāli</i>	string or chain tied around the neck of the bride by the groom at weddings (both Christian and Hindu).
<i>taṛavāṭṭu</i>	<i>Nāyar</i> 'house and land unit' (Moore 1983; see also Moore 1990)
<i>tāyampaka</i>	composition performed by a solo <i>ceṇṭa</i> (or as a duet between two <i>ceṇṭas</i> in double <i>tāyampaka</i> [<i>iraṭṭu tāyampaka</i>]), with other <i>ceṇṭas</i> and <i>ilattāḷams</i> keeping <i>tāla</i> (see Groesbeck 1995).
<i>timila</i>	long hourglass-shaped drum played with the palms of the hands; used in <i>pañcavādyam</i> .
<i>tīṇṭal</i>	distance pollution; untouchability. Ch. 2, pp. 60-64.
<i>vāṅkū viḷi</i>	Muslim call to prayer.

varṇṇa	Sanskrit 'varṇa'; 'light' or 'color'; refers to the four human types of <i>brāhman</i> ['priest'], <i>kṣatriya</i> ['protector'], <i>vaiśya</i> ['householder'], and <i>śūdra</i> ['servant'] (Marriott 2003). Outside of this system are the <i>avarṇṇa</i> groups, previously known as 'untouchables'. Categories of <i>jāti</i> are superimposed over the four basic <i>varṇṇa</i> categories.
veṭikkeṭṭu	fireworks.
veṭivazhipāṭu	the firing of a popgun as an offering to a Hindu deity.
vīṇa	plucked string instrument without resonant strings, used in Karnātak music.

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